

God's Love Plan in Jesus and the Church: 40 Days in the Old Testament

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For God's beloved church, which He bought with the blood of His Own.
Acts 20:28

Introduction

'And the angel who talked with me came again and woke me, like a man who is awakened out of his sleep. And he said to me, "What do you see?" I said, "I see, and behold, a lampstand all of gold, with a bowl on the top of it, and seven lamps on it, with seven lips on each of the lamps that are on the top of it. And there are two olive trees by it, one on the right of the bowl and the other on its left." ...I answered and said to him, "What are these two branches of the olive trees, which are beside the two golden pipes from which the golden oil is poured out?" He said to me, "Do you not know what these are?" I said, "No, my lord." Then he said, "These are the two anointed ones who stand by the Lord of the whole earth."

Zechariah 4:1-3,12-14

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/ZEC.4.1-3,12-14>

The Bible records the history of God's love plan for mankind through the time of the first apostles of Jesus Christ. This plan continues to unfold. Many thousands of years ago, God created men and women in His image and likeness, and He said they were good. He made them very much like Himself, having their own will, and with their will they doubted His best intent for them, disobeyed, and died spiritually, being separated from relationship with Him.

First published via posts at www.teams.church from October 13, 2021 through February 6th, 2022, this book contains 40 readings from the Old Testament that focus on who God is, Father, Son and Holy Spirit, and the unfolding of His love plan for His people. God pursues an intimate relationship with all, seeking to do good to them and bless them, bringing freedom and life, if they will trust Him in faith. This started with Adam and Eve, God with them; continued through Abraham, Israel, and Judah; and continues still through Jesus' church. With Abraham, the relationship restarted as God to man. In the time of Moses, the relationship became God with man and with woman. Through Jesus, it became God in man and woman.

The 2500 year old passage above from the vision of the young Zechariah is one beautiful picture of God's love plan for His church. In the vision, the anointed ones who stood by the Lord of the whole earth were Jesus Christ and the Holy Spirit.

The Holy Spirit is the Helper, one who was within the man Jesus to connect Him to the Father and to enable His ministry of the fullness of the Kingdom of God. They were represented as olive trees, each associated with the Almighty God. They poured out golden oil through golden pipes into a bowl on top of a golden lampstand, not unlike one that might be found in the holy place of the tabernacle. This bowl on the lampstand fed seven lamps through lips.

In the most holy place, there was no natural light. God Himself was the light. And so the Old Testament describes the continuous abiding presence of God with men and women, His lamps. It also describes the light to come through Jesus Christ and the ministry of the Holy Spirit among men and women in His church.

God's purpose now is for His people, His bride (Matthew 25:1-10), to burn brightly and continually (Matthew 5:14-16) as oil lamps that are fed by loving relationship with God through Jesus Christ and the Holy Spirit. God has taken what is His and made it available to His church through the abiding presence of Jesus and the Holy Spirit. In Christ, we are directly connected to God!

This book describes God's love plan in Jesus and the church in light of the lives of selected people from Old Testament times. They are part of the cloud of God's witnesses. It wraps up with a conclusion, and, for anyone interested, an account of my story in view of their stories. For further study, this revised version also contains selected Hebrew and Greek words for lookup.¹

¹ These words are referenced according to the numbers for Strong's Concordance, allowing lookup for how the words are elsewhere used in the Bible. For Hebrew words, a useful reference to help understanding is the Brown-Driver-Briggs Hebrew and English Lexicon (1906). For Greek words, a useful reference to aid understanding is Joseph Henry Thayer's Greek-English Lexicon of the New Testament (1886). Some Bible apps now have these references embedded, such as the Blue Letter Bible and the Bible KJV Strong's Concordance (Karios). Of these options, I prefer to use the latter.

Day 1: In God's image, after His likeness

'Then God said, "Let us make man in our image, after our likeness. And let them have dominion over the fish of the sea and over the birds of the heavens and over the livestock and over all the earth and over every creeping thing that creeps on the earth." '

Genesis 1:26

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/GEN.1.26>

What a statement and what good news—mankind made in the image and likeness of God, the glory of God's amazing work, created for dominion over the rest of creation.

Do we see ourselves this way? Do you see everyone else this way? *Everyone?*

How do we understand God's image? What is His likeness?

God can choose. He creates.

God is compassionate, putting love into action. He is by nature generous in every way.

God delights to show mercy. He's forgiving.

God loves justice. He has a heart for the least of these. He is not a respecter of persons.

The Spirit of God as shown in Jesus Christ is Life. Having dominion over everything in heaven and on earth, God makes things on earth right as they are in heaven. He is righteous.

Do you see yourself made in the image of God? In God's likeness? The way you see yourself and what you believe about yourself has a huge impact.

God delights in you as the glory of His creation.

Do you see others this way? Do you see everyone this way? Do you see them the way God sees them? God sees everyone in view of what redemption has made possible for them.

He made us able to choose... able to create.

We can choose to put love into action— to be compassionate.

We can choose to be generous, not just with our money, but in any way we discover that we may give.

We can choose to show mercy, to always forgive.

We can choose to do justly. We can love and care for the least of these, choosing to see them the way we know God sees them.

We can choose to join God in giving life and in making wrong things right.

Day 2: God created by His word

Rather than reflecting on Genesis 1-2, the Apostle Paul's writing about it is considered:

"For what can be known about God is plain to them, because God has shown it to them. For his invisible attributes, namely, his eternal power and divine nature, have been clearly perceived, ever since the creation of the world, in the things that have been made. So they are without excuse."

Romans 1:19-20 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/rom.1.19-20.ESV>

Genesis 1-2 gives the account of creation in the Bible. There is much debate about it, and I would argue that Christians should think about creation— "Each one should be fully convinced in his own mind" (Romans 14:5)— but need not agree about the details of it, as the details of how God created life are not an essential of the Christian faith on which all must agree.

I would suggest the following: God has revealed truth both through nature and through Scripture, and no one should think they have a completely right understanding about either one— not scientists in regards to fully understanding truth from nature, nor Christians in regards to fully understanding truth from the Bible.

Humility is needed on all sides, as we all take ourselves and our ability to fully understand all truth too seriously. We are all wrong about certain things.

Personally, I am most intrigued by Hugh Ross' view of a testable creation model that includes science and Scripture as sources of truth (as discussed in *More Than a Theory: Revealing a Testable Model for Creation*), allowing for the possibility that he could change his theory in the future based on new discoveries. Is he right? Certainly not fully. May he be far off? Quite possibly.

But it makes a lot of sense that God speaks both through Scripture and through nature, another source of God's revelation (Romans 1:19-20), and one should expect these two sources of truth to make sense together. We have nothing to fear from

the discoveries of science, as they should teach us more about the creation when rightly interpreted.

"So then let us pursue what makes for peace and for mutual upbuilding" (Romans 14:19). It is more important that the body of Christ remains unified (see also John 17:21-23, Ephesians 4:2-6,13-16,32) than that we all agree about how God did the creating. The details not yet clear to us are God's business.

This doesn't change the fact that God spoke this world and all life into existence, and He created mankind for a special relationship with Himself.

We have come to know enough. What will we do with what we know?

Day 3: The choices of Abraham

God made a promise to Abraham to give him a son:

'And behold, the word of the Lord came to him: "This man shall not be your heir; your very own son shall be your heir." And he brought him outside and said, "Look toward heaven, and number the stars, if you are able to number them." Then he said to him, "So shall your offspring be." And he believed the Lord, and he counted it to him as righteousness.'

Genesis 15:4-6 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/gen.15.4-6.ESV>

The account of the sacrifice of Issac, the son God had given Abraham, is given in Genesis 22. After Abraham chose to obey God, God spoke:

'... "By myself I have sworn, declares the Lord, because you have done this and have not withheld your son, your only son, I will surely bless you, and I will surely multiply your offspring as the stars of heaven and as the sand that is on the seashore. And your offspring shall possess the gate of his enemies, and in your offspring shall all the nations of the earth be blessed, because you have obeyed my voice."

Genesis 22:16-18 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/gen.22.16-18.ESV>

Abraham was a man chosen by God based on his character, showing us what it is that pleases God.

It was Abraham's faith. He chose to believe God at His word and act on it.

His faith was counted by God to him as righteousness. He was made right with God by believing God's word and acting on it, even as his father Adam had not chosen to do.

This gave God the legal right to carry out His will for mankind: to bless Abraham and his descendants, through any legal means, and to cause them to possess the gate of their enemies. (There is clearly a legal system in the design of God wherein He chose to give free will to His creation, e.g., see Colossians 2:13-15, Matthew 16:18.)

Being made righteous (tsaddīyq, H6662), they would receive the promises of God, having victory over the evil that had brought death upon mankind when Adam and Eve chose death over life.

This kind of faith in God which Abraham had was and still is the pathway back to life (zōē, G2222) and wholeness (shâlôm, H7965)— in all of their fullness and abundance, in relationship with the God who made mankind in His image and likeness.

It's the faith in the Father God that Jesus modeled, taught, and retaught to His disciples— Jesus, the One from God who brought fulfillment to God's promise to Abraham. Jesus brought the opportunity to be made righteous not only to Abraham's direct descendants, but to all nations.

God, Jehovah Jireh (yehôvâh yir'eh, H3070, Genesis 22:14), provided a way. That way is faith in who God is and that His will for us is good. God is not a respecter of persons; He has always looked for faith.

Now in the times of the New Testament, that only way is faith in the Son of God, Jesus Christ (John 14:6, Acts 4:12).

Mankind's disobedience changed our relationship with God, but let's not imagine that our Father desires to withhold any good thing from us, His children, created in His image and likeness as His glory.

God's will is always to do good, to make things right for His children (Matthew 6:10, Acts 10:38, 1 John 3:8).

Let's not wonder what God's (general) will is. His nature has been made clear enough to us, and God doesn't change (Numbers 23:19, Hebrews 13:8, James 1:17).

What will we choose to think about God? About His will?

What will we choose? God allowed us to choose.

There are *so many choices*.

Let's choose God. Let's believe God, putting our confidence in Him, His word, and His will to do good in cooperation with His church.

By way of Jesus' resurrection and His commission of His disciples with His own authority through the baptism of God's Spirit (Mark 16, Acts 2), the living Jesus made His church to be His body, the hope of the world.

The members of the church are the "offspring [who] shall possess the gate of [God's] enemies, and in [Abraham's] offspring shall all the nations of the earth be blessed."

This was quite a promise, a promise of redemption, that God made to Abraham. God always keeps His promises.

God allows anyone to choose to be part of this promise. His good news is for anyone who has faith in Him and His word.

Day 4: God of freedom

"When Pharaoh drew near, the people of Israel lifted up their eyes, and behold, the Egyptians were marching after them, and they feared greatly. And the people of Israel cried out to the Lord. They said to Moses, "Is it because there are no graves in Egypt that you have taken us away to die in the wilderness? What have you done to us in bringing us out of Egypt? Is not this what we said to you in Egypt: 'Leave us alone that we may serve the Egyptians'? For it would have been better for us to serve the Egyptians than to die in the wilderness." And Moses said to the people, "Fear not, stand firm, and see the salvation of the Lord, which he will work for you today. For the Egyptians whom you see today, you shall never see again. The Lord will fight for you, and you have only to be silent." The Lord said to Moses, "Why do you cry to me? Tell the people of Israel to go forward. Lift up your staff, and stretch out your hand over the sea and divide it, that the people of Israel may go through the sea on dry ground. And I will harden the hearts of the Egyptians so that they shall go in after them, and I will get glory over Pharaoh and all his host, his chariots, and his horsemen. And the Egyptians shall know that I am the Lord, when I have gotten glory over Pharaoh, his chariots, and his horsemen." Then the angel of God who was going before the host of Israel moved and went behind them, and the pillar of cloud moved from before them and stood behind them, coming between the host of Egypt and the host of Israel. And there was the cloud and the darkness. And it lit up the night without one coming near the other all night. Then Moses stretched out his hand over the sea, and the Lord drove the sea back by a strong east wind all night and made the sea dry land, and the waters were divided."

Exodus 14:10-21 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/exo.14.10-21.ESV>

Although Moses initially had no faith in himself and his ability to lead, he came to have great faith in God. Here in the face of frightened people who thought God had led them all this way just to face death in the wilderness, Moses instructed his people not to fear, even as Jesus often did to his disciples. Moses told the Israelites to stand firm, confident they would see the salvation (yeshû'âh, H3444) of the Lord, just as they had when they were freed from slavery in Egypt.

Moses expected God to fight for them, but this wasn't God's way: "Why do you cry to me?" Instead, God wanted Moses to be His channel, His agent, to lead His people. God wanted Moses to take action to access the power of God to bring the Israelites God's salvation— all through his faith. Through faith, Moses was to instruct the people to go forward, expecting God to make a way for them, for this was God's will—to bring them freedom, delivering them from their oppression. Moses was to lift his staff and stretch forth his hand, expecting the sea to be divided.

Moses acted upon God's word, and God confirmed His word with the miraculous. Not only did nature become obedient to part the waters, showing God's dominion, but the pillar of cloud went behind the people to protect them from the army, and God provided illumination. God redeemed His people through Moses' faith and his union with God.

Moses immediately praised God for what He did:

'Then Moses and the people of Israel sang this song to the Lord , saying, "I will sing to the Lord , for he has triumphed gloriously; the horse and his rider he has thrown into the sea. The Lord is my strength and my song, and he has become my salvation; this is my God, and I will praise him, my father's God, and I will exalt him..." "Who is like you, O Lord , among the gods? Who is like you, majestic in holiness, awesome in glorious deeds, doing wonders? You stretched out your right hand; the earth swallowed them. '

Exodus 15:1-2,11-12

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/EXO.15.1-2,11-12>

In Moses stretching out his hand, the Spirit of God had stretched out His right hand, and glorious triumph followed for God's people. The Lord was Moses' strength, awesome in power. God had become their salvation (yeshû'âh, H3444).

Moses praised God for the wonders (pele', H6382) He had just done. Thanks and praise is always supposed to be the attitude of believers. As Jesus brought Lazarus back to life, He showed a model of thanking God His Father for hearing Him even before the miraculous action of God had been seen, brought about by Jesus' own action (John 11:41-44). Jesus also thanked God before He multiplied

food for the masses in the hands of His disciples, showing Himself as the Lord who provides (John 6:11).

Moses and Jesus had the Spirit of God. In God, the unseen spiritual gives birth to that which is seen in the physical world; freedom and life come with it by the very nature of God. This is God's way.

Do you need God to set you free? Do you want to join God in bringing freedom to others?

Now in the times of the New Testament, brought about by the sacrifice of Jesus Christ, complete freedom is part of a complete salvation and victory over evil. Jesus replaced mankind's death sentence brought about by wrong choice with the ability to freely choose abundant Life (John 10:10).

Our God is a God who delights to bring freedom to those made in His image, His glory, and to use those made in His likeness in the process. This is His will.

Day 5: Jehovah Rophi

"Then Moses made Israel set out from the Red Sea, and they went into the wilderness of Shur. They went three days in the wilderness and found no water. When they came to Marah, they could not drink the water of Marah because it was bitter; therefore it was named Marah. And the people grumbled against Moses, saying, "What shall we drink?" And he cried to the Lord, and the Lord showed him a log, and he threw it into the water, and the water became sweet. There the Lord made for them a statute and a rule, and there he tested them, saying, "If you will diligently listen to the voice of the Lord your God, and do that which is right in his eyes, and give ear to his commandments and keep all his statutes, I will put none of the diseases on you that I put on the Egyptians, for I am the Lord, your healer." Then they came to Elim, where there were twelve springs of water and seventy palm trees, and they encamped there by the water."

Exodus 15:22-27 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/exo.15.22-27.ESV>

Immediately after heading into the wilderness, the faith of Israel was tested again, as they could find no water. Then the water they found was not drinkable.

Feeling desperate because of the people's response to hardship, Moses cried out (tsô'âq, H6817) to the Lord, just as he had when he needed deliverance from the Egyptian army at the Red Sea (see Day 4). God had answered Moses, "Why do you cry out to me?"

As when they were trapped by the Egyptians at the Red Sea, God, communicating through his Spirit, wanted Moses to take some action in faith. This time God showed Moses a log to use to take care of the need.

God can create from anything, as Jesus taught His disciples. God created more bread and fish from just a little, multiplying it (Luke 9:10-17). Sometimes Jesus used spit or spit and mud in His creative miracles (Mark 7:33, Mark 8:23, John 9:6).

Through Moses' action, God transformed a log into a substance that made the water both potable and sweet to the taste for the Israelites to drink. Jehovah Jireh provided for Moses and Israel, just as He did for Abraham (Genesis 22:14)

To those who would do right, being obedient to the commandment of God, God introduced Himself as Jehovah Rapha (yehôvâh râphâ'), their healer (râphâ', H7495): "If you will diligently listen to the voice of the Lord your God, and do that which is right in his eyes, and give ear to his commandments and keep all his statutes, I will put none of the diseases on you that I put on the Egyptians, for I am the Lord, your healer."

God had protected Israel from the plague on the firstborn because they obeyed His commandment given before Passover:

'Your lamb shall be without blemish, a male a year old. You may take it from the sheep or from the goats, and you shall keep it until the fourteenth day of this month, when the whole assembly of the congregation of Israel shall kill their lambs at twilight. "Then they shall take some of the blood and put it on the two doorposts and the lintel of the houses in which they eat it... It is the Lord's Passover. For I will pass through the land of Egypt that night, and I will strike all the firstborn in the land of Egypt, both man and beast; and on all the gods of Egypt I will execute judgments: I am the Lord. The blood shall be a sign for you, on the houses where you are. And when I see the blood, I will pass over you, and no plague will befall you to destroy you, when I strike the land of Egypt. '

Exodus 12:5-13

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/EXO.12.5-13>

Israel was not without fault before God, but God allowed for the substitute of the blood of a lamb without blemish. Through this sacrifice, God's people were considered as righteous, and they were protected from the plague that killed even Pharaoh's firstborn son.

God redeemed Israel from disease on this occasion, and He promised to continue this if they would continue to be obedient. God would also prepare for even a greater redemption for more of God's children through the Messiah, Jesus Christ (see Isaiah 53), the Lamb of God (John 1:29).

While remaining sinless seems impossible in our own power— even Moses did wrong (see Deuteronomy 32:51-52)— in the current times of the New Testament, putting faith in Jesus Christ makes a believer righteous (dikaiosunē, G1343), or as sinless. A genuine faith in Jesus makes one right (yâshâr, H3477) before God (2 Corinthians 5:21). This is the position of every earnest follower of Jesus.

Steadfast faith opens up the channel of God to bless abundantly, even as He desires to do for all (John 3:16, 2 Peter 3:9).

At the end of today's passage (v. 27), God does provide blessing to His people: "Then they came to Elim, where there were twelve springs of water and seventy palm trees, and they encamped there by the water."

In difficult times and places, God wants His people to remember His provision, His goodness, His faithfulness, His steadfast love. They all flow from His divine nature.

The redemptive names of God, Jehovah Rapha included, convey what God wants to be to His people, His church. The fullness of redemption came two thousand years ago through the resurrected Jesus.

God is good, and His salvation (sōzō, G4982) is complete. It is God's will to make us whole (sōzō).

Day 6: The first three commandments

“Now therefore, if you will indeed obey my voice and keep my covenant, you shall be my treasured possession among all peoples, for all the earth is mine; and you shall be to me a kingdom of priests and a holy nation. These are the words that you shall speak to the people of Israel.”

Exodus 19:5-6

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/EXO.19.5-6>

A priest (kôhên, H3548) was one that had special access to God to communicate between God and mankind. Priests were servants of mankind that represented God. At the beginning, Adam and Eve already had better access than this. They had an intimate relationship with their Creator. To keep it as God desired it to be, they had to obey God's command, believing Him and His blessings for them to be good— not holding anything back. God loved them greatly and made them as His glory, just a little lower than God, a kingdom (mamlâkâh, H4467) of priests, His treasure (segûllâh, H5459).

We know they chose not to continue to believe God though, which changed everything for them.

Through Abraham and in Exodus, we see God made a way back toward the intended intimacy with His creation and toward the restoration of His channel of blessing for them.

God being righteous and having set up a legal system in His creation, He made a covenant (berîyth, H1285) that His people had to keep in faith. Part of God's covenant was as follows:

' And God spoke all these words, saying, "I am the Lord your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of slavery. You shall have no other gods before me. You shall not make for yourself a carved image, or any likeness of anything that is in heaven above, or that is in the earth beneath, or that is in the water under the earth. You shall not bow down to them or serve them, for I the Lord your God am a jealous God, visiting the iniquity of the fathers on the children to the third and the fourth generation of those who hate me, but showing

Exodus 20:1-11

Everyone worships because mankind has been made to worship; if we don't worship God, we will worship something else. We must choose the object or objects of our worship.

On a daily basis, what is the first thing on our thoughts? The last thing? What is it that we adore? Whom do we care about most? Whom are we living to please? What causes us fear? What do we prioritize in our spending? What's the focus of our time, attention, and energy? What makes us excited? What brings us joy? What brings us hope? These questions can help us identify what we care about most.

God does not want His people to love His gifts more than Him, the Giver, including any person made in God's likeness. Every good and perfect gift is from God (James 1:17).

God's people are the creation and the glory of God, and God wants their love. Loving Him is the best thing for the people of God too — by His design. He is life and freedom. Choices to not love God are choices leading toward death and increasing bondage, although it does not seem this way at the moment.

Jesus worshiped His father and taught His disciples to do the same. He said that loving God was the greatest commandment (Matthew 22:36-38).

"...You shall not take the name of the Lord your God in vain, for the Lord will not hold him guiltless who takes his name in vain..."

Transitioning to the second of the Ten Commandments, the names of God are wonderful, showing who He is and who He wants to be to His people. God's people are to use these names in love and worship of God, and in conversation with God. God commands His people not to take His name in vain. God is patient with people, wanting them to come to repentance, seeing in them what redemption has made possible for them, but He is no pushover.

In the New Testament, the use of the name of Jesus gives His followers access to His authority. For example, see Acts 3:6 where the Apostle Peter heals a lame man through use of the name of Jesus, who he calls the Author of Life (Acts 3:15). This

same name that refers to the One who has authority over all of heaven and earth (Matthew 28:18) should never be used in a curse. Jesus is the compassion, generosity, grace, and righteousness of God personified.

“...Remember the Sabbath day, to keep it holy....”

Referring to the third commandment, God told the Israelites to set apart time for God where they could rest, remembering their Creator: their Sabbath. God wanted His people to rest from their work and busyness and remember Him. In order to do this, they had to keep the day holy (qâdash, H6942), which is sometimes translated as sanctified or hallowed.

Constant busyness and distraction is not from God. God is characterized by peace, not distraction. In this world of ours, there are so many things that can take our attention from God and the ways of God; this is not from God. He does not distract us from His call for His people to love Him, love others, and go about doing His will.

Jesus called Himself the “Lord even of the Sabbath” (Mark 2:23-28), and Christians choose to keep the Sabbath in different ways. The Seventh Day Adventists are a denomination of Bible-believing Christians (i.e., those who believe the Bible *is* the word of God) who still keep it on the seventh day of the week, or Saturday. Many others choose to take Sunday as a day of rest. Still many others choose to seek God daily during a “quiet time.” “Each one should be fully convinced in his own mind” (Romans 14:5).

Whatever our practice, God wants to be first on our thoughts, the main subject of our attention. We are called to pray without ceasing (1 Thessalonians 5:17). He is to be daily the subject of our worship, praise and thanks (1 Thessalonians 5:16-18). We are to be grateful for every good thing in our lives, as God is the source of all good. He is the source of everything we need and everything we should want, i.e., anything that is good for us and anything that brings glory to God.

In the current dispensation of the Holy Spirit (which began in Acts 2), Christ dwells in us (Colossians 1:27), so He is our Sabbath, our rest, even in our work for Him

(Matthew 11:28-30). For those who abide in Him, the indwelling Spirit brings rest, peace (Romans 14:17), and strength (Philippians 4:13).

God has created His people for a close relationship with Him, now brought near as a kingdom of priests through faith in Jesus Christ as Savior and Lord (Revelation 1:6). God loves us more than we can know, and we are to love Him. We are also to serve others, just as Christ demonstrated service.

We are created for and by a loving God, a God who defines love (agapē, G26). We are created to love.

Day 7: The last seven commandments

"Honor your father and your mother, that your days may be long in the land that the Lord your God is giving you. You shall not murder. You shall not commit adultery. You shall not steal. You shall not bear false witness against your neighbor. You shall not covet your neighbor's house; you shall not covet your neighbor's wife, or his male servant, or his female servant, or his ox, or his donkey, or anything that is your neighbor's."

Exodus 20:12-17

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/EXO.20.12-17>

The God who designed His people to love Him also commanded them to love and serve all others, who, according to Genesis 1:26, are made in His image (tselem, H6754) and likeness (demûth, H1823).

God also created the parent-child relationship as a likeness of His relationship with His children. Both parent and child are made in God's image, and the parents are to be honored (kâbad, H3513). The parents take care of children when they are young, and children are to ensure parents are cared for when they are old enough to give care.

Jesus clearly honored His mother during His ministry. He also scorned the tradition of men in His time that justified them not giving honor to their parents: ' "You leave the commandment of God and hold to the tradition of men." And he said to them, "You have a fine way of rejecting the commandment of God in order to establish your tradition! For Moses said, 'Honor your father and your mother'; and, 'Whoever reviles father or mother must surely die.' But you say, 'If a man tells his father or his mother, "Whatever you would have gained from me is Corban"' (that is, given to God) — then you no longer permit him to do anything for his father or mother, thus making void the word of God by your tradition that you have handed down. And many such things you do." '

Mark 7:8-13

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/MRK.7.8-13>

"...You shall not murder..."

We are not to commit murder because humans are made in God's image and likeness, giving them value close to that of God ('elôhîym, H430, Psalm 8:5, Hebrews 2:7). Satan is a murderer (John 8:44), and so we are instead to be like God, giving life (châyâh, H2421; zôopoieō, G2227) in every way that we have been enabled to do so, not taking it.

Speaking first of murder, Jesus said further that we are not even to treat others with contempt with words we speak to them (Matthew 5:21-22). Hate or contempt of one's fellow man does not permit one to also love God, the subject of the first three commandments, according to the Apostle John:

"If anyone says, "I love God," and hates his brother, he is a liar; for he who does not love his brother whom he has seen cannot love God whom he has not seen. And this commandment we have from him: whoever loves God must also love his brother."

1 John 4:20-21 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/1jn.4.20-21.ESV>

"...You shall not commit adultery..."

God's people are not to commit adultery. To do so is to make another person an object of lust, to lack satisfaction in God and His good gifts that come according to His plan and His ways. Jesus said to not even look at another person made in God's image with lust:

' "You have heard that it was said, 'You shall not commit adultery.' But I say to you that everyone who looks at a woman with lustful intent has already committed adultery with her in his heart." '

Matthew 5:27-28

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/MAT.5.27-28>

Jesus spoke very seriously about getting rid of sin in one's life, as it leads toward bondage, dissatisfaction, and death rather than the life, freedom, and peace Jesus came to give. Jesus was righteous, victorious over all sin, despite having the common temptations of mankind. He was the model of One who knew God's word, believed it to be true, and did what was right, despising evil.

An attitude of love toward others starts in one's beliefs about who they are and who they could be, image bearers of God with potential to become like God in

many ways. Jesus loves everyone. Having the love of Jesus starts with our thoughts about others.

Has the indwelling Holy Spirit transformed the way you think about others? (Romans 12:1-2, Ephesians 4:22-23, Colossians 3:9-10).

“...You shall not steal. You shall not bear false witness against your neighbor...”

According to the next two commandments, God’s people are not to steal nor give false testimony. We are to give, which is better than receiving, Jesus said (Acts 20:35). Life is not about getting good things for ourselves; we know that things don’t satisfy beyond some brief moments, and anyway God is the source of every good thing. God is generous in every way, and so ought we to be:

“He who supplies seed to the sower and bread for food will supply and multiply your seed for sowing and increase the harvest of your righteousness. You will be enriched in every way to be generous in every way, which through us will produce thanksgiving to God.”

2 Corinthians 9:10-11

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/2CO.9.10-11>

One’s moral choices, stealing and lying included, lead one of two possible ways. It is Satan who is a thief (John 10:10) and a liar (John 8:44). Isn’t it better then to always choose honesty and truth over dishonesty and lies? In this too, one chooses to enter through either the narrow gate, acting in obedience out of love in faith; or through the wide gate and road that leads toward destruction:

“So whatever you wish that others would do to you, do also to them, for this is the Law and the Prophets. Enter by the narrow gate. For the gate is wide and the way is easy that leads to destruction, and those who enter by it are many. For the gate is narrow and the way is hard that leads to life, and those who find it are few.”

Matthew 7:12-14

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/MAT.7.12-14>

It may not be intuitive that following God’s laws and ways in some choice (rather than our own way) leads to life, but that does not make it untrue. Mankind’s doubt of God’s goodness and good intention is the problem. The Bible teaches that things are not as they seem to be (Matthew 20:16, Hebrews 11:1-6); reality is different

from what we perceive and come to learn through our five senses from the world we experience.

Further, what Jesus said is true: good trees bear good fruit, while bad trees bear bad fruit (Matthew 7:16-23). What does your fruit look like?

"...You shall not covet your neighbor's house; you shall not covet your neighbor's wife, or his male servant, or his female servant, or his ox, or his donkey, or anything that is your neighbor's."

The Israelites were not to envy. In a world where we are able to know more and more about the business of our "neighbors," God's people are still not to envy, coveting what others have. Envy is a trap, distracting us and dividing our attention. The wisdom of Solomon says the following:

"Then I saw that all toil and all skill in work come from a man's envy of his neighbor. This also is vanity and a striving after wind."

Ecclesiastes 4:4

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/ECC.4.4>

Instead, God's people are to be satisfied in God and His good gifts, expecting from Him what is needed and asking in faith for what they want, aligning their will with His will.

If wanting more is about pleasing somebody else, this too is problematic, as God's people are to live in order to please Him. The Apostle Paul wrote about this:

'For am I now seeking the approval of man, or of God? Or am I trying to please man? If I were still trying to please man, I would not be a servant of Christ.'

Galatians 1:10

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/GAL.1.10>

Envy and people pleasing get in the way of loving our neighbors and being servants of all mankind, as Jesus called all believers to be, demonstrating it in His own life (e.g., John 13:1-17). We are designed as vessels for outflow, not just inflow. Even as with a body of water, those with no outflow become scummy. On the other hand, giving more and more of oneself is the way of growth and the way of God.

The Ten Commandments, part of God's moral law to the Jews, are summed up as follows: "Love God. Love others." This is the law of Christ (Matthew 22:36-40). Jesus Christ came not to abolish the law and the prophets but to fulfill (plēroō, G4137, Matthew 5:17).

Those who love God will follow the commandments of Christ. They will choose love of God and neighbor over self or *any extension of self*.

The following is true of followers of Jesus:

'There is therefore now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus. For the law of the Spirit of life has set you free in Christ Jesus from the law of sin and death. '

Romans 8:1-2

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/ROM.8.1-2>

Our God is the God of freedom and life.

Day 8: Moses' relationship with God

'Now Moses used to take the tent and pitch it outside the camp, far off from the camp, and he called it the tent of meeting. And everyone who sought the Lord would go out to the tent of meeting, which was outside the camp. Whenever Moses went out to the tent, all the people would rise up, and each would stand at his tent door, and watch Moses until he had gone into the tent. When Moses entered the tent, the pillar of cloud would descend and stand at the entrance of the tent, and the Lord would speak with Moses. And when all the people saw the pillar of cloud standing at the entrance of the tent, all the people would rise up and worship, each at his tent door. Thus the Lord used to speak to Moses face to face, as a man speaks to his friend. When Moses turned again into the camp, his assistant Joshua the son of Nun, a young man, would not depart from the tent. Moses said to the Lord, "See, you say to me, 'Bring up this people,' but you have not let me know whom you will send with me. Yet you have said, 'I know you by name, and you have also found favor in my sight.' Now therefore, if I have found favor in your sight, please show me now your ways, that I may know you in order to find favor in your sight. Consider too that this nation is your people." And he said, "My presence will go with you, and I will give you rest." And he said to him, "If your presence will not go with me, do not bring us up from here. For how shall it be known that I have found favor in your sight, I and your people? Is it not in your going with us, so that we are distinct, I and your people, from every other people on the face of the earth?" And the Lord said to Moses, "This very thing that you have spoken I will do, for you have found favor in my sight, and I know you by name." Moses said, "Please show me your glory." And he said, "I will make all my goodness pass before you and will proclaim before you my name 'The Lord.' And I will be gracious to whom I will be gracious, and will show mercy on whom I will show mercy." '

Exodus 33:7-19

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/EXO.33.7-19>

"The Lord passed before him and proclaimed, "The Lord, the Lord, a God merciful and gracious, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love and faithfulness, keeping steadfast love for thousands, forgiving iniquity and transgression and

sin, but who will by no means clear the guilty, visiting the iniquity of the fathers on the children and the children's children, to the third and the fourth generation.”

Exodus 34:6-7 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/exo.34.6-7.ESV>

Moses had changed a lot since the time God had called him at the burning bush (Exodus 3), where Moses had informed God in reply that people would not believe him or listen to his voice (Exodus 4:1); that he was “not eloquent,” being both “slow of speech and of tongue” (Exodus 4:10); and, finally, to “please send someone else” (Exodus 4:13).

In repeatedly choosing to obey God after this point, Moses had submitted himself fully to the Lord and made God's will his own will, and so he came to have the type of relationship that God desires to have with men and women. The Lord spoke with Moses “face to face” as we speak to our friends. In Exodus 34:29-35, it is recorded that Moses' face “shone because he had been talking with God.”

Moses asked God, “please show me now your ways, that I may know you in order to find favor in your sight.” He also requested, “If your presence will not go with me, do not bring us up from here.” God granted this request, assuring Moses, “you have found favor in my sight, and I know you by name.”

Moses said, “Please show me your glory.” God's glory (kâbôd, H3519) is the truth of His nature and also that nature reflected in mankind, who has been made just a little lower than God, able to commune with God. God's glory refers to His honor, splendor, dignity, and abundance.

In His close relationship with Moses, it pleased God to reveal Himself further to Moses, both in passing by him, although Moses could not see Him or he would die (Exodus 33:20-23), and speaking of His nature.

“The Lord passed before him and proclaimed, “The Lord, the Lord, a God merciful and gracious, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love and faithfulness, keeping steadfast love for thousands, forgiving iniquity and transgression and sin, but who will by no means clear the guilty...”

Here is the revealed nature, character, substance, and essence of the Spirit of God:

Mercy, compassion. (râcham, H7533)

Grace. (chânân, H2603)

Patience, longsuffering. ('ârêk 'aph, H750+H639)

Abounding in steadfast love and kindness (chêsêd, H2617)

Abundant in faithfulness. ('emeth, H571)

Forgiveness. (nâśâ', H5375)

Justice.

Mercy is the action of a heart full of compassion. The grace of God is His beautiful, unwarranted giving, as revealed best in Jesus Christ, who was filled with all the fullness of God's Spirit. Patience is in the character of God because He would clearly rather show mercy and forgiveness than judge. God is steadfast, a covenant keeping God of His word, faithful to His promises. Whatever God says is done.

The Spirit of the Lord was upon Moses (Numbers 11:17), so he had come to have this nature as well. Moses laid hands on his assistant, Joshua son of Nun, so he also became full of the spirit of wisdom (Deuteronomy 34:9), and he had this nature.

This is God's glory: the nature of God revealed in Himself and in those made in His image and likeness. God desires to make manifest His mercy, grace, patience, abounding love and faithfulness, forgiveness, and justice.

Now is the time of the New Testament brought by the victory of Jesus Christ. According to Scripture, the world has been in the last days after Pentecost, where God poured out His Spirit on all flesh (Joel 2:28, Acts 2:17), and everyone who calls on the name of the Lord shall be saved (Joel 2:32, Acts 2:21).

This time of the New Covenant is much better than that of the old, i.e., the times of Moses where God was less accessible. God has made all people having steadfast faith in Jesus His channel of His grace and compassion.

A very close relationship with God is not unattainable. It's God's will for His people, and God is no respecter of persons (Acts 10:34, KJV).

In fact, in Christ, we are directly connected to God (Galatians 2:20; 1 Corinthians 2:16, 3:16-17, 6:17; Ephesians 2:6, 5:30-32; Colossians 1:27, 2:19, 3:3)!

Day 9: The Lord is holy

'And the Lord spoke to Moses, saying, "Speak to all the congregation of the people of Israel and say to them, You shall be holy, for I the Lord your God am holy. Every one of you shall revere his mother and his father, and you shall keep my Sabbaths: I am the Lord your God. Do not turn to idols or make for yourselves any gods of cast metal: I am the Lord your God..." "When you reap the harvest of your land, you shall not reap your field right up to its edge, neither shall you gather the gleanings after your harvest. And you shall not strip your vineyard bare, neither shall you gather the fallen grapes of your vineyard. You shall leave them for the poor and for the sojourner: I am the Lord your God. "You shall not steal; you shall not deal falsely; you shall not lie to one another. You shall not swear by my name falsely, and so profane the name of your God: I am the Lord. "You shall not oppress your neighbor or rob him. The wages of a hired worker shall not remain with you all night until the morning. You shall not curse the deaf or put a stumbling block before the blind, but you shall fear your God: I am the Lord. "You shall do no injustice in court. You shall not be partial to the poor or defer to the great, but in righteousness shall you judge your neighbor. You shall not go around as a slanderer among your people, and you shall not stand up against the life of your neighbor: I am the Lord. "You shall not hate your brother in your heart, but you shall reason frankly with your neighbor, lest you incur sin because of him. You shall not take vengeance or bear a grudge against the sons of your own people, but you shall love your neighbor as yourself: I am the Lord..." "When a stranger sojourns with you in your land, you shall not do him wrong. You shall treat the stranger who sojourns with you as the native among you, and you shall love him as yourself, for you were strangers in the land of Egypt: I am the Lord your God. "You shall do no wrong in judgment, in measures of length or weight or quantity. You shall have just balances, just weights, a just ephah, and a just hin: I am the Lord your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt. And you shall observe all my statutes and all my rules, and do them: I am the Lord."

Leviticus 19:1-4,9-18,33-37

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/LEV.19.1-4,9-18,33-37>

It is understood that three types of laws were given to the Jews in the Old Testament: moral laws, ceremonial laws, and civil laws. The Ten Commandments are an example of moral law, as are the laws in the selected passage from today.

God is holy (qâdôsh, H6918), , set apart and free from sin, and therefore righteous (tsaddîyq, H6662) in character and conduct, acting according to His own words, law, and will. God expected His people to trust Him in faith, know that He intended good for them because He is good, and follow His commands. Only faith in God leads to freedom and life and blessing.

In the legal system of God that every created being must abide by — and by which God functions, only those without sin (or rendered as though without sin, see Colossians 2:14) can have a close relationship with God. God is holy, and He pursues a close relationship with men and women, so He commands holiness. He not only commands holiness, but He enables it by His grace and salvation (Titus 2:11-14). God does what is right, has allowed His people to know what is right, and expects His people to choose to do the right thing.

Consistently doing right follows from believing what is right, right thought patterns, speaking what is right, and, finally, choosing what is right. Steadfast faith results in right action.

For the Jews, doing right meant obeying the Ten Commandments and the other moral law to demonstrate their love for God and each other. It also meant treating others the way God wanted people treated, as they too were made in His image.

"When you reap the harvest of your land, you shall not reap your field right up to its edge... And you shall not strip your vineyard bare... You shall leave them for the poor and for the sojourner... You shall not curse the deaf or put a stumbling block before the blind... When a stranger sojourns with you in your land, you shall not do him wrong. You shall treat the stranger who sojourns with you as the native among you, and you shall love him as yourself, for you were strangers in the land of Egypt..."

Referring also to Deuteronomy 26:12-13 and Deuteronomy 27:19, God clearly had a heart for those marginalized in Jewish society: the poor ('ânîy, H6041), the deaf

(chêrêsh, H2795), the blind ('ivvêr, H5787), foreigners and sojourners (gêr, H1616), the orphans and fatherless (yâthôm, H3490), and widows ('almânâh, H490) . The tithe was to go to them and also to the Levites, or the church staff of the time.

Do we have a heart for the marginalized the way God does? Does the church?

The Jews were to love both their neighbors and the marginalized, looking out for them. In short, they were commanded, "you shall love your neighbor as yourself: I am the Lord."

Jesus interpreted this command in the familiar parable of the Good Samaritan (Luke 10:25-37). In Jesus' interpretation, the stranger that the Israelites were commanded to love as themselves (Leviticus 19:34) was considered the neighbor (Leviticus 19:18).

Two of the ways Jesus Christ and the kingdom of God are countercultural include welcoming the marginalized and denial of self-interest. Jesus is the "image of the invisible God" (Colossians 1:15) and "the exact imprint of His nature" (Hebrews 1:3). As revealed through the moral law and through Jesus, God expects that His people will love everyone and care for everyone as He does love and care for them, and that they will do justly as representatives of Him. This is what the people functioning in God's image and likeness will do. This is what Christ's body does.

God expects His church to step outside of themselves; see others as He sees them, considering what redemption has made possible for them; take responsibility for them; and love as He loves — unselfishly, benevolently, tenderly. God's law and God's ways do not allow for selfishness. Jesus commanded, 'But seek first the kingdom of God and his righteousness, and all these things will be added to you.'

Matthew 6:33

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/MAT.6.33>

God is righteous (tsaddîyq, H6662), and His people are to seek righteousness (tsedâqâh, H6666; dikaiosunē, G1343)— the rightness of God— for themselves and for others. They are to seek it, spirit, soul and body, in all things— in themselves, in their affairs, in their homes and churches, in their businesses, in their

neighborhoods, in their cities and countries, to the ends of the earth. They are to hunger for, thirst for, and to expect the righteousness that only God is able to bring to all people and things (see also Matthew 5:6).

“Holy, holy, holy, is the Lord God Almighty, who was and is and is to come!”
(Revelation 4:8)

Day 10: A Psalm of Moses about God's salvation

'He who dwells in the shelter of the Most High will abide in the shadow of the Almighty. I will say to the Lord, "My refuge and my fortress, my God, in whom I trust." For he will deliver you from the snare of the fowler and from the deadly pestilence. He will cover you with his pinions, and under his wings you will find refuge; his faithfulness is a shield and buckler. You will not fear the terror of the night, nor the arrow that flies by day, nor the pestilence that stalks in darkness, nor the destruction that wastes at noonday. A thousand may fall at your side, ten thousand at your right hand, but it will not come near you. You will only look with your eyes and see the recompense of the wicked. Because you have made the Lord your dwelling place—the Most High, who is my refuge—no evil shall be allowed to befall you, no plague come near your tent. For he will command his angels concerning you to guard you in all your ways. On their hands they will bear you up, lest you strike your foot against a stone. You will tread on the lion and the adder; the young lion and the serpent you will trample underfoot. "Because he holds fast to me in love, I will deliver him; I will protect him, because he knows my name. When he calls to me, I will answer him; I will be with him in trouble; I will rescue him and honor him. With long life I will satisfy him and show him my salvation."

Psalm 91:1-16

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/PSA.91.1-16>

Jewish tradition ascribes this psalm to Moses (yet compiled by David). The devil saw fit to tempt Jesus with some of its text, according to Matthew 4:5-7. Jesus used the truth in God's Word to respond to the devil: "it is written" (Matthew 4:4,7,10).

This psalm speaks of the protection and blessing of God for His people brought about by a relationship of trust in Him. The ever victorious God allows His people to abide with (yâshab, H3427) Him by faith, providing sanctuary. The fortress of the Most High ('elyôn, H5945), where His people may dwell in (yâshab, H3427) Him through trust (bâtach, H982), casts a large shadow.

Despite any appearance or situation that could cause fear, God desired for His people to remember His faithfulness, His provision, and His promise to shield, to deliver, and to bless those who follow Him.

“...For he will deliver you from the snare of the fowler and from the deadly pestilence...”

They were delivered (nâtsal, H5337) from that which would try to entrap. They were delivered from any deadly pestilence or plague. They were delivered from defeat in battle. They were delivered from all evil.

“...For he will command his angels concerning you to guard you in all your ways. On their hands they will bear you up, lest you strike your foot against a stone...”

They were delivered by the Lord of Hosts who commanded unseen armies to guard them, keeping them (shâmar, H8104) from any harm.

“...You will tread on the lion and the adder; the young lion and the serpent you will trample underfoot...”

God's people were protected in the desert as they approached the promised land to lay hold of it. While in the will of God, they could tread on (râmas, H7429; pateō, G3961) serpents and scorpions, and over all the power (exousia, G1849) of the enemy, and nothing would by any means hurt them (see Luke 10:19, Mark 16:18, Acts 28:3-5). For those with steadfast faith in the sovereign Lord and His word, in the Old Testament and the New, their tread was the march of the conqueror, their song the song of victory, their crown the crown of glory.

“...Because he holds fast to me in love, I will deliver him; I will protect him, because he knows my name. When he calls to me, I will answer him; I will be with him in trouble; I will rescue him and honor him. With long life I will satisfy him and show him my salvation.”

God desired for His people to know Him and to hold fast to Him in love (châshaq, H2836), knowing His will and His promise to protect them, deliver (châlats, H2502) them, rescue them, honor (kâbad, H3513) them. God promised those with steadfast faith in Him long life and satisfaction (sâba', H7646) in Him. He promised to show them His full salvation (yeshû'âh, H3444) in the midst of any trouble. God wanted

His people to know (yâda', H3045) Him and believe in His word, His nature, and His ability, as He had already shown to them.

They were to believe the words of God over the words of man and what their eyes showed them. The arm (zerôa', H2220) of the Lord is revealed for those who believe ('âman, H539) the report (shemû'âh, H8052) of God (Isaiah 53:1 KJV) and know the authority of God and His word (Matthew 4:10-11). The God of Abraham, Israel, Moses, and David is never defeated, and His words always accomplish what God purposes, succeeding in the thing for which God sends it (Isaiah 55:11).

Day 11: Caleb's faith in God

After making it to the outskirts of the Promised Land, the spies who went in were scared to enter it, except for Joshua and Caleb, who had faith in God. Caleb spoke up to the naysayers first:

'But Caleb quieted the people before Moses and said, "Let us go up at once and occupy it, for we are well able to overcome it." '

Numbers 13:30

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/NUM.13.30>

Caleb took God at His word and knew they would have the victory despite any appearance because they had God on their side. The Israelites did not believe him, and they continued their complaining and unbelief.

Here is how Joshua and Caleb responded:

'And Joshua the son of Nun and Caleb the son of Jephunneh, who were among those who had spied out the land, tore their clothes and said to all the congregation of the people of Israel, "The land, which we passed through to spy it out, is an exceedingly good land. If the Lord delights in us, he will bring us into this land and give it to us, a land that flows with milk and honey. Only do not rebel against the Lord . And do not fear the people of the land, for they are bread for us. Their protection is removed from them, and the Lord is with us; do not fear them." '

Numbers 14:6-9

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/NUM.14.6-9>

In response, God said to Moses:

'But my servant Caleb, because he has a different spirit and has followed me fully, I will bring into the land into which he went, and his descendants shall possess it. '

Numbers 14:24

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/NUM.14.24>

It was later recorded:

'Then the people of Judah came to Joshua at Gilgal. And Caleb the son of Jephunneh the Kenizzite said to him, "You know what the Lord said to Moses the man of God in Kadesh-barnea concerning you and me. I was forty years old when

Moses the servant of the Lord sent me from Kadesh-barnea to spy out the land, and I brought him word again as it was in my heart. But my brothers who went up with me made the heart of the people melt; yet I wholly followed the Lord my God. And Moses swore on that day, saying, 'Surely the land on which your foot has trodden shall be an inheritance for you and your children forever, because you have wholly followed the Lord my God.' And now, behold, the Lord has kept me alive, just as he said, these forty-five years since the time that the Lord spoke this word to Moses, while Israel walked in the wilderness. And now, behold, I am this day eighty-five years old. I am still as strong today as I was in the day that Moses sent me; my strength now is as my strength was then, for war and for going and coming. So now give me this hill country of which the Lord spoke on that day, for you heard on that day how the Anakim were there, with great fortified cities. It may be that the Lord will be with me, and I shall drive them out just as the Lord said." Then Joshua blessed him, and he gave Hebron to Caleb the son of Jephunneh for an inheritance. Therefore Hebron became the inheritance of Caleb the son of Jephunneh the Kenizzite to this day, because he wholly followed the Lord, the God of Israel. Now the name of Hebron formerly was Kiriath-arba. (Arba was the greatest man among the Anakim.) And the land had rest from war.'

Joshua 14:6-15

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/JOS.14.6-15>

Caleb had a different spirit. He believed the Lord. He wholly followed the Lord. He was bold. He spoke up. He stood up to those who rebelled against God. He desired to please God, and he knew that it was faith that pleased God.

As a result, at 85, Caleb's strength (kôach, H3581) was as it had been at 40 when he was set to enter the promised land. Believing God still, Caleb led his descendents to receive their inheritance, driving the occupants of the land out.

Moses is described in a similar way, even at the end of his life:

'Moses was 120 years old when he died. His eye was undimmed, and his vigor unabated.'

Deuteronomy 34:7

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/DEU.34.7>

A long life is a blessing from God, as Moses described:

'I call heaven and earth to witness against you today, that I have set before you life and death, blessing and curse. Therefore choose life, that you and your offspring may live, loving the Lord your God, obeying his voice and holding fast to him, for he is your life and length of days, that you may dwell in the land that the Lord swore to your fathers, to Abraham, to Isaac, and to Jacob, to give them.'

Deuteronomy 30:19-20

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/DEU.30.19-20>

Caleb chose life (chay, H2416). God quickened (châyâh, H2421) him and extended his length of days, and he and his offspring did dwell (yâshab, H3427) in the land of promise. Steadfast faith in God has always led to the giving of life (châyâh, H2421; zōopoieō, G2227), by the design of God.

God's people are to choose to believe God over what their eyes may see. They choose to believe ('âman, H539) the report (shemû'âh, H8052) of God over the report of man (Isaiah 53:1, John 12:37-43, Romans 10:16-17).

Day 12: The bronze serpent

'From Mount Hor they set out by the way to the Red Sea, to go around the land of Edom. And the people became impatient on the way. And the people spoke against God and against Moses, "Why have you brought us up out of Egypt to die in the wilderness? For there is no food and no water, and we loathe this worthless food." Then the Lord sent fiery serpents among the people, and they bit the people, so that many people of Israel died. And the people came to Moses and said, "We have sinned, for we have spoken against the Lord and against you. Pray to the Lord , that he take away the serpents from us." So Moses prayed for the people. And the Lord said to Moses, "Make a fiery serpent and set it on a pole, and everyone who is bitten, when he sees it, shall live." So Moses made a bronze serpent and set it on a pole. And if a serpent bit anyone, he would look at the bronze serpent and live. '

Numbers 21:4-9

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/NUM.21.4-9>

In many accounts from the Torah including this one, the Israelites who refused to go into the promised land seemed like a whiny bunch. Some of them became used to being provided for by God, and they had high expectations of Moses and for God's level of service to them. It's surprising that the incidents of God's judgment they witnessed, including Korah's Rebellion (Numbers 16), where the earth opened up to consume many and others were consumed by fire (v. 31-35), weren't enough to stop them. They had already been judged by God; they would never enter the promised land (Numbers 14:21-23,26-38).

On the occasion of the scripture selected for today, God allowed some of them to die by the way of bites from fiery serpents. Some of them came to Moses to ask for reprieve, admitting they had sinned against Moses and God. Moses agreed to talk to God on their behalf.

God asked Moses to make a fiery serpent and set it on a pole, so Moses made a bronze serpent and set it on a pole among the Israelites. By God's design, if any fiery serpent bit anyone, they would look upon (nâbat, H5027) the bronze serpent and be restored to life (châyah, H2425).

Jesus referred to this bronze serpent in this conversation with the Pharisee Nicodemus:

'And as Moses lifted up the serpent in the wilderness, so must the Son of Man be lifted up, that whoever believes in him may have eternal life. "For God so loved the world, that he gave his only Son, that whoever believes in him should not perish but have eternal life." '

John 3:14-16

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/JHN.3.14-16>

This bronze serpent was a type of Jesus Christ, who brought life (zōē, G2222) in its many forms. (By type, the following definition is intended: a person or thing symbolizing or exemplifying the ideal or defining characteristics of something.) When the Israelites were obedient to look at the bronze serpent, they were healed by the life of God (zōē, G2222). They were quickened (châyâh, H2421; zōopoieō, G2227).

Even so, Jesus Christ, the Son of Man and Son of God, was the one chosen to be lifted up to bring life (zōē, G2222) to whoever believes in Him. This salvation (sōzō, G4982) is much more than the healing that the Israelites experienced, for they would go on to die in the desert anyway. This salvation makes one whole by connecting them directly to God in Christ Jesus, also rescuing them from evil and its effects.

Faith in what Jesus did through the cross brings life (zōē, G2222) of every kind, including eternal life. God is life. Choosing to trust and follow Jesus is the only way to choose life.

Day 13: The greatest commandment

“Now this is the commandment—the statutes and the rules—that the Lord your God commanded me to teach you, that you may do them in the land to which you are going over, to possess it, that you may fear the Lord your God, you and your son and your son’s son, by keeping all his statutes and his commandments, which I command you, all the days of your life, and that your days may be long. Hear therefore, O Israel, and be careful to do them, that it may go well with you, and that you may multiply greatly, as the Lord, the God of your fathers, has promised you, in a land flowing with milk and honey. “Hear, O Israel: The Lord our God, the Lord is one. You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your might. And these words that I command you today shall be on your heart. You shall teach them diligently to your children, and shall talk of them when you sit in your house, and when you walk by the way, and when you lie down, and when you rise. You shall bind them as a sign on your hand, and they shall be as frontlets between your eyes. You shall write them on the doorposts of your house and on your gates.’

Deuteronomy 6:1-9

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/DEU.6.1-9>

When Jesus was asked what was the greatest commandment, He referred to this passage in Deuteronomy: “You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your might.”

This is for God’s family, so it was for the Jews and it is for the church. God’s people are to apply their will to loving God, letting it affect everything over which they have been given choice and control by God, both in soul (mind, will and emotions) and in body. In Hebrew, this included the heart (lêbab, H3824), soul (nephesh, H5315), and might (me’ôd, H3966).

They should keep this love of God and His word (dâbâr, H1697) ever before them and their families. Their attention should be directed on God and His word in every way. God should be an obsession of theirs. Their children should be taught to love God and know Him and His words. They should talk about God and His word all throughout the day, from when they rise to when they go to bed. The

words of God should be written everywhere so their attention is on God and His words.

The blessings for the Israelites that came from faithful love and obedience to God, doing what His word commanded (see also James 1:25), were that things might go well with His people: long life, abundance, and multiplication. Other blessings follow in Deuteronomy:

' "And because you listen to these rules and keep and do them, the Lord your God will keep with you the covenant and the steadfast love that he swore to your fathers. He will love you, bless you, and multiply you. He will also bless the fruit of your womb and the fruit of your ground, your grain and your wine and your oil, the increase of your herds and the young of your flock, in the land that he swore to your fathers to give you. You shall be blessed above all peoples. There shall not be male or female barren among you or among your livestock. And the Lord will take away from you all sickness, and none of the evil diseases of Egypt, which you knew, will he inflict on you, but he will lay them on all who hate you. '

Deuteronomy 7:12-15

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/DEU.7.12-15>

'The Lord will open to you his good treasury, the heavens, to give the rain to your land in its season and to bless all the work of your hands. And you shall lend to many nations, but you shall not borrow. And the Lord will make you the head and not the tail, and you shall only go up and not down, if you obey the commandments of the Lord your God, which I command you today, being careful to do them, '

Deuteronomy 28:12-13

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/DEU.28.12-13>

God is a covenant (berîyith, H1285) keeping God. He is known for His steadfast love (chêsêd, H2617). Israel's part of the covenant was love for God and obedience to His word, which simplifies to loving God and loving neighbor in the ways God directed.

According to the ways of God, this love in action on mankind's part causes God to unleash the life and blessing He wants to give to His people. This is God's will being done on earth as it is in heaven (Matthew 6:10). The Father desires to give good gifts to His children (Matthew 7:11).

Day 14: Be strong and courageous

Moses repeated to Joshua the message that God had given to him:

'Then Moses summoned Joshua and said to him in the sight of all Israel, "Be strong and courageous, for you shall go with this people into the land that the Lord has sworn to their fathers to give them, and you shall put them in possession of it. It is the Lord who goes before you. He will be with you; he will not leave you or forsake you. Do not fear or be dismayed." '

Deuteronomy 31:7-8

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/DEU.31.7-8>

God later gave this message to Joshua:

'No man shall be able to stand before you all the days of your life. Just as I was with Moses, so I will be with you. I will not leave you or forsake you. Be strong and courageous, for you shall cause this people to inherit the land that I swore to their fathers to give them. Only be strong and very courageous, being careful to do according to all the law that Moses my servant commanded you. Do not turn from it to the right hand or to the left, that you may have good success wherever you go. This Book of the Law shall not depart from your mouth, but you shall meditate on it day and night, so that you may be careful to do according to all that is written in it. For then you will make your way prosperous, and then you will have good success. Have I not commanded you? Be strong and courageous. Do not be frightened, and do not be dismayed, for the Lord your God is with you wherever you go." '

Joshua 1:5-9

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/JOS.1.5-9>

God told his people to be strong and very courageous because He went before them and was with them. Nothing has changed in this regard. God's love is steadfast, and He will not leave nor forsake His people.

In light of this, God commanded His people not to fear.

The Apostle Paul wrote:

"for God gave us a spirit not of fear but of power and love and self-control."

2 Timothy 1:7

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/2Ti.1.7>

The King James version replaces self-control (sōphronismos, G4995) with “a sound mind.”

Joshua also commanded God's people to be careful to do everything the Lord commanded them, linking their obedience to God to their success.

God is intrinsically linked with His words (dâbâr, H1697), the same ones that spoke ('âmar, H559) life (chay, H2416) into being. The words of God's moral law, the Ten Commandments included, commanded what was best for His people. God wanted His people to believe that He had their best in mind and act accordingly. Following God brought life, while choosing not to follow His law was sin, leading to death.

In not allowing God's words to depart from their mouths or their thoughts, or to affect their actions, they were keeping their God who loved them and created them ever before them.

Loving and following God, believing He has our best in mind, still leads to success.

As one example, consider selfishness. Loving God and following His command to love and serve all people leads to less selfishness.

What makes one the best kind of parent? One that isn't selfish.

What makes one the best kind of boss or leader? A less selfish one.

What makes one the best kind of friend? An unselfish one.

What about the best spouse? A less selfish one.

Followers of God must also consider what success is, since the common pursuit of happiness in the world just leaves one feeling empty, unlike the pursuit of the God

who is and who brings one life (zōē, G2222) and liberty (eleutheria, G1657, e.g., 2 Corinthians 3:17). He is the Giver of every good and perfect gift.

“...It is the Lord who goes before you. He will be with you; he will not leave you or forsake you...”

In the current times of the New Testament, God has an even better way of being with His people, His church. For those who choose Christ’s way over their own way, they receive the “riches” of the “mystery hidden for ages and generations,” “which is Christ in you, the hope of glory” (Colossians 1:26-27). The Spirit of Jesus Christ abides in each member of His church, His own body.

Jesus is Life, and He has dominion in heaven, on earth, and under the earth (Philippians 2:9-11), so His church can be strong and very courageous. He empowers His church to love God and to love and serve others just as He did. Like Joshua did as He led the people into the promised land, continuing to believe the words of God and act on them, Jesus has experienced only victory.

Since Jesus has victory in all things (2 Corinthians 2:14), the church (the body of believers who are *in Christ*) can be strong and very courageous, and it will be successful. It will take possession of the promises of God and the riches of its inheritance (2 Corinthians 1:20, Ephesians 1:3-14).

Day 15: Hannah gives her child back to God

1 Samuel 1 records the account of Hannah, who desperately wanted a child, a son: 'And she vowed a vow and said, "O Lord of hosts, if you will indeed look on the affliction of your servant and remember me and not forget your servant, but will give to your servant a son, then I will give him to the Lord all the days of his life..." '

1 Samuel 1:11

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/1SA.1.11>

God answered her:

'And in due time Hannah conceived and bore a son, and she called his name Samuel, for she said, "I have asked for him from the Lord ."'

1 Samuel 1:20

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/1SA.1.20>

Afterwards, she said to the priest,

"For this child I prayed, and the Lord has granted me my petition that I made to him. Therefore I have lent him to the Lord. As long as he lives, he is lent to the Lord."

1 Samuel 1:27-28

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/1SA.1.27-28>

'And Hannah prayed and said, "My heart exults in the Lord ; my horn is exalted in the Lord. My mouth derides my enemies, because I rejoice in your salvation. There is none holy like the Lord: for there is none besides you; there is no rock like our God. Talk no more so very proudly, let not arrogance come from your mouth; for the Lord is a God of knowledge, and by him actions are weighed. The bows of the mighty are broken, but the feeble bind on strength. Those who were full have hired themselves out for bread, but those who were hungry have ceased to hunger. The barren has borne seven, but she who has many children is forlorn. The Lord kills and brings to life; he brings down to Sheol and raises up. The Lord makes poor and makes rich; he brings low and he exalts. He raises up the poor from the dust; he lifts the needy from the ash heap to make them sit with princes and inherit a seat of honor. For the pillars of the earth are the Lord 's, and on them he has set

the world. He will guard the feet of his faithful ones, but the wicked shall be cut off in darkness, for not by might shall a man prevail.”

1 Samuel 2:1-9

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/1SA.2.1-9>

The name Hannah (channâh, H2584) means grace, referring also to mercy and favor (chânân, H2603). Hannah's character and her vow caught God's attention, and He remembered her, giving her a child that she named Samuel, meaning "God has heard."

Hannah honored her vow, giving Samuel to God by giving Him to the service of the priest Eli. God had answered her prayer, bringing her joy, and her song is recorded following her giving of her son back to God.

In saying her horn was exalted, as a bull's would be after winning a battle, Hannah was celebrating the victory that God had brought to her. God had saved her and lifted her up through answering her heart's cry: to give life (châyah, H2421) to a son.

When Hannah said her mouth derides her enemies, she may have been referring to the other wife of her husband, of whom it is written: 'And her rival used to provoke her grievously to irritate her, because the Lord had closed her womb. '

1 Samuel 1:6

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/1SA.1.6>

God was first in Hannah's life. He was the rock on which she could rely, the One who made her strong, the One who provided (Jehovah Jireh, H3070), the One who gave life (châyah, H2421) and abundance (kâbod, H3519), the sovereign One who made things right.

Hannah loved God, trusted Him, relied on Him to deliver (yeshû'âh, H3444) her, and rejoiced in Him. She gave back to God His good gift to her.

She is an example of how a man or woman should respond to the grace of God.

God's grace (chânān, H2603; charis, G5485) is the beautiful, gratuitous giving that is the divine outflowing of His nature. God's grace leads to complete salvation (yeshû'âh, H3444; sōzō, G4982) of any who would put their faith and trust in Him.

Hannah knew God was generous, experienced His generosity, and was satisfied in it.

Day 16: David anointed king

'Samuel did what the Lord commanded and came to Bethlehem. The elders of the city came to meet him trembling and said, "Do you come peaceably?" And he said, "Peaceably; I have come to sacrifice to the Lord. Consecrate yourselves, and come with me to the sacrifice." And he consecrated Jesse and his sons and invited them to the sacrifice. When they came, he looked on Eliab and thought, "Surely the Lord's anointed is before him." But the Lord said to Samuel, "Do not look on his appearance or on the height of his stature, because I have rejected him. For the Lord sees not as man sees: man looks on the outward appearance, but the Lord looks on the heart." Then Jesse called Abinadab and made him pass before Samuel. And he said, "Neither has the Lord chosen this one." Then Jesse made Shammah pass by. And he said, "Neither has the Lord chosen this one." And Jesse made seven of his sons pass before Samuel. And Samuel said to Jesse, "The Lord has not chosen these." Then Samuel said to Jesse, "Are all your sons here?" And he said, "There remains yet the youngest, but behold, he is keeping the sheep." And Samuel said to Jesse, "Send and get him, for we will not sit down till he comes here." And he sent and brought him in. Now he was ruddy and had beautiful eyes and was handsome. And the Lord said, "Arise, anoint him, for this is he." Then Samuel took the horn of oil and anointed him in the midst of his brothers. And the Spirit of the Lord rushed upon David from that day forward. And Samuel rose up and went to Ramah. Now the Spirit of the Lord departed from Saul, and a harmful spirit from the Lord tormented him... And whenever the harmful spirit from God was upon Saul, David took the lyre and played it with his hand. So Saul was refreshed and was well, and the harmful spirit departed from him.'

1 Samuel 16:4-14,23

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/1SA.16.4-14,23>

The Israelites demanded to be led by a king so they could be like the other nations around them (1 Samuel 8:19-20), thinking they knew what was best for them. God allowed them to choose, and so He led Samuel to anoint Saul, a very tall man (1 Samuel 9:2), as king and with the Spirit of the Lord (1 Samuel 10:6-10). Saul turned his back on God though, deciding not to perform His commandments because he feared his people and obeyed their voice (1 Samuel 15:11,24), so God, seeking a man after His own heart (1 Samuel 13:14), asked Samuel to anoint a different king.

Based upon the appearance of a man named Eliab, Samuel thought God had chosen him to be king. God told him though that “the Lord sees not as man sees: man looks on the outward appearance, but the Lord looks on the heart” (lêbâb, H3824). What is attractive to God is to see man and woman as God created them to be, made in His image and likeness (Genesis 1:26-27). This has to do with a person’s character and the nature of their soul, which is the seat of the mind, will, and emotions; it’s the interface between that which is seen — the body — and unseen, the spirit (1 Thessalonians 5:23).

God saw David, a young, ruddy keeper of sheep, for who he was in God’s likeness and who he could be. David was a shepherd at heart, and God is the shepherd of His people, for Israel knew God as the One before whom his fathers walked and his shepherd all of the days of his life (Genesis 48:15). David was also seen by God as one who would “do all my will” (Acts 13:22).

When Samuel anointed (mâsach, H4886) David at the Lord’s direction, the Spirit of the Lord left Saul, allowing him to be affected by a harmful spirit, and rushed upon David.

In the New Testament brought about by Jesus’ victory: 1) it’s made clear that harmful spirits are from Satan (Acts 10:38, 1 John 3:8), who had legally taken rule from man when Adam and Eve disobeyed God, and 2) the Holy Spirit does not come upon individuals but instead lives inside those who are made alive by their decision to follow Jesus Christ (Colossians 1:27, 1 Corinthians 6:19). All Christ followers are anointed (1 John 2:20).

Saul, still king, came to find that David’s presence and the music he played for Saul brought him peace and refreshing. This is an introduction in Scripture to the great psalmist, David, who wrote at least 75 of the 150 psalms. He was introduced to Saul as “skillful in playing, a man of valor, a man of war, prudent in speech, and a man of good presence, and the Lord is with him” (1 Samuel 16:18). Saul came to love David, making David his armor-bearer (v. 21).

Day 17: God promises an eternal kingdom to David's offspring

'Now, therefore, thus you shall say to my servant David, "Thus says the Lord of hosts, I took you from the pasture, from following the sheep, that you should be prince over my people Israel. And I have been with you wherever you went and have cut off all your enemies from before you. And I will make for you a great name, like the name of the great ones of the earth. And I will appoint a place for my people Israel and will plant them, so that they may dwell in their own place and be disturbed no more. And violent men shall afflict them no more, as formerly, from the time that I appointed judges over my people Israel. And I will give you rest from all your enemies. Moreover, the Lord declares to you that the Lord will make you a house. When your days are fulfilled and you lie down with your fathers, I will raise up your offspring after you, who shall come from your body, and I will establish his kingdom. He shall build a house for my name, and I will establish the throne of his kingdom forever. I will be to him a father, and he shall be to me a son. When he commits iniquity, I will discipline him with the rod of men, with the stripes of the sons of men, but my steadfast love will not depart from him, as I took it from Saul, whom I put away from before you. And your house and your kingdom shall be made sure forever before me. Your throne shall be established forever."

2 Samuel 7:8-16

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/2SA.7.8-16>

The promise God made to David is similar to the one He made to Abraham:

'... "By myself I have sworn, declares the Lord, because you have done this and have not withheld your son, your only son, I will surely bless you, and I will surely multiply your offspring as the stars of heaven and as the sand that is on the seashore. And your offspring shall possess the gate of his enemies, and in your offspring shall all the nations of the earth be blessed, because you have obeyed my voice."

Genesis 22:16-18 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/gen.22.16-18.ESV>

The promise made to David is more specific though than the one God made to Abraham. It refers both to Jesus and God's people, the church, who have been

grafted into God's people, Israel (Romans 11:17-36), as branches connected to the Vine, Jesus Christ, by God, the vinedresser (John 15:1-2).

It is David's descendent, Jesus Christ, that has a house (bayith, H1004), a kingdom (mamlâkâh, H4467), and a throne (kissê', H3678), being a son to God — the Son of God.

House. The house (bayith, H1004) is the body of Christ, the church (ekklēsia, G1577), made of Israelites and Gentiles, made of all the nations of the earth. And so it is a blessing to all nations, as promised to Abraham.

Kingdom. The kingdom (mamlâkâh, H4467; basileia, G932) is the one that Jesus preached as being near (eggizō, G1448, e.g., Matthew 3:2), the one that has come with His resurrection and glorification (Luke 22:18). The kingdom has come with Jesus' demonstration of the power (dunamis, G1411) and authority (exousia, G1849) of God to bring freedom, healing and salvation (Matthew 4:23-24, 1 Corinthians 4:19-20) through the Holy Spirit, now given to the body of Christ, the church (Luke 9:1-2). This kingdom (mamlâkâh, H4467; basileia, G932) that Jesus brought allowed the church (ekklēsia, G1577) to possess (yârash, H3423) the gate (sha'ar, H8179; pulē G4439) of God's enemies (Genesis 22:17, Matthew 16:18-19).

Throne. The throne (kissê', H3678; thronos, G2362) is the one Jesus received with authority over all of heaven and earth until the time that all evil is put under His feet (1 Corinthians 15:24-28). It is Christ's throne and, therefore, it belongs also to the body of Christ, the church, to accomplish the will of God and bring Him glory. It is the throne of grace (Hebrews 4:16), and *in Christ* we are seated with Him (Ephesians 2:6, Colossians 3:3).

"...When he commits iniquity, I will discipline him with the rod of men, with the stripes of the sons of men, but my steadfast love will not depart from him, as I took it from Saul, whom I put away from before you..."

It is by Jesus' stripes (nega', H5061; chabbûrâh, H2250; mōlōps, G3468) — those inflicted before His crucifixion — that Jehovah Rapha has healed (râphâ', H7495; therapeuō, G2323; iaomai, G2390) because Jesus took on the iniquity ('âvâh, H5753; 'âvôn, H5771), infirmity (astheneia, G769), sicknesses (cholîy, H2483; nosos,

G3554), and pain (mak'ôb, H4341) of all of mankind that have steadfast faith in Him (see also Isaiah 53:1-6, Matthew 8:16-17, 1 Peter 2:24). It is finished (teleō, G5055; John 19:30), and *in Christ* His steadfast love, lovingkindness, and mercy (chêsêd, H2617) does not depart from us.

God also promised a coming time when Israel will have rest from their enemies (2 Samuel 7:11). This will be brought by the second coming of Jesus Christ, which is thoroughly discussed in other parts of Scripture in the Old and New Testaments (including Acts 15:16-17, 2 Thessalonians 2:8, Zechariah 14:2-4, Zechariah 12:10, Isaiah 25:9, Isaiah 60:21, Micah 4:24, Isaiah 33:24, Isaiah 35:5-10, Habakkuk 2:14, Isaiah 65:19, Isaiah 2:3, Revelation 20:7-8,11-15; 21:1-8).

Through the line of David, God brought His kingdom, and He will bring complete victory (nikē, G3529) to everyone that abides in Jesus Christ by faith (1 John 5:4), because of the steadfast love (chêsêd, H2617) of God for men and women made in His image and likeness.

Day 18: Psalms of praise by David

"O Lord, our Lord, how majestic is your name in all the earth! You have set your glory above the heavens. Out of the mouth of babies and infants, you have established strength because of your foes, to still the enemy and the avenger. When I look at your heavens, the work of your fingers, the moon and the stars, which you have set in place, what is man that you are mindful of him, and the son of man that you care for him? Yet you have made him a little lower than the heavenly beings and crowned him with glory and honor. You have given him dominion over the works of your hands; you have put all things under his feet, all sheep and oxen, and also the beasts of the field, the birds of the heavens, and the fish of the sea, whatever passes along the paths of the seas. O Lord, our Lord, how majestic is your name in all the earth!"

Psalms 8:1-9 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/psa.8.1-9.ESV>

In this psalm, David's adoration of God, His name, and His creation is evident.

In David's song, he asked God why He cared so much for mankind. David declared that mankind had been made only a little lower than God ('elôhîym, H430, translated as God over 90% of the time), crowned ('âtar, H5849) with glory (kâbôd, H3519) and honor (hâdâr, H1926) as God is. David knew who he was to God.

David marveled at how we have been made in the image and likeness of God, given such dominion (mâshal, H4910) over the rest of creation.

This king who God made famous throughout history marveled at God as the majestic ('addîyr, H117) One. To David, it wasn't about him; it was about God.

David's heart is also revealed in the 19th Psalm:

"The heavens declare the glory of God, and the sky above proclaims his handiwork. Day to day pours out speech, and night to night reveals knowledge. There is no speech, nor are there words, whose voice is not heard. Their voice goes out through all the earth, and their words to the end of the world. In them he has set a tent for the sun, which comes out like a bridegroom leaving his chamber,

and, like a strong man, runs its course with joy. Its rising is from the end of the heavens, and its circuit to the end of them, and there is nothing hidden from its heat. The law of the Lord is perfect, reviving the soul; the testimony of the Lord is sure, making wise the simple; the precepts of the Lord are right, rejoicing the heart; the commandment of the Lord is pure, enlightening the eyes; the fear of the Lord is clean, enduring forever; the rules of the Lord are true, and righteous altogether. More to be desired are they than gold, even much fine gold; sweeter also than honey and drippings of the honeycomb. Moreover, by them is your servant warned; in keeping them there is great reward. Who can discern his errors? Declare me innocent from hidden faults. Keep back your servant also from presumptuous sins; let them not have dominion over me! Then I shall be blameless, and innocent of great transgression. Let the words of my mouth and the meditation of my heart be acceptable in your sight, O Lord, my rock and my redeemer."

Psalms 19:1-14 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/psa.19.1-14.ESV>

David not only marveled at creation; he claimed it to be a source of knowledge, just as the Apostle Paul did:

"For what can be known about God is plain to them, because God has shown it to them. For his invisible attributes, namely, his eternal power and divine nature, have been clearly perceived, ever since the creation of the world, in the things that have been made. So they are without excuse."

Romans 1:19-20 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/rom.1.19-20.ESV>

God's creation wasn't the only way God had spoken. David also delighted in God's word, calling it here the law (tôrâh, H8451) of the Lord, the testimony ('êdûth, H5715) of the Lord, the precepts (piqqûd, H6490) of the Lord, the commandment (mitsvâh, H4687) of the Lord, and the rules (mishpât, H4941) of the Lord.

David said that God's word revived the soul, made those with an open mind wise, caused rejoicing in the heart, enlightened the mind, and led to great reward if followed. According to David, God's word was true and to be desired more than fine gold or the finest of foods.

For David, God was the source of life, wisdom, joy, knowledge, truth and blessing. In faith, he did not doubt that God's will was to do good.

David's attention was on God, and David was satisfied in Him. He knew that God cared about what he thought about, what he said, what he loved, and whether he was obedient.

David wanted to be close to God, his rock and his redeemer, so he hated sin. David wanted to do right.

David was an outstanding example of the love a human can have for God and one who cared about the things God cares about.

As such, David was counted as a man after God's own heart (1 Samuel 13:14). His will was to do all of God's will (Acts 13:22).

Day 19: The Lord is my Shepherd

'The Lord is my shepherd; I shall not want. He makes me lie down in green pastures. He leads me beside still waters. He restores my soul. He leads me in paths of righteousness for his name's sake. Even though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death, I will fear no evil, for you are with me; your rod and your staff, they comfort me. You prepare a table before me in the presence of my enemies; you anoint my head with oil; my cup overflows. Surely goodness and mercy shall follow me all the days of my life, and I shall dwell in the house of the Lord forever.'

Psalms 23:1-6

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/PSA.23.1-6>

This psalm by David is the most popular to read at Christian and Jewish funerals, but really it is more applicable to a life lived with God, not death. It represents who God wants to be to us. God is Life (Genesis 2:7, John 1:1-4), and, furthermore, Jesus said about God:

'Now he is not God of the dead, but of the living, for all live to him.' '

Luke 20:38

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/LUK.20.38>

Just as Israel saw the Lord as His shepherd (Jehovah Rô'âh, see Genesis 48:15), so did David.

David knew he would not want because God is the Lord who provides, even as Abraham had experienced Him (Jehovah Jireh, Genesis 22:14, H3070). He trusted God to take care of him. In fact, David had more than enough to satisfy him; his cup overflowed (revâyâh, H7310).

"...He makes me lie down in green pastures. He leads me beside still waters. He restores my soul..."

God was David's peace (Jehovah Shâlôm, Judges 6:24, H3073), bringing comfort in every circumstance. David would not fear because he knew God was present with him. God would stay present with him; he would dwell (yâshab, H3427) in the house of the Lord forever.

"...He leads me in paths of righteousness for his name's sake. Even though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death, I will fear no evil, for you are with me; your rod and your staff, they comfort me. You prepare a table before me in the presence of my enemies..."

David trusted God to lead him to do what was right and to deliver him from evil. Jehovah Tsidqênû (Jeremiah 23:6, H3072), the Lord our Righteousness, does right and is always victorious over evil. David would be blessed even in the presence of his enemies.

"...Surely goodness and mercy shall follow me all the days of my life, and I shall dwell in the house of the Lord forever."

David knew that with God, goodness (tôb, H2896) and mercy (chêsêd, H2617) would follow him because that is the nature of God — one of grace, or a divine, gratuitous giving that flows from His nature.

Probably this psalm brings so much comfort in the face of the death of loved ones, because in such times, it is our hope that this is who God would be to us. What we really need is the love of God.

The love of God was best exemplified by Jesus, the fulfillment of all the redemptive names of God, and, by the design of God, our Good Shepherd:

'The thief comes only to steal and kill and destroy. I came that they may have life and have it abundantly. I am the good shepherd. The good shepherd lays down his life for the sheep. He who is a hired hand and not a shepherd, who does not own the sheep, sees the wolf coming and leaves the sheep and flees, and the wolf snatches them and scatters them. He flees because he is a hired hand and cares nothing for the sheep. I am the good shepherd. I know my own and my own know me, just as the Father knows me and I know the Father; and I lay down my life for the sheep.'

John 10:10-15

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/JHN.10.10-15>

Jesus is Life (zōē, G2222). He came to give abundant (perissos, G4053) life through the laying down of His own life because He knows and cares for His sheep. Every

one of His sheep — each created in God's image and likeness, has value just a little lower than that of God (Psalm 8:5).

Jesus brought about God's will to redeem, establishing the channel of God to life, provision, peace, righteousness, victory, goodness, grace, mercy, and the love of God.

Day 20: Bless the Lord, O my soul

'Bless the Lord, O my soul, and all that is within me, bless his holy name! Bless the Lord, O my soul, and forget not all his benefits, who forgives all your iniquity, who heals all your diseases, who redeems your life from the pit, who crowns you with steadfast love and mercy, who satisfies you with good so that your youth is renewed like the eagle's. The Lord works righteousness and justice for all who are oppressed. He made known his ways to Moses, his acts to the people of Israel. The Lord is merciful and gracious, slow to anger and abounding in steadfast love. He will not always chide, nor will he keep his anger forever. He does not deal with us according to our sins, nor repay us according to our iniquities. For as high as the heavens are above the earth, so great is his steadfast love toward those who fear him; as far as the east is from the west, so far does he remove our transgressions from us. As a father shows compassion to his children, so the Lord shows compassion to those who fear him. For he knows our frame; he remembers that we are dust. As for man, his days are like grass; he flourishes like a flower of the field; for the wind passes over it, and it is gone, and its place knows it no more. But the steadfast love of the Lord is from everlasting to everlasting on those who fear him, and his righteousness to children's children, to those who keep his covenant and remember to do his commandments. The Lord has established his throne in the heavens, and his kingdom rules over all. Bless the Lord, O you his angels, you mighty ones who do his word, obeying the voice of his word! Bless the Lord, all his hosts, his ministers, who do his will! Bless the Lord, all his works, in all places of his dominion. Bless the Lord, O my soul!'

Psalms 103:1-22

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/PSA.103.1-22>

This is a beautiful song of praise written by David. He throws all of himself into worship.

There are five benefits of loving and choosing God listed by David.

First, God forgives His people's sin, making them righteous so they can have a close relationship with Him.

Second, God heals (râphâ', H7495) all of His people's diseases in accordance with His promise given when He revealed Himself as Jehovah Rapha, "the Lord your healer" (Exodus 15:22-27).

Third, He redeems (gâ'al, H1350) their lives from the pit. This is the full, life-giving salvation of God, more significant than bodily healing. Fourth, He crowns His people with steadfast love (chêsêd, H2617) and mercy (racham, H7356); it is in His nature as the covenant-keeping Creator. Fifth, God satisfies (śâba', H7646) His people with good (tôb, H2896) so that they are renewed.

David saw God as intrinsically good, always wanting to do good in any situation. Is this the way we see God?

"...The Lord works righteousness and justice for all who are oppressed. He made known his ways to Moses, his acts to the people of Israel. The Lord is merciful and gracious, slow to anger and abounding in steadfast love..."

God's heart is to bring freedom to the oppressed, making right what is wrong, and He works through His people to do it, as He did with Moses. God revealed His nature to Moses (Exodus 34:6-7), and David repeats it in this song of praise: righteousness (tsedâqâh, H6666), merciful (rachûm, H7349), gracious (channûn), slow to anger ('ârêk 'aph, H750+H639), abounding (rab, H7227) in steadfast love or lovingkindness (chêsêd).

"...He will not always chide, nor will he keep his anger forever. He does not deal with us according to our sins, nor repay us according to our iniquities..."

David may have written this psalm after he was pardoned from adultery with Bathsheba and murder of her husband (2 Samuel 12:13-15). While Psalm 51 seems to have been written before David's pardon, this psalm took a different tone of rejoicing in God's forgiveness, love (râcham, H7355). What a picture David painted of the mercy and steadfast love (chêsêd, H2617) of God for His children! David had been forgiven much.

"...For he knows our frame; he remembers that we are dust. As for man, his days are like grass; he flourishes like a flower of the field; for the wind passes over it,

and it is gone, and its place knows it no more. But the steadfast love of the Lord is from everlasting to everlasting on those who fear him, and his righteousness to children's children, to those who keep his covenant and remember to do his commandments..."

David beautifully described how the eternal love of the covenant-keeping (berîth shâmar, H1285+H8104) God gives hope to mankind despite the apparent frailty of life. God's people can always look forward to being at the receiving end of the generosity of the all powerful God. We have framed with purpose (yêtsér, H3336) for our lives, and we have been made to flourish (tsûts, H6692)! We have been made to take on His beautiful character, to be doers of His word (Luke 6:46-48,8:21), and to enjoy life with Him as family members forever.

God is not the great I WAS nor the great I WILL BE. The God of David is still the living God, the great I AM (Genesis 15:1, Revelation 22:16).

"...The Lord has established his throne in the heavens, and his kingdom rules over all. Bless the Lord, O you his angels, you mighty ones who do his word, obeying the voice of his word!... Bless the Lord, O my soul!"

David rejoiced in the kingdom and the sovereignty of God, seeing himself again as a part of it after a very dark time in his life. Every part of his being joined the host of heaven in praise and adoration of the merciful, compassionate God who wills to do such good. God's spoken words are a mechanism to carry out His will.

David's passionate love toward God reflected in this psalm is reminiscent of the adoration shown toward Jesus by the woman of the city, a sinner who wept on Jesus' feet, wiped His feet with her hair, kissed His feet, and anointed them with ointment from an alabaster flask she brought, as recorded in Luke 7:36-50. The words Jesus spoke about her are true also of David:

"Therefore I tell you, her sins, which are many, are forgiven — for she loved much. But he who is forgiven little, loves little."

Luke 7:47 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/luk.7.47.ESV>

"Bless the Lord , O my soul, and all that is within me, bless his holy name!"

Day 21: Psalm 139

'O Lord, you have searched me and known me! You know when I sit down and when I rise up; you discern my thoughts from afar. You search out my path and my lying down and are acquainted with all my ways. Even before a word is on my tongue, behold, O Lord, you know it altogether. You hem me in, behind and before, and lay your hand upon me. Such knowledge is too wonderful for me; it is high; I cannot attain it. Where shall I go from your Spirit? Or where shall I flee from your presence? If I ascend to heaven, you are there! If I make my bed in Sheol, you are there! If I take the wings of the morning and dwell in the uttermost parts of the sea, even there your hand shall lead me, and your right hand shall hold me. If I say, "Surely the darkness shall cover me, and the light about me be night," even the darkness is not dark to you; the night is bright as the day, for darkness is as light with you. For you formed my inward parts; you knitted me together in my mother's womb. I praise you, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Wonderful are your works; my soul knows it very well. My frame was not hidden from you, when I was being made in secret, intricately woven in the depths of the earth. Your eyes saw my unformed substance; in your book were written, every one of them, the days that were formed for me, when as yet there was none of them. How precious to me are your thoughts, O God! How vast is the sum of them! If I would count them, they are more than the sand. I awake, and I am still with you. Oh that you would slay the wicked, O God! O men of blood, depart from me! They speak against you with malicious intent; your enemies take your name in vain. Do I not hate those who hate you, O Lord? And do I not loathe those who rise up against you? I hate them with complete hatred; I count them my enemies. Search me, O God, and know my heart! Try me and know my thoughts! And see if there be any grievous way in me, and lead me in the way everlasting!'

Psalm 139:1-24

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/PSA.139.1-24>

David may have written this psalm after he was made king over all of Israel and Judah, upon his second defeat of the Philistines (1 Chronicles 11-14, 2 Samuel 5).

This emotional song prompted by God's Spirit conveys the intimacy of God's relationship with men and women, each made in His image and likeness, each

created unique in spirit, soul and body. God is all knowing, and He concerns Himself in the details of our lives. David marveled at this truth.

God's people are unlike God in that He is omniscient and omnipresent, capable of knowing (yâda', H3045) everyone and being present anywhere, and He is not bound by time, having created it. The Spirit of God also has all knowledge and wisdom. God has given men and women each some measure of knowledge and wisdom that operates as part of the mind and body. God also gives some of His own wisdom, knowledge, and discernment of the spiritual to some as gifts of His Spirit (1 Corinthians 12:8-10). We know that David was one who had such inspiration from the Spirit of God because a number of his psalms have within them prophecies of the life of Jesus Christ (e.g., Psalm 16:9-11; Psalm 22:1, 15-16,18; Psalm 31:5; Psalm 40:6-8; Psalm 41:9; Psalm 69:21).

David imagined that God had discerned his thoughts from afar. Really God connects to and communicates with His people though through the spirit He has put inside of each one of them. Just as the temple of God in the Old Testament had three regions — an outer court, an inner court, and the holy of holies, we also have three parts, respectively: our body, our soul, and our spirit. The soul is the interface between the body and the spirit, including our mind, will, and emotions. The heavenly may just be another dimension or dimensions of reality which, unlike our bodies and this world in its present form, will persist.

What we think about is important because God desires our attention and our love. Our thoughts are important because they lead to what we say, how we choose to act, the habits we form (our ways), and the good we do. God is good and God is love, so when we do good motivated by love, this brings pleasure to God (1 Corinthians 13:13).

"...Where shall I go from your Spirit? Or where shall I flee from your presence?..."

The presence of the Spirit of God is beautiful because God always goes with His people. They are never alone. David marveled also at this truth.

'...If I say, "Surely the darkness shall cover me, and the light about me be night," even the darkness is not dark to you...'

Additionally, God is not constrained to taking in the world through senses as we are, our vision included. To God there is no darkness or light. Apart from anything that may be spiritually understood, we are the only ones limited to what we can understand through sense knowledge and reason.

"...For you formed my inward parts; you knitted me together in my mother's womb. I praise you, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made...."

David understood each human life as a wonderful (pâlâh, H6395), intricate work of God as Creator, each knit together in a mother's womb. God is Life (zōē, G2222), and He gives life out of His generous nature. Each life has such high value, precious to God, made in His image and likeness, bringing Him glory. It is God's Spirit (Rûach, H7307, also referred to as breath or wind) that both enables and sustains life. In God's knowledge and existence outside of time, God has formed not only each person as His handiwork (poiēma, G4161) but also the days of their lives (Ephesians 2:10). David rejoiced in the living God, desiring to know Him and make Him known, even as he was fully known (1 Corinthians 13:12).

"...Oh that you would slay the wicked, O God! ..."

David's song also shows that he understood his strength and power were not from him or his kingdom but from abiding with God his Creator. David had made God's enemies — those who spoke against God and took His name in vain — his enemies, and he asked God to slay them. David hated evil, or that which opposes God. Followers of Jesus Christ are still called to hate evil (Romans 12:9), yet also to love their enemies (Matthew 5:44).

"...Search me, O God, and know my heart! Try me and know my thoughts! And see if there be any grievous way in me, and lead me in the way everlasting!"

It seems that (most of the time) David continually examined his life, concluding this psalm by asking God to search him and to lead him, fusing his thoughts (rêa', H7454) and consciousness with God, aligning him with God's ways. David's attention was principally on God, desiring to be hemmed in, behind and before, one with God. David's heart was after God's own heart, his soul aligned to allow the Spirit of God to live and work through him. He sought to be a co-worker with God to accomplish His purposes (see also 1 Corinthians 3:9).

Day 22: Life in the Word of God

Psalm 119 was a special psalm to William Wilberforce, leader of the movement to abolish the slave trade, who used to recite the psalm as he walked from Parliament through Hyde Park to his home.

There is also a tradition within the church which holds that this acrostic poem was used by David to teach Solomon about the alphabet (from Aleph to Taw) and also about the ways of God. This may also be believable in view of his son Solomon's statement, ' "When I was a son with my father, tender, the only one in the sight of my mother, he taught me and said to me, "Let your heart hold fast my words; keep my commandments, and live..." ' (Proverbs 4:3-4).

Since Psalm 119 is the longest chapter of the Bible, it will not be reproduced here in its entirety.

'Blessed are the undefiled in the way, Who walk in the law of the LORD. Blessed are they that keep his testimonies, And that seek him with the whole heart...
Wherewithal shall a young man cleanse his way? By taking heed thereto according to thy word. With my whole heart have I sought thee: O let me not wander from thy commandments. Thy word have I hid in mine heart, That I might not sin against thee... I have rejoiced in the way of thy testimonies, As much as in all riches. I will meditate in thy precepts, And have respect unto thy ways. I will delight myself in thy statutes: I will not forget thy word. Deal bountifully with thy servant, That I may live, and keep thy word. Open thou mine eyes, That I may behold wondrous things out of thy law... My soul cleaveth unto the dust: Quicken thou me according to thy word. I have declared my ways, and thou heardest me: Teach me thy statutes. Make me to understand the way of thy precepts: So shall I talk of thy wondrous works. My soul melteth for heaviness: Strengthen thou me according unto thy word... Turn away mine eyes from beholding vanity; And quicken thou me in thy way. Stablish thy word Unto thy servant, who is devoted to thy fear. Turn away my reproach which I fear: For thy judgments are good. Behold, I have longed after thy precepts: Quicken me in thy righteousness. Let thy mercies come also unto me, O LORD, Even thy salvation, according to thy word... I will speak of thy testimonies also before kings, And will not be ashamed. And I will

delight myself In thy commandments, which I have loved. My hands also will I lift up unto thy commandments, which I have loved; And I will meditate in thy statutes. Remember the word unto thy servant, Upon which thou hast caused me to hope. This is my comfort in my affliction: For thy word hath quickened me... Let thy tender mercies come unto me, that I may live: For thy law is my delight... Quicken me after thy lovingkindness; So shall I keep the testimony of thy mouth. Forever, O LORD, Thy word Is settled in heaven. Thy faithfulness is unto all generations: Thou hast established the earth, and it abideth. They continue this day according to thine ordinances: For all are thy servants. Unless thy law had been my delights, I should then have perished in mine affliction. I will never forget thy precepts: For with them thou hast quickened me... How sweet are thy words unto my taste! Yea, sweeter than honey to my mouth! Through thy precepts I get understanding: Therefore I hate every false way. Thy word is a lamp unto my feet, And a light unto my path. I have sworn, and I will perform it, That I will keep thy righteous judgments. I am afflicted very much: Quicken me, O LORD, according unto thy word... Thou art my hiding place and my shield: I hope in thy word... Order my steps in thy word: And let not any iniquity have dominion over me... Thy word is very pure: Therefore thy servant loveth it. I am small and despised: Yet do not I forget thy precepts. Thy righteousness is an everlasting righteousness, And thy law is the truth... Hear my voice according unto thy lovingkindness: O LORD, quicken me according to thy judgment... Plead my cause, and deliver me: Quicken me according to thy word. Salvation is far from the wicked: For they seek not thy statutes. Great are thy tender mercies, O LORD: Quicken me according to thy judgments. Many are my persecutors and mine enemies; Yet do I not decline from thy testimonies. I beheld the transgressors, and was grieved; Because they kept not thy word. Consider how I love thy precepts: Quicken me, O LORD, according to thy lovingkindness. Thy word is true from the beginning: And every one of thy righteous judgments endureth forever... Seven times a day do I praise thee Because of thy righteous judgments. Great peace have they which love thy law: And nothing shall offend them.

Psalms

119:1-2,9-11,14-18,25-28,37-41,46-50,77,88-93,103-107,114,133,140-142,149,154-160,164-165

<https://my.bible.com/bible/1/PSA.119.1-2,9-11,14-18,25-28,37-41,46-50,58-62,77,88-93,103-107,114,133,140-142,149,154-160,164-165>

“Blessed are the undefiled in the way, Who walk in the law of the LORD. Blessed are they that keep his testimonies, And that seek him with the whole heart...”

The author of this psalm greatly cherished the words (dâbâr, H1697) of the Lord at heart (lêb, H3820). God's words are also called His law (tôrah, H8451), His testimonies ('êdâh, H5713), and His judgements (mishpât, H4941). The psalmist saw God as wrapped up in the words He spoke, which is understandable, and believed God's words to man to be the source of wholeness (tâmîym, H8549), and the source of all blessing ('esher, H835) from God to provide everything good to His children in His kingdom.

Faith in God's word was the channel of Life following the disobedience of Adam, which had brought death. It was true when this psalm was written three thousand years ago, and it continues to be true in that Jesus Christ is the Word of God made flesh (John 1:14).

“...Wherewithal shall a young man cleanse his way? By taking heed thereto according to thy word. With my whole heart have I sought thee: O let me not wander from thy commandments. Thy word have I hid in mine heart, That I might not sin against thee...”

The psalmist desired to be close to the love and the heart of God. God is holy and righteous, and only those who are in right standing with God can be close to Him. Sin comes from not believing the Word of God and acting on it, which means one is choosing one's own way or the devil's way over God's way. The psalmist believed that God's words (dâbâr, H1697; 'imrâh, H565) and ways were those of Life (châyâh, H2421). Jesus said that those who hunger and thirst for righteousness shall be filled and the pure in heart shall see God (Matthew 5:6,8). In fact, in Christ we are richly filled with the Word of God who dwells in us (Colossians 3:16), and we are hid (tsâphan, H6845; kruptō, G2928) in Him (Colossians 3:3).

“...I have rejoiced in the way of thy testimonies, As much as in all riches. I will meditate in thy precepts, And have respect unto thy ways. I will delight myself in thy statutes: I will not forget thy word. Deal bountifully with thy servant, That I may live, and keep thy word. Open thou mine eyes, That I may behold wondrous things out of thy law...”

The psalmist saw God's Word as a rare treasure of the greatest value, the revelation of truth and wisdom from God. It was ever on his mind, and it was his delight (shâ'a', H8173). Jesus spoke of the kingdom of heaven as such, a rare treasure (Matthew 13:44-45). The psalmist believed that in seeking God through His Word, God would open his eyes for him to discover wondrous things (pâlâ', H6381). He believed that God rewards those who seek (dârash, H1875; ekzēteō, G1567) Him (Hebrews 11:6).

"...My soul cleaveth unto the dust: Quicken thou me according to thy word. I have declared my ways, and thou heardest me: Teach me thy statutes. Make me to understand the way of thy precepts: So shall I talk of thy wondrous works. My soul melteth for heaviness: Strengthen thou me according unto thy word..."

The Word of God is the blueprint for the development of any human life according to God's ways, from their first physical creation as a seed, to being made eternal (an imperishable seed, 1 Peter 1:23), to being made like Jesus Christ in fullness (plērōma, G4138) as part of the body of Christ (Ephesians 4:13). The psalmist prayed to be quickened (i.e., to be given more of God's Life; châyâh, H2421) according to the Word of God. He asked to understand God's Word and ways so he could speak of God's wondrous works (pâlâ', H6381). He asked also to be strengthened (qûm, H6965) according to His Word. Since God's Word is the source of Life, it is also the source of strength. This song is emotional! It was also likely a model for David to teach his son to worship, to pray, and to delight in God's word.

"...Turn away mine eyes from beholding vanity; And quicken thou me in thy way. Stablish thy word Unto thy servant, who is devoted to thy fear. Turn away my reproach which I fear: For thy judgments are good. Behold, I have longed after thy precepts: Quicken me in thy righteousness. Let thy mercies come also unto me, O LORD, Even thy salvation, according to thy word..."

The psalmist asked God's help to turn his eyes away from pride in himself and his achievements, from any worthless things, focusing his attention on God's way. He asked to be given Life (châyâh, H2421) in the ways the Giver gives Life — in abundance (John 10:10-11), in every way (2 Corinthians 9:10-11). In asking for Life, he asked God to confirm (qûm, H6965) the promises of His Word to him, knowing this would bring good to him (2 Corinthians 1:20).

He asked to be quickened by God yet again, bringing him righteousness (tsedâqâh, H6666), the mercies (chêsêd, H2617) of God, and salvation (teshû'âh, H8668), according to the blueprint and plan of God for His children. This psalmist knew what to ask (aiteō, G154) of God according to His will, and how to seek (zêteō, G2212) it — persistently, taking it (lambanō, G2983), even as Jesus taught, ' "Ask, and it will be given to you; seek, and you will find; knock, and it will be opened to you. For everyone who asks receives, and the one who seeks finds, and to the one who knocks it will be opened. Or which one of you, if his son asks him for bread, will give him a stone? Or if he asks for a fish, will give him a serpent? If you then, who are evil, know how to give good gifts to your children, how much more will your Father who is in heaven give good things to those who ask him! ' Matthew 7:7-11

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/MAT.7.7-11>

"...I will speak of thy testimonies also before kings, And will not be ashamed. And I will delight myself In thy commandments, which I have loved. My hands also will I lift up unto thy commandments, which I have loved; And I will meditate in thy statutes. Remember the word unto thy servant, Upon which thou hast caused me to hope. This is my comfort in my affliction: For thy word hath quickened me..."

William Wilberforce spoke up about what was right before the kings of his time, as it were, and he was not ashamed, perhaps having been encouraged by this psalmist. This yielded fruit in an amazing way, bringing more of God's freedom to the nations. God's people should also speak up about what God's Word says and not be ashamed. As our example, Jesus went to public places where He spoke up and spoke openly, even as He told Pilate when confronted by him (John 18:20).

It is clear that the hope (yâchal, H3176) of this psalmist was the Word of God. He loved it and so he intentionally soaked it in, waiting on God to confirm it. It was his comfort in any affliction. The Word of God quickened (châyâh, H2421) him, giving him the Life only God can give as he needed it. He reformed his notions to harmonize with the Word. He assimilated God's faith, hope, and love expressed in God's Word.

*“...Let thy tender mercies come unto me, that I may live: For thy law is my delight...
Quicken me after thy lovingkindness; So shall I keep the testimony of thy mouth.
Forever, O LORD, Thy word is settled in heaven. Thy faithfulness is unto all
generations: Thou hast established the earth, and it abideth. They continue this
day according to thine ordinances: For all are thy servants. Unless thy law had
been my delights, I should then have perished in mine affliction. I will never forget
thy precepts: For with them thou hast quickened me...”*

The psalmist always delighted in God's Life-giving Word as He delighted in God himself. He believed that it was the mercy in the nature of God that allowed him to continue to live despite his affliction. The psalmist then asked again to be given life (châyâh, H2421) by God, according to His character of lovingkindness (chêsêd, H2617), so he could live his life according to the blueprint of God for mankind, His Word.

God's Word quickened (châyâh, H2421) the psalmist in his affliction ('onîy, H6040). This is a legal matter: “Thy word is settled in heaven.” Here is part of God's Word to His people that the psalmist knew to be settled in heaven:

“...“If thou wilt diligently hearken to the voice of the LORD thy God, and wilt do that which is right in his sight, and wilt give ear to his commandments, and keep all his statutes, I will put none of these diseases upon thee, which I have brought upon the Egyptians: for I am the LORD that healeth thee.”

Exodus 15:26

<https://my.bible.com/bible/1/EXO.15.26>

Throughout this psalm, the author continued to describe how he met the conditions for this promise, and he took this promise to be accomplished. To be quickened (chêsêd, H2617) in body is to be healed (râphâ', H7495). God's promises to the righteous are unbreakable. God's Word always does what it is sent to do, including overcoming any affliction. (As the psalmist held onto the promise in God's Word, the affliction had no legal right to remain in him.) There is nothing that can stop it, for it overpowers any evil.

Faithful to God as a servant, God's Word created and gave life, and it sustains the earth and all of the life therein. The Apostle Paul described God's creation by way of His Word the following way:

“...even God, who quickeneth the dead, and calleth those things which be not as though they were. “

Romans 4:17b

<https://my.bible.com/bible/1/ROM.4.17>

It is God that causes the dead to live (zōopoieō, G2227) by His Word, calling (kaleō, G2564) things into existence and expecting them to be as He has called them. His word is settled. This is the unwavering faith inherent to the nature of God.

God's words are His servants to accomplish His good will for His people, and His Word is also the Servant spoken of by Isaiah (especially in Isaiah 53) that would fully accomplish the fullness of His redemptive purposes. Redemption in Christ is also a process of God's quickening, as the Apostle Paul described:

“But God, who is rich in mercy, for his great love wherewith he loved us, even when we were dead in sins, hath quickened us together with Christ, (by grace ye are saved;) “

Ephesians 2:4-5

<https://my.bible.com/bible/1/EPH.2.4-5>

Though our spirits were dead before salvation, by grace we have been quickened together with (suzōopoieō, G4806) Christ! (See also Romans 8:10-11). In Christ, we have been made righteous (1 Corinthians 1:30), and so all of God's promises are for us (2 Corinthians 1:19-20).

“...How sweet are thy words unto my taste! Yea, sweeter than honey to my mouth! Through thy precepts I get understanding: Therefore I hate every false way. Thy word is a lamp unto my feet, And a light unto my path. I have sworn, and I will perform it, That I will keep thy righteous judgments. I am afflicted very much: Quicken me, O LORD, according unto thy word...”

The psalmist believed God's Word was both life-giving and light-giving. It quickened (châyâh, H2421), it gave understanding (bîyn, H995), and it guided. Through the life- and light-giving Word, he knew right from wrong (see also Hebrews 4:12), and so he hated every false way because he loved the way of God. In asking to be quickened, He asked for God's good will to be accomplished in his life through the power of God. He trusted that affliction was not in God's blueprint for the abundant Life God offers for a follower of His, so God would replace it with His Life.

"...Thou art my hiding place and my shield: I hope in thy word... Order my steps in thy word: And let not any iniquity have dominion over me... Thy word is very pure: Therefore thy servant loveth it. I am small and despised: Yet do not I forget thy precepts. Thy righteousness is an everlasting righteousness, And thy law is the truth... Hear my voice according unto thy lovingkindness: O LORD, quicken me according to thy judgment..."

The first section here is reminiscent of the following section of another psalm of David:

'You are a hiding place for me; you preserve me from trouble; you surround me with shouts of deliverance. Selah '

Psalm 32:7

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/PSA.32.7>

The psalmist had faith in God's protection for His people. The Lord is a covenant-keeping God. In steadfast faith, the psalmist had hope (yâchal, H3176) in the strength and the power of God to make him victorious over the dominion (shâlat, H7980) of sin and also over any effects of the fall. The righteous God is always victorious over any evil. Righteousness (tsedâqâh, H6666) like that of God is also the blueprint of God for every life (Leviticus 21:8, Exodus 19:6, 1 Corinthians 2:16, 2 Corinthians 5:21).

Next, the psalmist asked yet again to be quickened (châyâh, H2421) according to God's Word (mishpât, H4941) and His lovingkindness (chêsêd, H2617). This is what he saw that he needed: more of the Life God gives according to His Word and His nature.

"...Plead my cause, and deliver me: Quicken me according to thy word. Salvation is far from the wicked: For they seek not thy statutes. Great are thy tender mercies, O LORD: Quicken me according to thy judgments. Many are my persecutors and mine enemies; Yet do I not decline from thy testimonies. I beheld the transgressors, and was grieved; Because they kept not thy word. Consider how I love thy precepts: Quicken me, O LORD, according to thy lovingkindness. Thy word is true from the beginning: And every one of thy righteous judgments endureth for ever..."

The psalmist trusted his cause to God, expecting in faith to be delivered (gā'al, H1350), quickened (châyâh, H2421), and saved (yeshû'âh, H3444). In His compassion (racham, H7356), this is what God does for His people. This is what God sent His Word, even in the flesh, to do: to deliver and to quicken (Matthew 8:17, Luke 4:18-19, John 6:63, Acts 10:38, Romans 8:11, Ephesians 2:4-7, 1 John 3:8). The following statement summarizes the prayer of this psalmist very well: "Quicken me according to thy word." He saw God's giving of Life — in every way He gives Life — in keeping with God's lovingkindness (chêsêd, H2617); it is God's will and His design. God's Life-giving Word endures forever.

"...Seven times a day do I praise thee Because of thy righteous judgments. Great peace have they which love thy law: And nothing shall offend them"

The psalmist kept God's law ever on his mind throughout the day, stopping to praise God seven times a day. Scripture records that Daniel prayed three times a day, giving thanks as he did (Daniel 6:10). Further, Jesus set a model for personal prayer to the Father, teaching His disciples to start prayer with praise (Matthew 6:9).

The psalmist said that loving God's Word brings one abounding peace (shâlôm, H7965). Lovers of God's Word have such peace that nothing shall offend (mikshôl, H4383) them. They do not take offense. As lovers of God and servants of mankind, they refuse to take offense. This is counter cultural. Yet they do not compromise the truth of the Word of God because they love God and His Word. Jesus Christ, the Word of God made flesh, embodied this same attitude (e.g., Matthew 5:38-48; 15:1-9; 21:12-17; 22:23-33; 23:1-38), and, abiding in Him (John 15:1), we are predestined to become like Him (Romans 8:29).

Day 23: A psalm about the steadfast love of the Lord

' Oh give thanks to the Lord, for he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever! Let the redeemed of the Lord say so, whom he has redeemed from trouble and gathered in from the lands, from the east and from the west, from the north and from the south. Some wandered in desert wastes, finding no way to a city to dwell in; hungry and thirsty, their soul fainted within them. Then they cried to the Lord in their trouble, and he delivered them from their distress. He led them by a straight way till they reached a city to dwell in. Let them thank the Lord for his steadfast love, for his wondrous works to the children of man! For he satisfies the longing soul, and the hungry soul he fills with good things. Some sat in darkness and in the shadow of death, prisoners in affliction and in irons, for they had rebelled against the words of God, and spurned the counsel of the Most High. So he bowed their hearts down with hard labor; they fell down, with none to help. Then they cried to the Lord in their trouble, and he delivered them from their distress. He brought them out of darkness and the shadow of death, and burst their bonds apart. Let them thank the Lord for his steadfast love, for his wondrous works to the children of man! For he shatters the doors of bronze and cuts in two the bars of iron. Some were fools through their sinful ways, and because of their iniquities suffered affliction; they loathed any kind of food, and they drew near to the gates of death. Then they cried to the Lord in their trouble, and he delivered them from their distress. He sent out his word and healed them, and delivered them from their destruction. Let them thank the Lord for his steadfast love, for his wondrous works to the children of man! And let them offer sacrifices of thanksgiving, and tell of his deeds in songs of joy! Some went down to the sea in ships, doing business on the great waters; they saw the deeds of the Lord, his wondrous works in the deep. For he commanded and raised the stormy wind, which lifted up the waves of the sea. They mounted up to heaven; they went down to the depths; their courage melted away in their evil plight; they reeled and staggered like drunken men and were at their wits' end. Then they cried to the Lord in their trouble, and he delivered them from their distress. He made the storm be still, and the waves of the sea were hushed. Then they were glad that the waters were quiet, and he brought them to their desired haven. Let them thank the Lord for his steadfast love, for his wondrous works to the children of man! Let them extol him in the congregation of the people, and praise him in the assembly

of the elders. He turns rivers into a desert, springs of water into thirsty ground, a fruitful land into a salty waste, because of the evil of its inhabitants. He turns a desert into pools of water, a parched land into springs of water. And there he lets the hungry dwell, and they establish a city to live in; they sow fields and plant vineyards and get a fruitful yield. By his blessing they multiply greatly, and he does not let their livestock diminish. When they are diminished and brought low through oppression, evil, and sorrow, he pours contempt on princes and makes them wander in trackless wastes; but he raises up the needy out of affliction and makes their families like flocks. The upright see it and are glad, and all wickedness shuts its mouth. Whoever is wise, let him attend to these things; let them consider the steadfast love of the Lord .'

Psalms 107:1-43

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/PSA.107.1-43>

This psalm of David gives thanks to the Lord six times for His steadfast love (chêsêd, H2617). God described Himself through Moses as the God "showing steadfast love to thousands of those who love me and keep my commandments" (Exodus 20:6) and "abounding in steadfast love and faithfulness, keeping steadfast love for thousands" (Exodus 34:6-7).

The steadfast love of the Lord endures forever. It redeems those who love God. The redemption (gô'al, H1350) of the Lord saved God's people from trouble. It provided them a city to dwell in where their needs were provided. God satisfied their needs with good, both their physical needs and their souls longing for God.

The steadfast love of Lord produces the same for His church today — those who love Him, even as the Apostle John wrote, 'Beloved, I wish above all things that thou mayest prosper and be in health, even as thy soul prospereth. '

3 John 1:2

<https://my.bible.com/bible/1/3JN.1.2>

"...Some sat in darkness and in the shadow of death, prisoners in affliction and in irons, for they had rebelled against the words of God..."

The redemption of the Lord brings freedom, even as the Israelites experienced freedom from the slavery in Egypt. Darkness, death and bondage come from sin, choosing one's own way rather than following the words of God. Evil can then take a toehold, a foothold (topos, G5117, Ephesians 4:27), a stronghold (ochurōroma, G3794, 2 Corinthians 10:4-5), even a chokehold. In steadfast love (chêsêd, H2617), God responds to the earnest prayers of His people with extraordinary works (pâlâ', H6381), bringing deliverance (yâsha', H3467) from any oppression. The steadfast love of God restores light in darkness.

"...Some were fools through their sinful ways, and because of their iniquities suffered affliction; they loathed any kind of food, and they drew near to the gates of death. Then they cried to the Lord in their trouble, and he delivered them from their distress. He sent out his word and healed them..."

The redemption of the Lord brings healing (râphâ', H7495), sent out (shâlach, H7971) by God's word (dâbâr, H1697), from any affliction ('ânâh, H6031). In steadfast love (chêsêd, H2617), God responds to the fervent prayers (energeō deēsis, G1754+G1162) of His people, bringing deliverance (mâlat, H4422) from any distress or destruction (James 5:16-17). Freedom comes by way of the words of God, His servants, which do not return to Him empty (Isaiah 55:11). God brings Life in every way, quickening His people through His word (Psalm 119:88-89,107; also of David) because He is Life itself. He gives Life, whereas the thief comes only to steal, kill and destroy (John 10:10). God's people can be confident that God will hear them, even as Christ was (John 11:41). Thanks be to God, who in Christ always leads His people in triumphal procession, and through them spreads the fragrance of Him everywhere (2 Corinthians 2:14-15). The Lord truly is a God full of compassion, and gracious, longsuffering, and plenteous in mercy and truth (Psalm 86:15; also of David).

"...Some went down to the sea in ships, doing business on the great waters; they saw the deeds of the Lord, his wondrous works in the deep. For he commanded and raised the stormy wind, which lifted up the waves of the sea. They mounted up to heaven; they went down to the depths; their courage melted away in their evil plight; they reeled and staggered like drunken men and were at their wits' end. Then they cried to the Lord in their trouble, and he delivered them from

their distress. He made the storm be still, and the waves of the sea were hushed. Then they were glad that the waters were quiet, and he brought them to their desired haven..."

The redemption of the Lord brings physical protection to His people, even as it often did for David throughout his life. This enables God's people to take heart in the midst of danger. The Apostle Paul showed great faith in the midst of danger when he was about to be shipwrecked at Malta (Acts 27:13-44). He exhibited courage and saved the lives of many on the ship bound for Rome.

The text from the psalm above could have quite literally played out when Jesus, crossing the Sea of Galilee with his disciples, calmed the waters by His authority, as Mark recorded:

'And a great windstorm arose, and the waves were breaking into the boat, so that the boat was already filling. But he was in the stern, asleep on the cushion. And they woke him and said to him, "Teacher, do you not care that we are perishing?" And he awoke and rebuked the wind and said to the sea, "Peace! Be still!" And the wind ceased, and there was a great calm. He said to them, "Why are you so afraid? Have you still no faith?" And they were filled with great fear and said to one another, "Who then is this, that even the wind and the sea obey him?"'

Mark 4:37-41

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/MRK.4.37-41>

The steadfast love (chêsêd, H2617) of God preserves the lives of His people. The words of God accomplish this — in this case, it was the words of Jesus: "Be still!"

"...Let them thank the Lord for his steadfast love, for his wondrous works to the children of man! Let them extol him in the congregation of the people, and praise him in the assembly of the elders..."

Just as the disciples were amazed at Jesus' authority, so ought God's people be amazed at Him, joining the praise of the assembly in heaven: "Worthy is the Lamb that was slain to receive power, and riches, and wisdom, and strength, and honour, and glory, and blessing. And every creature which is in heaven, and on the earth, and under the earth, and such as are in the sea, and all that are in them, heard I saying, Blessing, and honour, and glory, and power, be unto him that sitteth upon the throne, and unto the Lamb for ever and ever. "

Revelation 5:12-13

"...He turns rivers into a desert, springs of water into thirsty ground, a fruitful land into a salty waste, because of the evil of its inhabitants. He turns a desert into pools of water, a parched land into springs of water. And there he lets the hungry dwell, and they establish a city to live in; they sow fields and plant vineyards and get a fruitful yield. By his blessing they multiply greatly... Whoever is wise, let him attend to these things; let them consider the steadfast love of the Lord."

The redemption of the Lord yields abundant life. God makes streams of life flow from the hearts of those who belong to Him (Proverbs 4:23, John 7:38). God multiplies (râbâh, H7235; plēthunō, G4129) His grace and peace (2 Peter 1:2) to those who hold steadfast to Him in love. If His people keep the soil of their soul (the seat of the mind, will and emotions) fertile through an active, steadfast love for God and others, not letting the cares of the world interfere, then the seed they receive is greatly multiplied, producing a fruitful (karpophoreō, G2592) yield (see also Matthew 13:22-23).

The love of the Lord is steadfast for those who love Him and stay committed to Him, and the wide channel of God's great love carries with it the goodness of God and abundant life in free flow. The steadfast love of the Lord is so good that it is worth shouting about in praise (terû'âh, H8643), according to David (Psalm 33:1-3).

Day 24: Proverbs of Solomon

Selections from a couple of Solomon's proverbs are given below:

"My son, do not forget my teaching, but let your heart keep my commandments, for length of days and years of life and peace they will add to you. Let not steadfast love and faithfulness forsake you; bind them around your neck; write them on the tablet of your heart. So you will find favor and good success in the sight of God and man. Trust in the Lord with all your heart, and do not lean on your own understanding. In all your ways acknowledge him, and he will make straight your paths. Be not wise in your own eyes; fear the Lord, and turn away from evil. It will be healing to your flesh and refreshment to your bones. Honor the Lord with your wealth and with the firstfruits of all your produce; then your barns will be filled with plenty, and your vats will be bursting with wine. My son, do not despise the Lord's discipline or be weary of his reproof, for the Lord reproves him whom he loves, as a father the son in whom he delights."

Proverbs 3:1-12 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/pro.3.1-12.ESV>

"When I was a son with my father, tender, the only one in the sight of my mother, he taught me and said to me, "Let your heart hold fast my words; keep my commandments, and live... My son, be attentive to my words; incline your ear to my sayings. Let them not escape from your sight; keep them within your heart. For they are life to those who find them, and healing to all their flesh. Keep your heart with all vigilance, for from it flow the springs of life."

Proverbs 4:3-4, 20-23 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/pro.4.3-23.ESV>

These selections from the proverbs written by Solomon follow well after David's psalms. Solomon was known for his great knowledge, having asked God for an understanding mind to govern his people and received a wise and discerning mind in response (1 Kings 3:5-15). According to the selection from Proverbs 4, he was also carefully taught the words of God by his father, David.

"My son, do not forget my teaching, but let your heart keep my commandments, for length of days and years of life and peace they will add to you. Let not steadfast love and faithfulness forsake you; bind them around your neck; write them on the tablet of your heart. So you will find favor and good success in the sight of God and man. Trust in the Lord with all your heart, and do not lean on your own understanding. In all your ways acknowledge him, and he will make straight your paths."

Solomon believed that long life and peace (shâlôm, H7965) resulted from keeping God's commandments (mitsvâh, H4687). He pursued knowledge (yâda', H3045) of, steadfast love (chêsêd, H2617) for, and faithfulness ('emeth, H571) to the covenant-keeping God as his fathers had, believing that favor (chên, H2580), rightness (yâshar, H3474), and blessing resulted from it.

The heart (lêb, H3820) refers to the soul, that interface between the human spirit and body which includes the personality, mind, emotions and will. By the design of God, it is under the control of each person.

Solomon gave counsel to write the word of God on the tablet of one's heart. Through continued meditation on them, God's cherished words should come to be written on one's mind. The apostle Paul referred to this as renewing (anakainōsis, G342; ananēōō, G365) one's mind (nous, G3563) to the word of God: 'Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewal of your mind, that by testing you may discern what is the will of God, what is good and acceptable and perfect.'

Romans 12:2

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/ROM.12.2>

Paul also spoke of it in the following way:

'to put off your old self, which belongs to your former manner of life and is corrupt through deceitful desires, and to be renewed in the spirit of your minds, and to put on the new self, created after the likeness of God in true righteousness and holiness.'

Ephesians 4:22-24

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/EPH.4.22-24>

God's people are to be transformed by the renewing of their minds that results from knowing, believing, confessing, and continually acting on the words of God. One with a renewed mind knows who they are: a child of God, made in His image and likeness — one of righteousness (dikaïosunē, G1343) and holiness (hosiōtēs,

G3742). One with a renewed mind (sōphronismos, G4995) chooses to believe and act on the truth revealed in God's Word rather than lies. One with a renewed mind trusts (bâtach, H982) the Lord with all of their heart (lêb, H3820), leaning not on their own understanding. One with a renewed mind walks in the will (thelēma, G2307) of God because their will has been purposely aligned with God's will. Such choices lead to a straight path and favor (chên, H2580) in the sight of God and man.

Solomon also wrote about God's Word (or words): *"It will be healing to your flesh and refreshment to your bones"* and *"For they are life to those who find them, and healing to all their flesh. Keep your heart with all vigilance, for from it flow the springs of life."* Just as his father David recorded healing (râphâ', H7495) from all disease (tachalû', H8463) and quickening (châyâh, H2421) in the midst of affliction ('onîy, H6040) as benefits (gemûl, H1576) of God's word and His nature of goodness and lovingkindness (chêsêd, H2617) in Psalms 103 and 119 (see Day 20 and Day 22), Solomon wrote in Proverbs 3 and 4 that God's words are the source of healing (riph'ûth, H7500; marpê', H4832) and life (châyâh, H2421; zōopoieō, G2227).

Jesus Christ, the Spirit-filled Word of God incarnate, always spoke the words of God, and so He spoke similarly when He said, 'It is the Spirit who gives life; the flesh is no help at all. The words that I have spoken to you are spirit and life. '

John 6:63

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/JHN.6.63>

and

'Whoever believes in me, as the Scripture has said, 'Out of his heart will flow rivers of living water.'"

John 7:38

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/JHN.7.38>

The life (zōē, G2222) that Jesus Christ offers (see also John 3:17, 10:10) to the children of God includes salvation and wholeness (sōzō, G4982); eternal life; reconciliation to God; favor; peace; and abundance.

"...Honor the Lord with your wealth and with the firstfruits of all your produce; then your barns will be filled with plenty, and your vats will be bursting with wine..."

God is generous and has been generous with His people, who were commanded to love God first (as discussed in reference to the first three commandments, see Day 6). Since His people were to be like Him, they were also to be generous and to give of their firstfruits. As discussed before in reference to Leviticus 19 (see Day 9), the giving of the Jews was to go to the marginalized, who were also loved by God, and also to the Levites (priests). The result of such obedience out of faith is to be provided for by the generosity of God. The Life-giving God is generous, and He wants those made in His image and likeness to be generous. The secret of living is giving — giving of oneself fully to God, and then, with open hands, giving of what God has given to them out of His great love.

Jesus Christ is the image of God and the ultimate example for God's church of the fullness of the Spirit of God in a man. Jesus is the church's example of doing good, living a life of compassion, and giving. Jesus instructed His disciples, "Freely as you have received, freely give" (Matthew 10:8). As we have freely and undeservedly (dōrean, G1432) received and taken (lambanō, G2983) from Jesus Christ, we are to freely (dōrean, G1432) and generously (haplotēs, G572, 2 Corinthians 9:11,13) give (didōmi, G1325). His example and His instructions are for every believer.

"...My son, do not despise the Lord's discipline or be weary of his reproof, for the Lord reproves him whom he loves, as a father the son in whom he delights..."

God gets intimately involved in the sacred process of the growth of His children into His glorious image and likeness (see also 2 Corinthians 3:18, Romans 8:29, Ephesians 2:10 Ephesians 4:13-16). After all, God designed the human parent-child relationship after another beautiful one: His relationship with each man and woman He created. He knows some wrong choices will be made, and still He works to shape each one for their good, even as a potter molds clay (Isaiah 64:8). God delights (râtsâh, H7521) in His children, wanting only the best for each one of them. God's will (thelēma, G2307) for each is good (agathos, G18) and it is perfect (teleios, G5046, see Romans 12:2), finishing each as a master work (ma'āśeh, H4639; poiēma, G4161).

Day 25: Elijah's faith

'Now Elijah the Tishbite, of Tishbe in Gilead, said to Ahab, "As the Lord, the God of Israel, lives, before whom I stand, there shall be neither dew nor rain these years, except by my word." And the word of the Lord came to him: "Depart from here and turn eastward and hide yourself by the brook Cherith, which is east of the Jordan. You shall drink from the brook, and I have commanded the ravens to feed you there." So he went and did according to the word of the Lord. He went and lived by the brook Cherith that is east of the Jordan. And the ravens brought him bread and meat in the morning, and bread and meat in the evening, and he drank from the brook. And after a while the brook dried up, because there was no rain in the land. Then the word of the Lord came to him, "Arise, go to Zarephath, which belongs to Sidon, and dwell there. Behold, I have commanded a widow there to feed you." So he arose and went to Zarephath. And when he came to the gate of the city, behold, a widow was there gathering sticks. And he called to her and said, "Bring me a little water in a vessel, that I may drink." And as she was going to bring it, he called to her and said, "Bring me a morsel of bread in your hand." And she said, "As the Lord your God lives, I have nothing baked, only a handful of flour in a jar and a little oil in a jug. And now I am gathering a couple of sticks that I may go in and prepare it for myself and my son, that we may eat it and die." And Elijah said to her, "Do not fear; go and do as you have said. But first make me a little cake of it and bring it to me, and afterward make something for yourself and your son. For thus says the Lord, the God of Israel, 'The jar of flour shall not be spent, and the jug of oil shall not be empty, until the day that the Lord sends rain upon the earth.'" And she went and did as Elijah said. And she and he and her household ate for many days. The jar of flour was not spent, neither did the jug of oil become empty, according to the word of the Lord that he spoke by Elijah. After this the son of the woman, the mistress of the house, became ill. And his illness was so severe that there was no breath left in him. And she said to Elijah, "What have you against me, O man of God? You have come to me to bring my sin to remembrance and to cause the death of my son!" And he said to her, "Give me your son." And he took him from her arms and carried him up into the upper chamber where he lodged, and laid him on his own bed. And he cried to the Lord, "O Lord my God, have you brought calamity even upon the widow with whom I sojourn, by killing her son?" Then he stretched himself upon the child three times

and cried to the Lord, "O Lord my God, let this child's life come into him again." And the Lord listened to the voice of Elijah. And the life of the child came into him again, and he revived. And Elijah took the child and brought him down from the upper chamber into the house and delivered him to his mother. And Elijah said, "See, your son lives." And the woman said to Elijah, "Now I know that you are a man of God, and that the word of the Lord in your mouth is truth."

1 Kings 17:1-24

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/1KI.17.1-24>

Elijah the prophet lived during the time of Ahab, King of Israel, who worshiped idols rather than God. In faith, Elijah declared to Ahab that it would not rain, speaking words (dâbâr, H1697) with the authority of the living God. James said that Elijah accomplished this through a fervent prayer of faith (James 5:17), and for three years and six months it did not rain. The Lord answered his prayer.

Next, Elijah heard from God regarding how God would provide for him and where he would be protected. Elijah trusted and obeyed the word of the Lord, not seeking to fend for himself. Consistent with His name given to Abraham, Jehovah Jireh, the Lord provided for Elijah's needs at the brook Cherith, east of the Jordan. In faith, he was protected from any harm there.

Next, God had a different purpose for Elijah, so He sent Elijah to a widow in Zarephath. At the opening of His public ministry to the Jews, Jesus was quick to point out that this widow was a Gentile (Luke 4:16-26). God is not a respecter of persons. The God of mercy has a heart for all of the marginalized including: the poor, the deaf, the blind, foreigners, the fatherless, and widows (Leviticus 6, Deuteronomy 26:12-13, Deuteronomy 27:19, see Day 9).

The widow was generous to care for Elijah, willing to give him the last meal she was going to prepare for herself and her son before they had nothing, expecting to starve to death in the midst of the famine. What!? God knew the heart of this woman; she had a heart of generosity like that of God, full of grace (gratuitous giving). God is a giver. The widow was beautiful in the image and likeness of God.

Telling the woman not to fear, Elijah the prophet, by the wisdom of God (1 Corinthians 12:8), spoke words from God:

“For thus says the Lord, the God of Israel, ‘The jar of flour shall not be spent, and the jug of oil shall not be empty, until the day that the Lord sends rain upon the earth.’”

Elijah stayed with the woman and her son, and the Lord provided for them there by way of the miraculous, even as they had faith that He would. The Spirit of God multiplied to provide food, even as Jesus did through His disciples to feed the multitudes (see Matthew 14:13-21). He who created the heavens and the earth also created food to meet the needs of the children of God. Jesus told his disciples to expect God to meet their needs in faith, not worrying about such things (Matthew 6:25-32): “But seek first the kingdom of God and his righteousness, and all these things will be added to you.”

Matthew 6:33

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/MAT.6.33>

Elijah sought (zēteō, G2222) first the kingdom (basilea, G932) of God and the righteousness (dikaïosunē, G1343) of God. He sought it also for this woman and her son. As a son of God and servant of man, he sought to make things right, depending on the God who was with him to bring victory while he took action. When Satan made a move to take the woman’s son, leaving no breath (neshâmâh, H5397) left in him, Elijah brought the kingdom (basilea, G932) of God to bear. He layed over the child and cried out (qârâ’, H7121) to God for life (châyâh, H2421), and God answered his fervent (energeō, G1752, James 5:16) prayer, bringing resurrection life (zōopoieō, G227) to the boy through the Spirit of God that was with Elijah. This was by the same Spirit of God that raised (egeirō, G1453) Jesus Christ from the dead (Romans 8:11).

In His righteousness, God is victorious over death. Elijah knew the righteousness of God, sought it first, and was made righteous through his steadfast faith. His actions springing from his faith brought God’s righteousness to the world around him, causing God’s kingdom to come and His will (thelēma, G2307) to be done on earth as it is in heaven (Matthew 6:10). God’s will is to give life and make things right in response to faith.

Day 26: Elijah's prayers for fire and rain answered

'Then Elijah said to all the people, "Come near to me." And all the people came near to him. And he repaired the altar of the Lord that had been thrown down. Elijah took twelve stones, according to the number of the tribes of the sons of Jacob, to whom the word of the Lord came, saying, "Israel shall be your name," and with the stones he built an altar in the name of the Lord. And he made a trench about the altar, as great as would contain two seahs of seed. And he put the wood in order and cut the bull in pieces and laid it on the wood. And he said, "Fill four jars with water and pour it on the burnt offering and on the wood." And he said, "Do it a second time." And they did it a second time. And he said, "Do it a third time." And they did it a third time. And the water ran around the altar and filled the trench also with water. And at the time of the offering of the oblation, Elijah the prophet came near and said, "O Lord, God of Abraham, Isaac, and Israel, let it be known this day that you are God in Israel, and that I am your servant, and that I have done all these things at your word. Answer me, O Lord, answer me, that this people may know that you, O Lord, are God, and that you have turned their hearts back." Then the fire of the Lord fell and consumed the burnt offering and the wood and the stones and the dust, and licked up the water that was in the trench. And when all the people saw it, they fell on their faces and said, "The Lord, he is God; the Lord, he is God." ...And Elijah said to Ahab, "Go up, eat and drink, for there is a sound of the rushing of rain." So Ahab went up to eat and to drink. And Elijah went up to the top of Mount Carmel. And he bowed himself down on the earth and put his face between his knees. And he said to his servant, "Go up now, look toward the sea." And he went up and looked and said, "There is nothing." And he said, "Go again," seven times. And at the seventh time he said, "Behold, a little cloud like a man's hand is rising from the sea." And he said, "Go up, say to Ahab, 'Prepare your chariot and go down, lest the rain stop you.'" And in a little while the heavens grew black with clouds and wind, and there was a great rain. And Ahab rode and went to Jezreel. And the hand of the Lord was on Elijah, and he gathered up his garment and ran before Ahab to the entrance of Jezreel.'

1 Kings 18:30-39, 41-46 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/1ki.18.30-46.ESV>

When Elijah met Ahab again after years of drought, the nation had turned against God, so he resolved to demonstrate to Israel that God was the true God, the only One worthy of worship. Elijah did this in a showdown that he arranged against the prophets of Baal at Mount Carmel:

“And you call upon the name of your god, and I will call upon the name of the Lord, and the God who answers by fire, he is God.” And all the people answered, “It is well spoken.””

1 Kings 18:24 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/1ki.18.24.ESV>

The prophets of Baal failed in the showdown because the false god had no power. Meanwhile, Elijah was confident God would answer:

“And at noon Elijah mocked them, saying, “Cry aloud, for he is a god. Either he is musing, or he is relieving himself, or he is on a journey, or perhaps he is asleep and must be awakened.””

1 Kings 18:27 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/1ki.18.27.ESV>

Elijah’s heart was fully devoted to God, and Elijah knew that the Spirit of God who had raised the boy to life through him would show Himself strong (châzaq, H2388, 2 Chronicles 16:9). In steadfast faith, he was confident that he would not be defeated — so confident that he made it impossible for the altar to be lit on fire by any natural means.

Elijah’s will had been aligned with God’s, and so he prayed, “O Lord, God of Abraham, Isaac, and Israel, let it be known this day that you are God in Israel, and that I am your servant, and that I have done all these things at your word.” And God answered Elijah’s fervent prayer in a marvelous, unmistakable way. This sign caused the Israelites to believe in God, bringing Him glory.

Elijah moved to then pray for rain. He was so confident God would answer, he twice told Ahab it would rain (1 Kings 18:41-45).

James, the brother of Jesus, explained what happened the following way:

"Elijah was a man with a nature like ours, and he prayed fervently that it might not rain, and for three years and six months it did not rain on the earth. Then he prayed again, and heaven gave rain, and the earth bore its fruit."

James 5:17-18 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/jas.5.17-18.ESV>

James explained to the early church that Elijah was a normal man (homoioopathēs, G3663). Jesus' disciples and the women who followed him were commoners as well. God is no respecter of persons (prosōpolēpsia, G4382). Elijah's faith made him uncommon though, and so the hand of the Lord was on him.

James also explained (though in regard to healing): "The effectual fervent prayer of a righteous man availeth much" (v. 16). Like Abraham, Elijah was made righteous by his steadfast faith. And so in bringing God's victory, he made things right in Israel just as he did for the Gentile widow and her son.

"Elijah was a man with a nature like ours," and it was always possible when he prayed for him to say, "God has answered" ('êl 'ânâh, H410+H6030).

Day 27: Elisha's spirit

'When they had crossed, Elijah said to Elisha, "Ask what I shall do for you, before I am taken from you." And Elisha said, "Please let there be a double portion of your spirit on me." And he said, "You have asked a hard thing; yet, if you see me as I am being taken from you, it shall be so for you, but if you do not see me, it shall not be so." And as they still went on and talked, behold, chariots of fire and horses of fire separated the two of them. And Elijah went up by a whirlwind into heaven. And Elisha saw it and he cried, "My father, my father! The chariots of Israel and its horsemen!" And he saw him no more. Then he took hold of his own clothes and tore them in two pieces. And he took up the cloak of Elijah that had fallen from him and went back and stood on the bank of the Jordan. Then he took the cloak of Elijah that had fallen from him and struck the water, saying, "Where is the Lord, the God of Elijah?" And when he had struck the water, the water was parted to the one side and to the other, and Elisha went over. '

2 Kings 2:9-14

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/2KI.2.9-14>

'Now the wife of one of the sons of the prophets cried to Elisha, "Your servant my husband is dead, and you know that your servant feared the Lord, but the creditor has come to take my two children to be his slaves." And Elisha said to her, "What shall I do for you? Tell me; what have you in the house?" And she said, "Your servant has nothing in the house except a jar of oil." Then he said, "Go outside, borrow vessels from all your neighbors, empty vessels and not too few. Then go in and shut the door behind yourself and your sons and pour into all these vessels. And when one is full, set it aside." So she went from him and shut the door behind herself and her sons. And as she poured they brought the vessels to her. When the vessels were full, she said to her son, "Bring me another vessel." And he said to her, "There is not another." Then the oil stopped flowing. She came and told the man of God, and he said, "Go, sell the oil and pay your debts, and you and your sons can live on the rest." '

2 Kings 4:1-7

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/2KI.4.1-7>

A man came from Baal-shalishah, bringing the man of God bread of the firstfruits, twenty loaves of barley and fresh ears of grain in his sack. And Elisha said, "Give to the men, that they may eat." But his servant said, "How can I set this before a hundred men?" So he repeated, "Give them to the men, that they may eat, for thus says the Lord, 'They shall eat and have some left.'" So he set it before them. And they ate and had some left, according to the word of the Lord.'

2 Kings 4:42-44

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/2KI.4.42-44>

"...Please let there be a double portion of your spirit on me..."

Elisha asked for a double portion of God's spirit. It was made his because Elisha saw Elijah be taken to heaven. Having wisdom from God, Elijah knew this was about to come. Elijah knew that if the fullness of God's spirit came to Elisha, he would see this happen. Elisha saw chariots of fire and a whirlwind when Elijah was taken. According to God's wisdom and purpose, Elijah would return later to the earth:

' "Behold, I will send you Elijah the prophet before the great and awesome day of the Lord comes. And he will turn the hearts of fathers to their children and the hearts of children to their fathers, lest I come and strike the land with a decree of utter destruction."

Malachi 4:5-6

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/MAL.4.5-6>

Elisha did receive from the Spirit of God. From God's Spirit, he was given revelation from God: wisdom, knowledge, and spiritual discernment. He was also given faith to perform miracles, as all his recorded words came to pass (see 1 Corinthians 12:8-10, Mark 11:22-24).

'...And he took up the cloak of Elijah that had fallen from him and went back and stood on the bank of the Jordan. Then he took the cloak of Elijah that had fallen from him and struck the water, saying, "Where is the Lord, the God of Elijah?" And when he had struck the water, the water was parted to the one side and to the other, and Elisha went over...'

Elisha had faith then when he struck the water of the Jordan as Elijah had done, it would part as it had just done for Elijah (2 Kings 2:8), and it did. Elisha exercised

his faith, and it grew from there to become greater to bless others (see Solomon's knowledge about such things in Proverbs 11:25), leading not to mountaintop-type experiences but rather to a plateau life.

In steadfast faith, Elisha also performed creative miracles not unlike those Jesus did by the Spirit of God during His ministry. First, Elisha provided for a widow and her children, saving her children from becoming slaves. Elisha had compassion on her, bringing the freedom that God brings through multiplying as only the power of God can. The widow believed the words of Elisha, trusting him to be sent by God, and she was blessed.

"...Give them to the men, that they may eat, for thus says the Lord, 'They shall eat and have some left.'..."

Next, Elisha spoke words from God and multiplied loaves of barley to feed one hundred, having food left over. By his faith exercised again, Elisha was made able to provide for others, demonstrating the steadfast love of God.

Jesus has the fullness of the Life-giving Spirit of God. He promised it to the church (John 14:15-17) and it was poured out for the church (Acts 2:17), even as the Apostle Paul spoke,

'For in [Christ] the whole fullness of deity dwells bodily, and you have been filled in him, who is the head of all rule and authority.'

Colossians 2:9-10

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/COL.2.9-10>

Christ is the Head, and the church, formed by its confessions of faith (Romans 10:9-13), is His functioning body in the world. Christ is alive in each member of the body, and each member is in Him, each of them ambassadors of Christ to carry His love (agapē, G26) to the world (2 Corinthians 5:20). God has promised something better for the church in Jesus Christ than faith-filled prophets like Elijah and Elisha did not have (Acts 2:38-39, Hebrews 11:39-40).

Day 28: Elisha and the Shunammite woman

'One day Elisha went on to Shunem, where a wealthy woman lived, who urged him to eat some food. So whenever he passed that way, he would turn in there to eat food. And she said to her husband, "Behold now, I know that this is a holy man of God who is continually passing our way. Let us make a small room on the roof with walls and put there for him a bed, a table, a chair, and a lamp, so that whenever he comes to us, he can go in there." One day he came there, and he turned into the chamber and rested there. And he said to Gehazi his servant, "Call this Shunammite." When he had called her, she stood before him. And he said to him, "Say now to her, 'See, you have taken all this trouble for us; what is to be done for you? Would you have a word spoken on your behalf to the king or to the commander of the army?'" She answered, "I dwell among my own people." And he said, "What then is to be done for her?" Gehazi answered, "Well, she has no son, and her husband is old." He said, "Call her." And when he had called her, she stood in the doorway. And he said, "At this season, about this time next year, you shall embrace a son." And she said, "No, my lord, O man of God; do not lie to your servant." But the woman conceived, and she bore a son about that time the following spring, as Elisha had said to her. When the child had grown, he went out one day to his father among the reapers. And he said to his father, "Oh, my head, my head!" The father said to his servant, "Carry him to his mother." And when he had lifted him and brought him to his mother, the child sat on her lap till noon, and then he died. And she went up and laid him on the bed of the man of God and shut the door behind him and went out. Then she called to her husband and said, "Send me one of the servants and one of the donkeys, that I may quickly go to the man of God and come back again." And he said, "Why will you go to him today? It is neither new moon nor Sabbath." She said, "All is well." Then she saddled the donkey, and she said to her servant, "Urge the animal on; do not slacken the pace for me unless I tell you." So she set out and came to the man of God at Mount Carmel. When the man of God saw her coming, he said to Gehazi his servant, "Look, there is the Shunammite. Run at once to meet her and say to her, 'Is all well with you? Is all well with your husband? Is all well with the child?'" And she answered, "All is well." And when she came to the mountain to the man of God, she caught hold of his feet. And Gehazi came to push her away. But the man of God said, "Leave her alone, for she is in bitter distress, and the Lord has hidden

it from me and has not told me." Then she said, "Did I ask my lord for a son? Did I not say, 'Do not deceive me?'" He said to Gehazi, "Tie up your garment and take my staff in your hand and go. If you meet anyone, do not greet him, and if anyone greets you, do not reply. And lay my staff on the face of the child." Then the mother of the child said, "As the Lord lives and as you yourself live, I will not leave you." So he arose and followed her. Gehazi went on ahead and laid the staff on the face of the child, but there was no sound or sign of life. Therefore he returned to meet him and told him, "The child has not awakened." When Elisha came into the house, he saw the child lying dead on his bed. So he went in and shut the door behind the two of them and prayed to the Lord. Then he went up and lay on the child, putting his mouth on his mouth, his eyes on his eyes, and his hands on his hands. And as he stretched himself upon him, the flesh of the child became warm. Then he got up again and walked once back and forth in the house, and went up and stretched himself upon him. The child sneezed seven times, and the child opened his eyes. Then he summoned Gehazi and said, "Call this Shunammite." So he called her. And when she came to him, he said, "Pick up your son." She came and fell at his feet, bowing to the ground. Then she picked up her son and went out. '

2 Kings 4:8-37

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/2KI.4.8-37>

'Now Elisha had said to the woman whose son he had restored to life, "Arise, and depart with your household, and sojourn wherever you can, for the Lord has called for a famine, and it will come upon the land for seven years." So the woman arose and did according to the word of the man of God. She went with her household and sojourned in the land of the Philistines seven years. And at the end of the seven years, when the woman returned from the land of the Philistines, she went to appeal to the king for her house and her land. Now the king was talking with Gehazi the servant of the man of God, saying, "Tell me all the great things that Elisha has done." And while he was telling the king how Elisha had restored the dead to life, behold, the woman whose son he had restored to life appealed to the king for her house and her land. And Gehazi said, "My lord, O king, here is the woman, and here is her son whom Elisha restored to life." And when the king asked the woman, she told him. So the king appointed an official

for her, saying, "Restore all that was hers, together with all the produce of the fields from the day that she left the land until now." '

2 Kings 8:1-6

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/2KI.8.1-6>

The Shunamite woman knew Elisha as a holy (qâdôsh, H6918) man of God, a fellow worker (sunergos, G4904) with Him (1 Corinthians 3:9), and so she extended hospitality to him, even giving him his own room in her home. Elisha looked into how he could be a blessing to her, and he decided to use the gifts of faith and miracles God had given to him to give her a son. He spoke according to a spirit of faith (2 Corinthians 4:13-15), and the words he spoke came to pass: "At this season, about this time next year, you shall embrace a son." God is generous in every way, and He was generous through Elisha, having given him seed to sow a harvest of righteousness (2 Corinthians 9:10).

When Satan took the Shunamite woman's son away from her, she went directly to Elisha at Mount Carmel, expecting he could make it right (or be whole, shâlôm, H7965) because he was connected to God. Elisha told his servant Gehazi to take his staff to the dead boy and lay it on his face. This was not enough to restore him to life, so Elisha, not willing to stop until it was made as it should be, went personally. He went into the room alone with the boy and prayed to the Lord. Elisha then decided to lay right on top of him so the Life of the Spirit of God from him would transfer into the boy, making him alive. The boy began to recover, his flesh becoming warm. God's work wasn't completed yet, so Elisha did this a second time, causing the boy to fully recover. The same Spirit that raised Jesus from the dead dwelled (enoikeō, G1774) in Elisha (Romans 8:11), and he gave that resurrection Life (zōopoieō, G2227) to this boy. Elisha then called his mother in to reunite her with her son that the Holy Spirit had quickened through Elisha's act of faith.

"...She came and fell at his feet, bowing to the ground..." The continued generosity of the God of grace brought through Elisha produced an overflow of thanksgiving and glory to God. Thanks be to God for His inexpressible gift! (2 Corinthians 9:10-15)

Zealous (zēlōtēs, G2207) of good works (Titus 2:14), Elisha continued to seek ways to bless this family. In the words of wisdom God had given to Elisha (1 Corinthians 2:7,10-16), it was revealed to him that there would be famine in the land for seven years. In order to provide for her and her family, Elisha sent her off to the land of the Philistines where there would be no famine. The woman took heed of Elisha's words to her, yet she lost her land during this time.

God continued to bless this woman of faith. After seven years, she went to petition the king for her land back. At this time, Gehazi was talking to the king, who wanted to hear of the great things Elisha had done. A testimony of God's goodness, the Shunamite woman, was standing right before him. She spoke up about what the Lord had done for her through Elisha — how God had brought her son back to life (châyâh, H2421) through Elisha. Upon her testimony of God's goodness to her, God restored to her everything that had been hers.

Elisha was God's handiwork (poiēma, G4161), created to do good works, which God prepared in advance for him to do (Ephesians 2:10). These good works are (for) people created in God's image and likeness. For Elisha, one of them was the Shunamite woman.

Throughout history, the story of God, God has continued to reveal Himself as "The Lord, the Lord, a God merciful and gracious, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love and faithfulness" (Exodus 34:6). God showed His compassion (rachûm, H7349) and grace (channûn, H2587) to the Shunamite woman through Elisha, and He continues to show the abundance of His steadfast love (chêsêd, H2617) and faithfulness ('emeth, H571) through the church (1 Corinthians 13:13), the temple (naos, G3485) of the Holy Spirit (1 Corinthians 3:16, 2 Corinthians 6:16-18), as each member seeks to lift up Jesus, do good, and to build up (oikodomē, G3619) the church (1 Corinthians 14:12). The living (zaō, G2198) God continues to dwell (enoikeō, G1774) in and walk in (emperipateō, G1704) His people.

Day 29: Elisha and the Syrians

"Naaman, commander of the army of the king of Syria, was a great man with his master and in high favor, because by him the Lord had given victory to Syria. He was a mighty man of valor, but he was a leper... So Naaman came with his horses and chariots and stood at the door of Elisha's house. And Elisha sent a messenger to him, saying, "Go and wash in the Jordan seven times, and your flesh shall be restored, and you shall be clean ...So he went down and dipped himself seven times in the Jordan, according to the word of the man of God, and his flesh was restored like the flesh of a little child, and he was clean."

2 Kings 5:1, 9-10, 14 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/2ki.5.1-14.ESV>

"Once when the king of Syria was warring against Israel, he took counsel with his servants, saying, "At such and such a place shall be my camp." But the man of God sent word to the king of Israel, "Beware that you do not pass this place, for the Syrians are going down there." And the king of Israel sent to the place about which the man of God told him. Thus he used to warn him, so that he saved himself there more than once or twice. And the mind of the king of Syria was greatly troubled because of this thing, and he called his servants and said to them, "Will you not show me who of us is for the king of Israel?" And one of his servants said, "None, my Lord, O king; but Elisha, the prophet who is in Israel, tells the king of Israel the words that you speak in your bedroom." And he said, "Go and see where he is, that I may send and seize him." It was told him, "Behold, he is in Dothan." So he sent there horses and chariots and a great army, and they came by night and surrounded the city. When the servant of the man of God rose early in the morning and went out, behold, an army with horses and chariots was all around the city. And the servant said, "Alas, my master! What shall we do?" He said, "Do not be afraid, for those who are with us are more than those who are with them." Then Elisha prayed and said, "O Lord, please open his eyes that he may see." So the Lord opened the eyes of the young man, and he saw, and behold, the mountain was full of horses and chariots of fire all around Elisha. And when the Syrians came down against him, Elisha prayed to the Lord and said, "Please strike this people with blindness." So he struck them with blindness in accordance with the prayer of Elisha. And Elisha said to them, "This is not the way, and this is

not the city. Follow me, and I will bring you to the man whom you seek." And he led them to Samaria. As soon as they entered Samaria, Elisha said, "O Lord, open the eyes of these men, that they may see." So the Lord opened their eyes and they saw, and behold, they were in the midst of Samaria. As soon as the king of Israel saw them, he said to Elisha, "My father, shall I strike them down? Shall I strike them down?" He answered, "You shall not strike them down. Would you strike down those whom you have taken captive with your sword and with your bow? Set bread and water before them, that they may eat and drink and go to their master." So he prepared for them a great feast, and when they had eaten and drunk, he sent them away, and they went to their master. And the Syrians did not come again on raids into the land of Israel."

2 Kings 6:8-23 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/2ki.6.8-23.ESV>

Naaman was a Syrian army commander. He was healed of leprosy when he obeyed the word of Elisha, who had gifts (charisma, G5486) of healing (iama, G2386) from the Spirit of God (1 Corinthians 12:9). Elisha required an action from Naaman, asking him to wash in the Jordan River seven times. When he did this, his flesh was restored.

When Jesus Christ started his public ministry in Nazareth, declaring in a synagogue on the Sabbath that He was anointed (mâshach, H4886; chriō, G5548) by the Spirit of the Lord to "set at liberty those who are oppressed" (derôr, H1865, aphesis, G859; Luke 4:18, Isaiah 61:1), He mentioned this incident where Naaman was cleansed of his leprosy, showing that God did not favor the Jews. He is no respecter of persons (prosōpolēptēs, G4381, Acts 10:34), even as Peter declared when the Holy Spirit first came upon the Gentiles during the ministry of the church. Peter saw Jesus demonstrate the same kind of spiritual power during His ministry, including an incident where Jesus healed ten Samaritan lepers who asked him to show mercy (eleeō, G1653). Like Elisha, Jesus required an act of faith from them, asking them to go show themselves to the priests. "And as they went, they were cleansed" (Luke 17:14).

"...Elisha, the prophet who is in Israel, tells the king of Israel the words that you speak in your bedroom..."

From God's Spirit, Elisha was given revelation: words (logos, G3056) of wisdom (sophia, G4678), words of knowledge (gnōsis, G1108), and discerning (diakrisis, G1253) of spirits (pneuma, G4151, 1 Corinthians 12:8-10). By the Spirit of God, Elisha had given knowledge that saved Israel from Syria: God enabled him to know words (dâbâr, H1697) the king of Syria spoke in private. Elisha's name means God is salvation ('eliyshâ', H477), and the salvation of God is what he brought to God's people.

Jesus Christ also had words of knowledge through the Spirit of God that brought salvation (sōtēria, G4991) to many residing in Samaria (John 4:22,39). The Spirit of God enabled Jesus to know many things about the Samaritan woman who came to draw water from Jacob's well at Sychar (John 4:16-18), causing her to believe Jesus was the Messiah when He revealed it to her (John 4:26) and to tell many others about it.

'...Then Elisha prayed and said, "O Lord, please open his eyes that he may see." So the Lord opened the eyes of the young man, and he saw, and behold, the mountain was full of horses and chariots of fire all around Elisha...'

Through a gift of God's Spirit, Elisha also had discernment of spirits, a sixth sense. His faith had become an eye that saw the invisible. Before he prayed for his servant's eyes to be opened, he already saw that God, the Lord of Hosts (Jehovah Sabaoth, H3068+H6635, 1 Samuel 1:3), was with him. Elisha had first seen chariots of fire and horses of fire when Elijah was taken to heaven (2 Kings 2:11). Now God had opened his servant's eyes to see them as well. There was no reason to fear. Elisha was strong and courageous because God was fighting for them, making him more than a conqueror (hupernikaō, G5245, Romans 8:37). The Spirit of God agreed with Elisha's prayer of faith and struck the Syrians with blindness, removing a mountain for him (Matthew 17:20, Mark 11:23). Elisha led them to the king of Israel, King Jehoram, at Samaria, where he urged the king to have mercy on them. The Syrians' eyes were then opened at Elisha's prayer. They were given a great feast instead of being killed, and then they were sent back to Syria. While Elijah's fervent prayers had stopped and then restarted rain, those of Elisha gave and then removed blindness.

By ability (dunamis, G1411) from the Spirit of God, Jesus also saw the spiritual. After He gave authority (exousia, G1849) to and sent out seventy-two of His disciples as His ambassadors (presbeuō, G4243, 2 Corinthians 5:20) to 36 towns in Israel to heal (therapeuō, G2323) the sick (asthenēs, G772), proclaim the kingdom (basileia, G932) of God, and speak on His behalf, He saw Satan fall (piptō, G4098) like lightning from heaven. He told His disciples the spirits had been made subject (hupotassō, G5293) to them (Luke 10:9-20). Jesus taught and empowered them to do just as He did (Acts 10:38, Mark 16:15-20, John 14:12-16). Referring again to spiritual sight, Jesus also gave some of His disciples the ability to see the spiritual world, Elijah included, at the Transfiguration (Matthew 16:28- 17:13).

Just as Solomon is remembered as one who asked for an understanding mind to discern what is right and received it (1 Kings 3:9-14), Elisha is remembered as one who asked for more of God's Spirit and received it: "Please let there be a double portion of your spirit on me" (2 Kings 2:9). He was one who earnestly desired the higher (kreittōn, G2909) gifts (charisma, G5486; 1 Corinthians 12:31) in order to serve God's purposes, and God responded to his faith. Elisha aligned his will (thelēma, G2307) with God's will; he did God's will on earth as it is done (ginomai, G1096) in heaven, and he brought deliverance (rhuomai, G4506) to God's people (Matthew 6:10,13).

While Elisha, led by the Spirit, brought glory to God by showing the image, likeness, and dominion (mamlākāh, H4467; basileia, G932) of God as a son (Genesis 1:26, Romans 8:14) and had aspects of his supernatural ministry which were similar to that of Jesus, he was not perfect (see 2 Kings 2:23-24) nor did he receive what was promised (Hebrews 11:39). In contrast, Jesus Christ, the promised One, the Son of God, is perfect, "the radiance of the glory of God and the exact imprint of his nature" (Hebrews 1:3). "He is the image of the invisible God" (Colossians 1:3). At least since His baptism (John 1:32-33), He as a man has had the fullness of the Spirit of God. The Apostle John wrote to the church about Him: "For from his fullness we have all received, grace upon grace."

John 1:16 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/jhn.1.16.ESV>

The church, the body of Christ, has received the Spirit of Christ to live within it in fullness (Ephesians 4:4-16), enabling it to show the goodness of God's will toward all (Romans 12:2).

Day 30: Isaiah's prophecies about the life of Jesus

'Therefore the Lord himself will give you a sign. Behold, the virgin shall conceive and bear a son, and shall call his name Immanuel.'

Isaiah 7:14

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/ISA.7.14>

'But there will be no gloom for her who was in anguish. In the former time he brought into contempt the land of Zebulun and the land of Naphtali, but in the latter time he has made glorious the way of the sea, the land beyond the Jordan, Galilee of the nations. The people who walked in darkness have seen a great light; those who dwelt in a land of deep darkness, on them has light shone. You have multiplied the nation; you have increased its joy; they rejoice before you as with joy at the harvest, as they are glad when they divide the spoil. For the yoke of his burden, and the staff for his shoulder, the rod of his oppressor, you have broken as on the day of Midian. For every boot of the tramping warrior in battle tumult and every garment rolled in blood will be burned as fuel for the fire. For to us a child is born, to us a son is given; and the government shall be upon his shoulder, and his name shall be called Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God, Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace. Of the increase of his government and of peace there will be no end, on the throne of David and over his kingdom, to establish it and to uphold it with justice and with righteousness from this time forth and forevermore. The zeal of the Lord of hosts will do this.'

Isaiah 9:1-7

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/ISA.9.1-7>

'There shall come forth a shoot from the stump of Jesse, and a branch from his roots shall bear fruit. And the Spirit of the Lord shall rest upon him, the Spirit of wisdom and understanding, the Spirit of counsel and might, the Spirit of knowledge and the fear of the Lord. And his delight shall be in the fear of the Lord. He shall not judge by what his eyes see, or decide disputes by what his ears hear, but with righteousness he shall judge the poor, and decide with equity for the meek of the earth; and he shall strike the earth with the rod of his mouth, and with the breath of his lips he shall kill the wicked. Righteousness shall be the belt of his waist, and faithfulness the belt of his loins. The wolf shall dwell with the

lamb, and the leopard shall lie down with the young goat, and the calf and the lion and the fattened calf together; and a little child shall lead them.'

Isaiah 11:1-6

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/ISA.11.1-6>

Isaiah answered the call of God to go speak God's words to His people, although the people did not understand or perceive (Isaiah 6:8-9). Isaiah is known for his great wisdom (sophia, G4678, 1 Corinthians 2:7,16), having had many revelations of the mind (nous, G3563) of God for the future, including the life of Christ and events pertaining to His second coming. Having wisdom from the Spirit of God, David's psalms also had many prophecies that pertained to Jesus' life (e.g., Psalm 22).

'Therefore the Lord himself will give you a sign. Behold, the virgin shall conceive and bear a son, and shall call his name Immanuel. '

Isaiah prophesied that Jesus would be born of a virgin, Mary. For the church, Jesus is Immanuel ('immânû'êl, H6005), God with us, who dwells (katoikeō, G2730) in us through faith (Romans 8:9-11, Ephesians 3:17, Colossians 1:27). Those who join (kollaō, G2853) themselves to the Lord become one spirit with Him (1 Corinthians 6:17) and one flesh with Him, members of His body, of His flesh, and of His bones (Ephesians 5:31-32). This is God's design for His church (John 17:21), made in His image and likeness (Genesis 1:26), as fully revealed in Christ (Colossians 1:15).

"...But there will be no gloom for her who was in anguish. In the former time he brought into contempt the land of Zebulun and the land of Naphtali, but in the latter time he has made glorious the way of the sea, the land beyond the Jordan, Galilee of the nations. The people who walked in darkness have seen a great light; those who dwelt in a land of deep darkness, on them has light shone..."

Jesus' ministry was primarily in Galilee, and for a time He lived in "Capernaum by the sea, in the territory of Zebulun and Naphtali" (Matthew 4:12-16).

'From that time Jesus began to preach, saying, "Repent, for the kingdom of heaven is at hand." '

Matthew 4:17

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/MAT.4.17>

In Capernaum, Jesus taught and healed in the synagogue (Mark 1:21-28, John 6:35-59). In Capernaum, Mark recorded that Jesus taught as one who had

authority, and He cast out a demon simply by telling it to come out of a man. Jesus frequently called the people to repent (metanoēō, G3340), or change their minds, and taught about the kingdom (mamlâkâh, H4467; basileia, G932) of heaven that He had brought near (eggizō, G1448) to them. In Capernaum, John recorded Jesus' words to a crowd that He was the bread of life (zōē, G2222, John 6:35), speaking of the New Covenant. Jesus also declared that His words were spirit and life, and it is the Spirit of God that gives life (John 6:63). Jesus revealed God's truth as the Light (phōs, G5457) of the World (John 1:4-5, 3:19-21, 8:12), His great (gâdôl, H1419) light ('ôr, H216) overcoming the shadow of death (tsalmâveth, H6757) in the land.

"...You have multiplied the nation; you have increased its joy; they rejoice before you as with joy at the harvest, as they are glad when they divide the spoil. For the yoke of his burden, and the staff for his shoulder, the rod of his oppressor, you have broken as on the day of Midian..."

God has multiplied (râbâh, H7235) the people of God in harvest (qâtsîyr, H7105; therismos, G2326, Matthew 9:35-38) after harvest through Jesus and His body, the church, which has extended into the entire world. God has brought freedom (eleutheroō, G1659, Galatians 5:1) and joy (šimchâh, H8057) to His multiplied people through Jesus Christ, who always has victory and has made the people of His church more than conquerors (hupernikaō, G5245, Romans 8:1-2, 37).

"...For to us a child is born, to us a son is given; and the government shall be upon his shoulder, and his name shall be called Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God, Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace. Of the increase of his government and of peace there will be no end, on the throne of David and over his kingdom, to establish it and to uphold it with justice and with righteousness from this time forth and forevermore. The zeal of the Lord of hosts will do this..."

The birth of Jesus in Bethlehem (Micah 5:2) in a stable (Luke 2:6) was the humble entrance of Immanuel into the world, a show of the zealous (qin'âh, H7068) love of God for the men and women He created. Following his suffering, death, and resurrection, Jesus was exalted (huperupsoō, G5251) to be given all authority (miśrâh, H4951, exousia, G1849) over heaven and earth by God the Father (Matthew 28:18, Philippians 2:9-11). Through the kingdom (mamlâkâh, H4467; basileia, G932)

Jesus Christ ushered in, He brings peace (shâlôm, H7965) and righteousness (tsedâqâh, H6666), even as He started to do during His ministry. Seated on God's throne (kissê', H3678), He made the church members of His body, through which they have intimate union with God the Father and with the Spirit of God given to them. In His righteousness, Jesus will continue to have victory over all evil until it is put under His feet completely (1 Corinthians 15:24-25).

"...There shall come forth a shoot from the stump of Jesse, and a branch from his roots shall bear fruit..."

Jesus is from the lineage of David, from the tribe of Jesse. Israel was in bad shape at the time of Isaiah, such that it might be called a stump (geza', H1503). Yet new life, a shoot (chôtêr, H2415), would come of the mess that Israel had become in the form of Jesus Christ, Immanuel. To bear fruit (pârâh, H6509) is to yield life in accordance with the goodness and the will of God.

Jesus Christ taught that He was the true vine out of which His disciples grew as branches (klêma, G2814, John 15:2). God's people must now abide (menō, G3306) in Christ and His word (rhēma, G4487) in order to live, to grow, and to bear fruit. They must be doers of His word. The chief fruit of abiding in Christ is love (apagē, G26, John 15:1-17).

"...And the Spirit of the Lord shall rest upon him, the Spirit of wisdom and understanding, the Spirit of counsel and might, the Spirit of knowledge and the fear of the Lord..."

The Spirit (rûach, H7307, pneuma, G4151) of the Lord has rested (nûach, H5117, menō, G3306) upon Jesus Christ from the time of His baptism (baptizō, G9078, John 1:31-33), and in Him the fullness (plērōma, G4138) of God dwells (Colossians 2:9). Although He was fully man, Jesus was given revelation from God, including God's wisdom (chokmâh, H2451, sophia, G4678), knowledge (da'ath, H1847, gnosis, G1108), and discernment (bîynâh, H998, diakrisis, G1253, 1 Corinthians 12:8-10) of the spiritual (e.g., see John 1:48; 4:17-18,39; 5:19-20,30). The Spirit of God that dwells in Christ and His people (Christ's body) is the source of all counsel ('êtsâh, H6098, paraklētos, G3875, John 14:26), power (dunamis, G1411, Acts 1:8), and strength (gebûrâh, H1369; endunamoō, G1743, Philippians 4:13).

“...He shall not judge by what his eyes see, or decide disputes by what his ears hear, but with righteousness he shall judge the poor, and decide with equity for the meek of the earth; and he shall strike the earth with the rod of his mouth, and with the breath of his lips he shall kill the wicked. Righteousness shall be the belt of his waist, and faithfulness the belt of his loins. The wolf shall dwell with the lamb, and the leopard shall lie down with the young goat, and the calf and the lion and the fattened calf together; and a little child shall lead them.”

While righteousness (tsedeq, H6664) and faithfulness (‘emûnâh, H530) are part of Jesus’ nature as God, the other description here spoke of a time to come when Jesus will judge and when Jesus, the Prince of Peace, will bring the rule of peace. Jesus came to make everything right (tsedeq, H6664); He changes everything. By the Spirit that He gave to His church, He turned the world upside down (anastatoō, G387, Acts 17:6).

Day 31: Isaiah's prophecy of coming salvation

' Strengthen the weak hands, and make firm the feeble knees. Say to those who have an anxious heart, "Be strong; fear not! Behold, your God will come with vengeance, with the recompense of God. He will come and save you." Then the eyes of the blind shall be opened, and the ears of the deaf unstopped; then shall the lame man leap like a deer, and the tongue of the mute sing for joy. For waters break forth in the wilderness, and streams in the desert... And a highway shall be there, and it shall be called the Way of Holiness; the unclean shall not pass over it. It shall belong to those who walk on the way; even if they are fools, they shall not go astray. '

Isaiah 35:3-6,8

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/ISA.35.3-6,8>

' A voice cries: "In the wilderness prepare the way of the Lord ; make straight in the desert a highway for our God. Every valley shall be lifted up, and every mountain and hill be made low; the uneven ground shall become level, and the rough places a plain. And the glory of the Lord shall be revealed, and all flesh shall see it together, for the mouth of the Lord has spoken." A voice says, "Cry!" And I said, "What shall I cry?" All flesh is grass, and all its beauty is like the flower of the field. The grass withers, the flower fades when the breath of the Lord blows on it; surely the people are grass. The grass withers, the flower fades, but the word of our God will stand forever... Behold, the Lord God comes with might, and his arm rules for him; behold, his reward is with him, and his recompense before him. He will tend his flock like a shepherd; he will gather the lambs in his arms; he will carry them in his bosom, and gently lead those that are with young... Have you not known? Have you not heard? The Lord is the everlasting God, the Creator of the ends of the earth. He does not faint or grow weary; his understanding is unsearchable. He gives power to the faint, and to him who has no might he increases strength. Even youths shall faint and be weary, and young men shall fall exhausted; but they who wait for the Lord shall renew their strength; they shall mount up with wings like eagles; they shall run and not be weary; they shall walk and not faint.'

Isaiah 40:3-8,10-11,28-31

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/ISA.40.3-8,10-11,28-31>

'How beautiful upon the mountains are the feet of him who brings good news, who publishes peace, who brings good news of happiness, who publishes salvation, who says to Zion, "Your God reigns."

Isaiah 52:7 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/iso.52.7.ESV>

The name Isaiah (yesha'yâh, H3470), means Jehovah has saved. As a prophet, Isaiah had words (logos, G3056) of wisdom (sophia, G4678, 1 Corinthians 12:8) from God, supernatural revelations of the mind and purpose (mustērion, G3466) of God communicated by the Holy Spirit (1 Corinthians 2:7). The purpose described in these passages was that of God's salvation to come to God's people over the proceeding thousands of years.

' Strengthen the weak hands, and make firm the feeble knees. Say to those who have an anxious heart, "Be strong; fear not! Behold, your God will come with vengeance, with the recompense of God. He will come and save you." ... '

To some with especially steadfast faith, God's salvation (yâsha', H3467) comes as they need it, as Moses described in Psalm 91 (see Day 10). Moses and David knew God's salvation. In the time of Isaiah, Israel received deliverance from Assyria by way of an angel when they decided to pray to the Lord for it (see Isaiah 37). Since this passage refers though to the Messiah, Jesus Christ, it refers to the way He will bring salvation to the nation of Israel in His second coming during the time of the Millenium (see Zechariah 14 for one relevant prophecy about this time).

"...Then the eyes of the blind shall be opened, and the ears of the deaf unstopped; then shall the lame man leap like a deer, and the tongue of the mute sing for joy. For waters break forth in the wilderness, and streams in the desert..."

The ministry of Jesus (lēsous, G2424) Christ brought this prophecy of God's full salvation (sōzō, G4982, Matthew 1:21) into its time of fulfillment, drawing the kingdom (basilea, G932) of heaven near (eggizō, G1448, Matthew 4:17). Jesus healed (therapeuō, G2323) everybody that came to Him (e.g., Matthew 4:23, Mark 6:56, Luke 4:30), and when Jesus gave the Spirit of God to the church (Acts 2:38-39), then the church began to do it as well (John 14:12-14, Acts 5:12-16). This included the blind, the deaf, the lame and the mute (e.g. Mark 2:9-12, 7:34-37, 8:22-25, 9:25-27, 10:51-52, Acts 3:4-8, 5:12-16, 8:5-8, 9:32-35, 15:12, 19:11-12). The gift of the Holy Spirit to

all of God's people through Jesus became the rivers of living (zaō, G2198) water promised by God (John 7:37-39). The gift is now for "whoever believes" (John 7:38).

...“And a highway shall be there, and it shall be called the Way of Holiness; the unclean shall not pass over it. It shall belong to those who walk on the way; even if they are fools, they shall not go astray...”

In the New Testament, believers in Jesus who profess (homologeō, G3670) their faith with their lips (Romans 10:10) are made righteous (dikaiosunē, G1343, 2 Corinthians 5:21) and empowered by the Spirit of God to renew (ananēōō, G365) their minds (nous, G3563) and lead holy (qôdesh, H6944; hosiotēs, G3742) lives (Colossians 2:13-15, Ephesians 4:22-24), having victory (thriambeuō, G2358) in all things that bring glory (doxazō, G1392) to God (Matthew 5:6, John 14:13-14).

‘...A voice cries: “In the wilderness prepare the way of the Lord; make straight in the desert a highway for our God. Every valley shall be lifted up, and every mountain and hill be made low; the uneven ground shall become level, and the rough places a plain...”’

The prophets, out of the wisdom of God, proclaimed the coming of the Messiah, especially John the Baptist, as described in Mark 1:1-8. John the Baptist described how the ministry of Jesus would change everything. In the kingdom (basilea, G932) of heaven that Jesus brought near (eggizō, G1448), everything is different (Matthew 6:10, 20:16) than it is in normal social systems. Further, our lives may be made completely different when we are baptized with the Holy Ghost (Mark 1:8); being led by this Spirit conforms us into the image (eikōn, G1504) of Christ (Romans 8:14,29), sons and daughters (adelphos, G80) of God.

‘...And the glory of the Lord shall be revealed, and all flesh shall see it together, for the mouth of the Lord has spoken.” A voice says, “Cry!” And I said, “What shall I cry?” All flesh is grass, and all its beauty is like the flower of the field. The grass withers, the flower fades when the breath of the Lord blows on it; surely the people are grass. The grass withers, the flower fades, but the word of our God will stand forever...’

Jesus, the Word (dâbâr, H1697) of God in the flesh, fulfilled (plēroō, G4137) the prophecy of Isaiah, as John wrote:

'And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and we have seen his glory, glory as of the only Son from the Father, full of grace and truth. (John [the Baptist] bore witness about him, and cried out, "This was he of whom I said, 'He who comes after me ranks before me, because he was before me.'") '

John 1:14-15

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/JHN.1.14-15>

Jesus testified that the Word of God would all be accomplished (ginomai, G1096), in a large part through the way He fulfills it:

“Do not think that I have come to abolish the Law or the Prophets; I have not come to abolish them but to fulfill them. For truly, I say to you, until heaven and earth pass away, not an iota, not a dot, will pass from the Law until all is accomplished.”

Matthew 5:17-18 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/mat.5.17-18.ESV>

The Word (logos, G3056) of God stands forever, as the Apostle John also described in Revelation (see e.g., Revelation 19:13). As the Apostle Peter wrote, those in whom the Word (rhēma, G4487) is implanted as an imperishable (aphthartos, G862) seed in the new birth (i.e., those in the church) also become eternal (1 Peter 1:23):

'Having purified your souls by your obedience to the truth for a sincere brotherly love, love one another earnestly from a pure heart, since you have been born again, not of perishable seed but of imperishable, through the living and abiding word of God; for "All flesh is like grass and all its glory like the flower of grass. The grass withers, and the flower falls, but the word of the Lord remains forever." And this word is the good news that was preached to you.'

1 Peter 1:22-25

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/1PE.1.22-25>

The Word of God coming in the flesh was God's good news to humanity because humanity was bound for death without the full salvation of God, which brings quickening (zōopoieō, G2227, Romans 8:11) in every good (agathos, G18) form from God.

'How beautiful upon the mountains are the feet of him who brings good news, who publishes peace, who brings good news of happiness, who publishes salvation...'

As Isaiah wrote and the Apostle Paul echoed (Romans 10:15), the feet of those who bring this good news (bâsar, H1319) of the gospel (euaggelizō, G2097) to those made in God's image and likeness are beautiful (nâ'âh, H4998; hōraios, G5611) to God. Belief in the gospel of Jesus Christ is the only source of salvation (yeshû'âh, H3444; sōtēria, G4991, Acts 4:12), peace (shâlôm, H7965, eirēnē, G1515), and Life (zōē, G2222, John 10:10). God's will in His gift of Jesus to the world is good (tōb, H2896; eudokia, G2107) toward all of mankind (Luke 2:14). Happiness ('esher, H835, Isaiah 30:8; makarios, G3107, Matthew 5:3) comes from understanding the giving nature of God, accepting His gift (dōron, G1435) of salvation (sōzō, G4982, Ephesians 2:4-10), and learning through the Spirit of God to give all of oneself (2 Corinthians 9:6-13), as only the grace (charis, G5485), great love (agapē, G26), and tenderness of God can give. The church gives itself fully to God and fully to serving mankind, "enriched in every way to be generous in every way" (ploutizō, G4148, 2 Corinthians 9:11), even as God is generous (haplotēs, G572).

"...Behold, the Lord God comes with might, and his arm rules for him; behold, his reward is with him, and his recompense before him. He will tend his flock like a shepherd; he will gather the lambs in his arms; he will carry them in his bosom, and gently lead those that are with young..."

The Lord God came in might (châzâq, H2389) in human form through Jesus of Nazareth, bringing the power of the kingdom of heaven to earth so His will would be done on earth as it is in heaven via the dominion (mâshal, H4910) given to Jesus, which Jesus gave in turn to the church, the body of Christ. Jesus showed the example of what it means to lead (nâhal, H5095) in a way that is pleasing to God. Jesus is the Good (kalos, G2570) Shepherd (râ'âh, H7462; poimēn, G4166) who laid down his life (psuchē, G5590) for the church to bring them abundant (perissos, G4053) life (zōē, G2222, John 10:10-11). Jesus is the perfect image (charaktēr, G5481) of the invisible God (Hebrews 1:3, Colossians 1:15), revealing the tenderness of the heart (eusplagchnos, G2155, Ephesians 4:32) of the Almighty God. The compassion (splagchnizomai, G4697) of God shown in Jesus Christ (Matthew 9:35-36) is so beautiful that it is attractive to the entire world. This is what the world wants to experience: the love of God (apapē, G26, 1 Corinthians 13:13). All of those made in God's image and likeness also want to see things made right, and this is just what the Righteous God does and will do, bringing a reward to those that make God's will their own and do good.

'...Have you not known? Have you not heard? The Lord is the everlasting God, the Creator of the ends of the earth. He does not faint or grow weary; his understanding is unsearchable. He gives power to the faint, and to him who has no might he increases strength. Even youths shall faint and be weary, and young men shall fall exhausted; but they who wait for the Lord shall renew their strength; they shall mount up with wings like eagles; they shall run and not be weary; they shall walk and not faint.'

Praise be to the one everlasting God, the creator (bârâ', H1254) of everything and everyone that we see, experience, and come to understand (tâbûn, H8394) — in the context of its original goodness. Praise be to the God who created His church in His image and likeness, making them “partakers of the divine nature” (koinōnos, G2844) through His full salvation. God is good! Through salvation, He “has granted to us all things that pertain to life and godliness” (2 Peter 1:3-4). Through salvation, each part of the body of Christ has been made alive, eternal and strong (’ôn, H202). Through connection to the Spirit of the everlasting God, the church has been filled with living energy and endued with power (kôach, H3581, dunamis, G1411). The church can do *all things* through Christ who provides to it the strength (’otsmâh, H6109; endunamoō, G1743) of God (Philippians 4:13).

Day 32: Isaiah's prophecy of the atonement of God's servant

"Behold, my servant shall act wisely; he shall be high and lifted up, and shall be exalted. As many were astonished at you— his appearance was so marred, beyond human semblance, and his form beyond that of the children of mankind— so shall he sprinkle many nations"

Isaiah 52:13-15b ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/isa.52.13-14.ESV>

"Who has believed what he has heard from us? And to whom has the arm of the Lord been revealed? For he grew up before him like a young plant, and like a root out of dry ground; he had no form or majesty that we should look at him, and no beauty that we should desire him. He was despised and rejected by men, a man of sorrows and acquainted with grief; and as one from whom men hide their faces he was despised, and we esteemed him not. Surely he has borne our griefs and carried our sorrows; yet we esteemed him stricken, smitten by God, and afflicted. But he was pierced for our transgressions; he was crushed for our iniquities; upon him was the chastisement that brought us peace, and with his wounds we are healed. All we like sheep have gone astray; we have turned—every one—to his own way; and the Lord has laid on him the iniquity of us all. He was oppressed, and he was afflicted, yet he opened not his mouth; like a lamb that is led to the slaughter, and like a sheep that before its shearers is silent, so he opened not his mouth. By oppression and judgment he was taken away; and as for his generation, who considered that he was cut off out of the land of the living, stricken for the transgression of my people? And they made his grave with the wicked and with a rich man in his death, although he had done no violence, and there was no deceit in his mouth. Yet it was the will of the Lord to crush him; he has put him to grief; when his soul makes an offering for guilt, he shall see his offspring; he shall prolong his days; the will of the Lord shall prosper in his hand. Out of the anguish of his soul he shall see and be satisfied; by his knowledge shall the righteous one, my servant, make many to be accounted righteous, and he shall bear their iniquities. Therefore I will divide him a portion with the many, and he shall divide the spoil with the strong, because he poured out his soul to death and was numbered with the transgressors; yet he bore the sin of many, and makes intercession for the transgressors."

Isaiah 53:1-12 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/isa.53.1-12.ESV>

Isaiah, a prophet who lived about 700 years before the time of Jesus Christ, had words of wisdom from God, supernatural revelations of the mind and purpose of God communicated by the Holy Spirit. The purpose of God revealed in these passages was that of His servant ('ebed, H5650), the Son of God who would become the final atonement (kâphar, H3722, Exodus 29:33; katallagē, G2643) for God's church among the nations in order to defeat evil and its effects, redeeming them as children of God for God's glory and for their good.

The servant of the Lord is the Word (logos, G3056) of God that became flesh (John 1:14), Jesus (lēsous, G2424) of Nazareth. God's Word is His servant to accomplish His will on earth just as God's words (dâbâr, H1697) are his servants ('ebed, H5650) to accomplish His will (Ps 119:89-91).

"...Who has believed what he has heard from us? And to whom has the arm of the Lord been revealed?..."

This purpose of God is only for those who believe in and confess (homologeō, G3670) Jesus Christ as their Lord (kurios, G2962), deciding to follow and live for Him (Romans 10:9-10). Their spirits, although born dead as sons of Adam and daughters of Eve, are quickened together with (suzōpoeiō, G4806, Ephesians 2:5) Jesus Christ. To them the power of God, the arm of the Lord, for salvation (sōzō, G4982) is revealed.

"...For he grew up before him like a young plant, and like a root out of dry ground; he had no form or majesty that we should look at him, and no beauty that we should desire him..."

Jesus was born in a dirty animal stable to common, working people of Nazareth, a town in Israel that was not at all impressive among the Jews. He was a carpenter by trade, having no form or majesty (hâdâr, H1926) about him, just as there was none about David when the Lord chose him as king, and just as there was none about the disciples that Jesus chose to follow Him in changing the world. One of Jesus' disciples, Nathaniel, said, "Can anything good come out of Nazareth?" (John 1:46)

"...He was despised and rejected [or forsaken] by men, a man of sorrows [or pains] and acquainted with grief [or knowing sickness]; and as one from whom men hide their faces [or as one who hides his face from us] he was despised, and we esteemed him not. Surely he has borne our griefs [or sicknesses] and carried our sorrows [or pains]; yet we esteemed him stricken, smitten by God, and afflicted. But he was pierced for our transgressions; he was crushed for our iniquities; upon him was the chastisement that brought us peace, and with his wounds we are healed..." [Notes from the English Standard Version are included in brackets]

This passage is referred back to in Matthew 8 that describes part of Jesus' ministry:

'That evening they brought to him many who were oppressed by demons, and he cast out the spirits with a word and healed all who were sick. This was to fulfill what was spoken by the prophet Isaiah: "He took our illnesses and bore our diseases." '

Matthew 8:16-17

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/MAT.8.16-17>

These events occurred at the Apostle Peter's house, right after Jesus healed his mother-in-law. Peter, who had been directly taught by Jesus about the prophecies concerning Himself (Luke 24:27), interpreted Jesus' atonement in the following way to the church:

'He committed no sin, neither was deceit found in his mouth. When he was reviled, he did not revile in return; when he suffered, he did not threaten, but continued entrusting himself to him who judges justly. He himself bore our sins in his body on the tree, that we might die to sin and live to righteousness. By his wounds you have been healed. '

1 Peter 2:22-24

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/1PE.2.22-24>

These passages describe the atonement of Jesus Christ at the hands of the Jewish people who rejected Him, led by the Jewish teachers of the law, the Sadducees and Pharisees. Some of the Jewish people who welcomed Jesus into Jerusalem as King within the week turned on Him and demanded His crucifixion at the hands of Pilate, a Roman, although He was not guilty of wrongdoing

according to Roman law. The main charge brought against Him by the Jews was that He claimed to be the Son of God, which He was indeed.

The purpose of God revealed through Isaiah was for the suffering servant, Jesus, to be turned over to the will of Satan for a time, where He would be falsely accused, tortured at a whipping post, sentenced to death, and made to be a curse (qelâlâh, H7045, Deuteronomy 21:23; katara, G2671, Galatians 3:13) as He was hung on a cross to die a brutal, shameful death. According to Isaiah, Jesus' atonement allowed for the payment of the sin of mankind (transgression, pasha', H6588; iniquity, 'âvôn, H5771) once and for all. Turned over to Satan, Jesus knew great pain (mak'ôb, H4341) and was also made sick (cholîy, H2483).

According to the Spirit of God that inspired the writing of Matthew, this passage of Isaiah means that Jesus through His atonement took (lambanō, G2983) our illnesses (asthenia, G769) and bore our diseases (nosos, G3554). Jesus' finished work, including His stripes (chabbûrâh, H2250; mōlōps, G3468) at the whipping post and His suffering and death on the cross, brought the opportunity of complete deliverance for sin and the problems caused by sin for all of mankind. The problems of sin that may be canceled by Jesus' finished work include eternal death, separation from God, sickness (cholîy, H2483; nosos, G3554), pain and sorrow (mak'ôb, H4341), and any affliction ('ânâh, H6031) or infirmity (asthenia, G769). Jesus has already borne (nâšâ', H5375) and carried (sâbal, H5445) these for us.

Any that put their faith in the finished work of Jesus Christ and confess it (Romans 10:9-10) are able to receive salvation (sōzō, G4982), oneness with God, physical healing, freedom from any affliction, and peace (shâlôm, H7965). Healing (râphâ', H7495) and salvation are a double cure for the effects of sin, coming hand in hand in a full salvation, as understood by David (Psalm 103:2-3) and as demonstrated by the ministry of Jesus and the apostles (where the latter is described first in the Acts of the Apostles). During His ministry, Jesus looked at sin and sickness, an effect of sin, hand in hand, saying, 'For which is easier, to say, 'Your sins are forgiven,' or to say, 'Rise and walk'? But that you may know that the Son of Man has authority on earth to forgive sins" —he then said to the paralytic— "Rise, pick up your bed and go home." '

Matthew 9:5-6

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/MAT.9.5-6>

"...All we like sheep have gone astray; we have turned—every one—to his own way; and the Lord has laid on him the iniquity of us all. He was oppressed, and he was afflicted, yet he opened not his mouth; like a lamb that is led to the slaughter, and like a sheep that before its shearers is silent, so he opened not his mouth..."

The atonement (kâphar, H3722; katallagē, G2643) of Jesus Christ (Christos, G5547) was a transaction that by the workings of the legal system of God (Colossians 2:13-15) set Him up for the ministry that He had on earth, as Peter explained to the Gentiles after Christ's ascension when they received the Holy Spirit:

"how God anointed Jesus of Nazareth with the Holy Spirit and with power. He went about doing good and healing all who were oppressed by the devil, for God was with him."

Acts 10:38 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/act.10.38.ESV>

Jesus Christ, the Anointed (chriō, G5548) One, was subjected to the oppression (nâgaś, H5065; katadunastēuō, G2616) of and slaughter by the devil so that He could completely deliver all of the men and women of the world that were and are oppressed. Jesus, still present on the throne at God's right hand and also through the Holy Spirit in each believer's spirit, continues this ministry of doing good (euergeteō, G2109) and making whole (iaomai, G2390). Christ does it through His Spirit-filled body, His church. Jesus, the Lamb (śeh, H7716; amnos, G286) of God (John 1:29), silently endured rejection, suffering, and a gruesome death in order to subvert the thief (kleptēs, G2812) who comes to steal (kleptō, G2813), to slaughter (thuō, G2380), to render useless and to destroy (apollumi, G622). Jesus laid down His life in order to give abundant (perissos, G4053) life (zōē, G2222, John 10:10-11).

"Behold, my servant shall act wisely; he shall be high and lifted up, and shall be exalted. As many were astonished at you—his appearance was so marred, beyond human semblance, and his form beyond that of the children of mankind—so shall he sprinkle [startle] many nations..."

Jesus subjected Himself to the will (thelēma, G2307) of God the Father. God's purpose was to redeem mankind, dearly loved and made in His image and

likeness. Jesus was lifted up (nâšâ', H5375, rûm, H7311; hupsoō, G5312) on the cross for the reason He spoke to Nicodemus: '... as Moses lifted up the serpent in the wilderness, so must the Son of Man be lifted up, that whoever believes in him may have eternal life. "For God so loved the world, that he gave his only Son, that whoever believes in him should not perish but have eternal life."

John 3:14-16 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/jhn.3.14-16.ESV>

The passage from Isaiah also describes some detail of Jesus' suffering that was revealed to him by God: His appearance was astonishing, marred (mishchâth, H4893) beyond human semblance. The Apostle Paul also wrote about how Jesus Christ, God's servant, was exalted (gâbahh, H1361): "And being found in human form, he humbled himself by becoming obedient to the point of death, even death on a cross. Therefore God has highly exalted him and bestowed on him the name that is above every name, so that at the name of Jesus every knee should bow, in heaven and on earth and under the earth, and every tongue confess that Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of God the Father."

Philippians 2:8-11 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/php.2.8-11.ESV>

Jesus Christ has been exalted (huperupsoō, G5251) by God the Father, the atonement making this possible according to God's legal system. He is exalted with authority (exousia, G1849, Matthew 28:18) over any kingdom on earth, over every heavenly being, and over the kingdom of Satan. The servant Jesus, the Word of God, speaks the words of God (John 8:42, 12:49, 14:10); everything and everyone must obey these words, which function as God's servants that carry out His will (Psalm 119:89-91), as already mentioned.

Even during Christ's ministry, every evil spirit had to obey Him. The King James Version translates the interpretation of Isaiah's prophecy the following way:

"When the even was come, they brought unto him many that were possessed with devils: and he cast out the spirits with his word, and healed all that were sick: that it might be fulfilled which was spoken by Esaias the prophet, saying, Himself took our infirmities, and bare our sicknesses."

Matthew 8:16-17 KJV

<https://bible.com/bible/1/mat.8.16-17.KJV>

The disciples who wrote the gospels called some of the evil spirits that afflicted people spirits of infirmity (astheneia, G769, e.g., Luke 13:11). Jesus' authority loosed (apoluō, G630, luō, G3089) people from any spirit of infirmity at a word or at a touch:

"And, behold, there was a woman which had a spirit of infirmity eighteen years, and was bowed together, and could in no wise lift up herself. And when Jesus saw her, he called her to him, and said unto her, Woman, thou art loosed from thine infirmity. And he laid his hands on her: and immediately she was made straight, and glorified God... And ought not this woman, being a daughter of Abraham, whom Satan hath bound, lo, these eighteen years, be loosed from this bond on the sabbath day?"

Luke 13:11-13, 16 KJV

<https://bible.com/bible/1/luk.13.11-16.KJV>

The Apostle John wrote that

'...The reason the Son of God appeared was to destroy the works of the devil.'

1 John 3:8b

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/1JN.3.8>

Whatever faults or weaknesses one has, the full salvation brought through Jesus Christ allows for Him to make them faultless (amōmos, G299) and blameless in God's presence (Jude 1:24). The redeeming and freeing blood of Jesus has sprinkled the nations, and this gospel of the kingdom will be proclaimed throughout the whole world as Jesus' church continues to be built up (Matthew 16:18-19, 24:14).

"...By oppression and judgment he was taken away; and as for his generation, who considered that he was cut off out of the land of the living, stricken for the transgression of my people? And they made his grave with the wicked and with a rich man in his death, although he had done no violence, and there was no deceit in his mouth. Yet it was the will of the Lord to crush him; he has put him to grief [he and made him sick]; when his soul makes [when you make his soul] an offering for guilt, he shall see his offspring; he shall prolong his days; the will of the Lord shall prosper in his hand. Out of the anguish of his soul he shall see and be satisfied; by his knowledge shall the righteous one, my servant, make

many to be accounted righteous, and he shall bear their iniquities. Therefore I will divide him a portion with the many, and he shall divide the spoil with the strong, because he poured out his soul to death and was numbered with the transgressors; yet he bore the sin of many, and makes intercession for the transgressors." [Notes from the English Standard Version are included in brackets]

Jesus, the Righteous One, died alongside criminals. He was sentenced to die by the Roman authority to appease a violent mob of Jews who demanded for Him to be crucified, although it was known He had done nothing wrong. He only spoke the truth and did good according to the will of His Father. One of the criminals recognized he had done wrong while Jesus had not, and showed faith when "...he said, "Jesus, remember me when you come into your kingdom."

Luke 23:42 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/luk.23.42.ESV>

For this simple confession of faith, Jesus gave to him eternal life, saying he would be with Jesus in paradise the same day. His sins (pesha', H6588, 'âvôn, H5771, 'âshâm, H817) were borne (nâšâ', H5375, sâbal, H5445; bastazō, G941) by Jesus, he was made right with God (righteous, tsaddîyq, H662; dikaïosunē, G1343, 2 Corinthians 5:21). This forgiven criminal was raised up together (sunegeirō, G4891) with Jesus and made to sit together (sugkathizō, G4776) in heavenly places in Christ Jesus (Ephesians 2:6).

For any that put their faith in the finished work of Jesus Christ for them, they receive life (zōē, G2222) in the same way. Jesus' atonement (kâphar, H3722; katallagē, G2643) makes men and women who receive Jesus as Lord at-one with the munificent God (1 Corinthians 2:16, 6:17; Ephesians 5:30), taking care of every need and countering every effect of sin. Because Jesus was made sick (châlâh, H2470) in His atonement and because His body was bruised and broken (dâkâ', H1792), the arm (zerôa, H2220) of the Lord was also revealed to heal (therapeuō, G2323) during His ministry—both in person and in His ongoing ministry through the body of Christ (Romans 8:11). Jesus' victory over sin, sickness and death became the same victory also for His church (2 Corinthians 2:14, Romans 8:37), accessible "by the faith of the Son of God" (Galatians 2:20 KJV). Jesus Christ has indeed destroyed (luō, G3089) the works (ergon, G2041) of the devil.

Jesus was buried in the grave of a rich man who was a disciple of his (Matthew 27:57-60). Meanwhile, the spirit of Jesus was in paradise with the criminal He saved, and He descended to hell to preach the gospel to those who were dead in order that some would live (zaō, G2198) in the Spirit (1 Peter 4:6). Jesus returned to earth to appear to His disciples many times and to interpret Scriptures concerning Himself to His disciples, preparing them for their ministry to the world as apostles who were to be led by the Spirit.

Jesus ascended to heaven, sitting on a throne at the right hand of the Father to make intercession for His church (the “many” who were justified, as mentioned in the bolded passage above; rab, H7227), having been given all authority over heaven and earth (Matthew 28:18-20). The regnant, living Jesus still rules on this Throne, and the Spirit of God that He received to give to His church is with each believer in some measure (Ephesians 4:7-16). This is the same spirit that raised Jesus from the dead (Romans 8:11)!

Through the atonement of Jesus, God has made believers the temple (naos, G3485) of the Holy Spirit (1 Corinthians 6:17,19-20), the living Christ dwelling and abiding (menō, G3306) in each of them, spirit, soul, and body (1 Corinthians 2:16, Ephesians 5:30), as branches (klēma, G2814) connected to the Vine (ampelos, G288, John 15:1,4-5).

God has divided (châlaq, H2505) His spoil (shâlâl, H7998) with His children: deliverance, salvation, freedom, healing, peace, wholeness, abundant life, blessing, belonging, hope. The Word of God living in them and empowering them as they each grow into the image of Christ (Romans 8:29, Ephesians 4:11-16), God’s children do the word of God (James 1:22-25) and the will of God for the glory of God, meeting the needs of the world. Jesus will continue to make intercession (entugchanō, G1793) for the children of God (Romans 8:34, Hebrews 7:25), those born again by faith, until all evil is put under His feet (1 Corinthians 15:25). In this, God’s will is done on earth as it is in heaven (Matthew 6:10). The will (chêphets, H2656) of the Lord (yehôvâh, H3068) has prospered (tsâlach, H6743) and will continue to prosper in His hand. God’s will for His church in the ages to come is to show the exceeding riches (ploutos, G4149) of His grace (charis, G5485) in His kindness (chrēstotēs, G5544) toward them through Christ Jesus (Ephesians 2:7).

The atonement was God's great, complete triumph of the Father for His children (Colossians 2:13-15), a product of His giving nature and His great love for all men and women formed in His image and likeness. Jesus has redeemed (agorazō, G59) His church out of every tribe and tongue and people and nation, making them kings (basileus, G935) and priests (hiereus, G2409) to our God (Revelation 5:9-10). As kings, the members of God's church are the royalty of God, sons and daughters of the King of kings. As priests, each member of the church is a servant of God to the world, each hiding behind the form and the loveliness of God's servant ('ebed, H5650), Jesus of Nazareth.

Day 33: Come to the waters

"Come, everyone who thirsts, come to the waters; and he who has no money, come, buy and eat! Come, buy wine and milk without money and without price. Why do you spend your money for that which is not bread, and your labor for that which does not satisfy? Listen diligently to me, and eat what is good, and delight yourselves in rich food. Incline your ear, and come to me; hear, that your soul may live; and I will make with you an everlasting covenant, my steadfast, sure love for David. Behold, I made him a witness to the peoples, a leader and commander for the peoples. Behold, you shall call a nation that you do not know, and a nation that did not know you shall run to you, because of the Lord your God, and of the Holy One of Israel, for he has glorified you. Seek the Lord while he may be found; call upon him while he is near; let the wicked forsake his way, and the unrighteous man his thoughts; let him return to the Lord, that he may have compassion on him, and to our God, for he will abundantly pardon. For my thoughts are not your thoughts, neither are your ways my ways, declares the Lord. For as the heavens are higher than the earth, so are my ways higher than your ways and my thoughts than your thoughts. For as the rain and the snow come down from heaven and do not return there but water the earth, making it bring forth and sprout, giving seed to the sower and bread to the eater, so shall my word be that goes out from my mouth; it shall not return to me empty, but it shall accomplish that which I purpose, and shall succeed in the thing for which I sent it. For you shall go out in joy and be led forth in peace; the mountains and the hills before you shall break forth into singing, and all the trees of the field shall clap their hands. Instead of the thorn shall come up the cypress; instead of the brier shall come up the myrtle; and it shall make a name for the Lord, an everlasting sign that shall not be cut off."

Isaiah 55:1-13 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/isa.55.1-13.ESV>

"Come, everyone who thirsts, come to the waters... Why do you spend your money for that which is not bread, and your labor for that which does not satisfy?..."

The Giver provides for His covenant people and satisfies them with good and with plenty. Yet those God has created seek satisfaction according to their own ways and purposes:

“for my people have committed two evils: they have forsaken me, the fountain of living waters, and hewed out cisterns for themselves, broken cisterns that can hold no water.”

Jeremiah 2:13 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/jer.2.13.ESV>

God has freely offered living (chay, H2416) water to the Jews through faith in Him, and God freely offers living (zaō, G2198) water to all through Jesus Christ (John 4:13-14, 7:37-39), the Way (hodos, G3598), the Truth (alētheia, G225), and the Life (zōē, G2222) of God (John 14:6), which starts with putting faith in His atoning work, thereby entering into covenant with God. Despite what God had done for His people, He says that His people have forsaken Him, instead laboring to hew out cisterns for themselves, hoping what is in the cisterns will bring life. However, any cistern built apart from God is broken (shābar, H7665). Any pursuit that does not seek first the fountain (māqôr, H4726) of living water will not satisfy. It holds no life and it leads in a way opposed to that of God’s way.

To those who put their faith in God and then give themselves fully to God, seeking to do His will (see Isaiah 58:6-10), God promised that
“... the Lord will guide you continually and satisfy your desire in scorched places and make your bones strong; and you shall be like a watered garden, like a spring of water, whose waters do not fail.”

Isaiah 58:11 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/iso.58.11.ESV>

God accomplishes this through His Spirit, first bringing life and then further nourishment. When God saves a son or a daughter (John 3:3-6), the at-first-invisible transformation is a miraculous one, a completely new creation (kainos ktisis, G2537+G2937 2 Corinthians 5:17), yet His work is not done (Ephesians 4:22-23). Giving life to their spirit by His Spirit, the creative work of God has only started to take root. God wants to bless them and make them a blessing as they continue by their daily, God-given choices to come to the waters. The Spirit He gives is an earnest (arrhabōn, G728) of heaven — a handful of the heavenly inheritance and the life to come (Ephesians 1:13-14, 2 Corinthians 1:20-22). The seed of the kingdom (basileia, G932) continues to grow (auxanō, G837) and mature as one comes to the living waters, undistracted by the cares of the world (Mark 4:26-32, Matthew 13:22-23, Colossians 2:19).

God invites any to *“...Listen diligently to me, and eat what is good, and delight yourselves in rich food. Incline your ear, and come to me; hear, that your soul may live; and I will make with you an everlasting covenant, my steadfast, sure love for David...”* The covenant-keeping (berîth, H1285) God has offered His steadfast love (chêsêd, H2617) and good (tôb, H2896) to all who will come (yâlak, H3212) to Him through Jesus Christ, listening (shâma’, H8085) diligently. Every good and perfect gift is from God (James 1:17), who is love (agapē, G26) and grace (charis, G5485). The kindness and the compassion of God is meant to lead His children to turn to Him (Romans 2:4), the Giver. God desires for His children to believe that He wills their good and He will provide it. In His great love for His children and as a reward for seeking (ekzēteō, G1567) Him (Hebrews 11:6), God continues to quicken (châyâh, H2421; suzōopoieō, G4806, zōopoieō, G2227) any who come to Him for Life (Ephesians 2:5-10, Romans 8:11). Jesus Christ, the Word of God, quickens spirit, soul and body, by way of the connecting medium of the Spirit of God in them.

“...For my thoughts are not your thoughts, neither are your ways my ways, declares the Lord. For as the heavens are higher than the earth, so are my ways higher than your ways and my thoughts than your thoughts. For as the rain and the snow come down from heaven and do not return there but water the earth, making it bring forth and sprout, giving seed to the sower and bread to the eater, so shall my word be that goes out from my mouth; it shall not return to me empty, but it shall accomplish that which I purpose, and shall succeed in the thing for which I sent it...”

The ways of God and His kingdom that Jesus brought near are not the ways of mankind and the kingdoms people build for themselves. In accordance with the love plan of God, Jesus came to seek (bâqar, H1239) and save (nâtsal, H5337) the lost (pûts, H6327) as the Good Shepherd (in fulfillment of the prophecy made by Ezekiel recorded in Ezekiel 34:11-13), rejoicing in every lost sheep that is found and returns (Matthew 18:12-13). It is God’s will (châphêts, H2654) that His children align their wills with His will (John 5:30, Romans 12:2), their ways (derek, H1870) with His ways, their thoughts (machashâbâh, H4284) with His thoughts, becoming doers (poiētēs, G4163) of the Word (logos, G3056) of God (James 1:22-25), not just hearers that act upon their own wills and go their own ways, building their own kingdoms for their own glory. God’s words (dâbâr, H1697) are His servants, and they will come

to pass ('âsâh, H6213; tsâlach, H6743). They do not return to Him empty. And so the word of God planted in a life as an imperishable (aphthartos, G862) seed (1 Peter 1:23), when born (yâlad, H3205), nourished, cherished, and fed at the waters, grows (tsâmach, H6779), brings life (zaō, G2198), and bears fruit (karpos, G2590), accomplishing the will and purpose (châphêts, H2654, thelō ethelō, G2309) of God (John 15:7-8). The children of God (those quickened with Christ, suzōpoieō, G4806, Colossians 2:3) then sow and reap, together bringing a harvest to God for the glory of God (2 Corinthians 9:6-15). The church, the body of Christ, is victorious in accomplishing God's redemptive and life-giving purposes.

And here is the result as the blueprint of God unfolds when His Word is accomplished: *"...For you shall go out in joy and be led forth in peace; the mountains and the hills before you shall break forth into singing, and all the trees of the field shall clap their hands. Instead of the thorn shall come up the cypress; instead of the brier shall come up the myrtle; and it shall make a name for the Lord, an everlasting sign that shall not be cut off."*

The trees of the field are the people of God, the body of Christ (see also Ezekiel 17:22-24), those whose spirits have been made alive by God and connected to Him (1 Corinthians 6:17). The church goes out in joy (śimchâh, H8057). It is led forth by the Spirit of God in peace (shâlôm, H7965). God's people rejoice as He makes things right through Jesus Christ and His good will (râtsôn, H7522, Isaiah 61:2; thelēma, G2307, Matthew 6:10) is done on earth as it is in heaven. His will is done through the redemption (apolutrōsis, G629) and sanctification (hagiasmos, G38, 1 Corinthians 1:30) of God's people and through the good works done by the church and by God's Spirit in the church, bringing honor and glory to God. Through the redemption and sanctification that God brings, He turns lack (châsêr, H2637, Psalms 23:1), pain (mak'ôb, H4341) and death (the thorn and the brier) into healing, uprightness, perseverance, strength, beauty, and life (the cypress and the myrtle). In Israel, the tall cypress (berôsh, H1265) has represented healing, uprightness, and the hope of eternal life; cypresses are long-living trees able to endure harsh climates and poor soil. A myrtle (hadas, H1918) is a slow-growing, fragrant tree, always green, with a strong root system and beautiful blossoms; even if cut to a stump (geza', H1503, Isaiah 11:1), it sprouts ('âlâh, H5927, pârah, H6509) again. God is the famous One. His kingdom and His goodness never ends, and He will continue to be exalted.

God calls everyone — each one like a potter's flask (Jeremiah 18-19, 2 Corinthians 4:7-18) — to come (yâlak, H3212) to the waters (potomos, G4215, John 7:38). We must die to ourselves and our old life in order to live (zaō, G2198). He is the fountain (mâqôr, H4726) of living (chay, H2416, Jeremiah 2:13) waters. There is fullness (plēorōma, G4138, plēroō, G4137) for filling (Colossians 2:9-10, Ephesians 3:19), pouring out (râvâh, H7301, Proverbs 11:25), and refilling (anakainoō, G341) at the waters (2 Corinthians 4:7-11,16). One can even jump in, immersed, infilled, caught up and led by the flow (derôr, H1865, Isaiah 61:1; rheō, G4482, John 7:38). Jesus invites any who thirst to come to God and drink (John 4:10,13-14), saying that rivers of living water will flow out of the hearts (koilia, G2836) of those who put their faith in Him (John 7:37-39).

Day 34: God will pour out His Spirit on all flesh

“Blow a trumpet in Zion; sound an alarm on my holy mountain! Let all the inhabitants of the land tremble, for the day of the Lord is coming; it is near... Yet even now,” declares the Lord, “return to me with all your heart, with fasting, with weeping, and with mourning; and rend your hearts and not your garments. Return to the Lord your God, for he is gracious and merciful, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love; and he relents over disaster... And it shall come to pass afterward, that I will pour out my Spirit on all flesh; your sons and your daughters shall prophesy, your old men shall dream dreams, and your young men shall see visions. Even on the male and female servants in those days I will pour out my Spirit. And I will show wonders in the heavens and on the earth, blood and fire and columns of smoke. The sun shall be turned to darkness, and the moon to blood, before the great and awesome day of the Lord comes. And it shall come to pass that everyone who calls on the name of the Lord shall be saved. For in Mount Zion and in Jerusalem there shall be those who escape, as the Lord has said, and among the survivors shall be those whom the Lord calls.”

Joel 2:1, 12-13, 28-32 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/jol.2.1-32.ESV>

“Blow a trumpet in Zion; sound an alarm on my holy mountain! Let all the inhabitants of the land tremble, for the day of the Lord is coming; it is near...”

A number of prophets spoke of the coming day of the Lord, a day of God's final judgment, including Isaiah:

“For the Lord of hosts has a day against all that is proud and lofty, against all that is lifted up—and it shall be brought low; ...And the haughtiness of man shall be humbled, and the lofty pride of men shall be brought low, and the Lord alone will be exalted in that day.”

Isaiah 2:12,17 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/iso.2.12-17.ESV>

The Apostle Peter was also a prophet, and he spoke of this day as well:

“The Lord is not slow to fulfill his promise as some count slowness, but is patient toward you, not wishing that any should perish, but that all should reach repentance. But the day of the Lord will come like a thief, and then the heavens will pass away with a roar, and the heavenly bodies will be burned up and

dissolved, and the earth and the works that are done on it will be exposed... But according to his promise we are waiting for new heavens and a new earth in which righteousness dwells."

2 Peter 3:9-10, 13 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/2pe.3.9-13.ESV>

It's also discussed in the Apostle John's vision in Revelation 20:7-21:7.

"...And I will show wonders in the heavens and on the earth, blood and fire and columns of smoke. The sun shall be turned to darkness, and the moon to blood, before the great and awesome day of the Lord comes...For in Mount Zion and in Jerusalem there shall be those who escape, as the Lord has said, and among the survivors shall be those whom the Lord calls..."

These prophecies refer again to events during the second coming of Jesus Christ, including the coming day of the Lord, which Jesus described, as recorded in the gospels of Matthew, Luke and Mark. Isaiah (13:10), Ezekiel (32:7), Zephaniah (1:15), and Zechariah (12-14) also described this time. Just as it was likely difficult to imagine what the life of Christ and the New Testament times would be like before the time of Christ, given the prophecies of the Old Testament alone—it is doubtful that anyone really knew—it is difficult to know details about the period of the second coming of Jesus beyond the glimpses into the future recorded in such passages.

'...“Yet even now,” declares the Lord, “return to me with all your heart, with fasting, with weeping, and with mourning; and rend your hearts and not your garments. Return to the Lord your God, for he is gracious and merciful, slow to anger, and abounding in steadfast love; and he relents over disaster..."

Just as the other prophets did, Peter included, Joel also called God's people to repentance (metanoia, G3341). To repent is to change one's mind in a way that is confirmed by one's choices; it is to put one's soul (mind, will, emotions) in the right relation to God. God, merciful (rachûm, H7349), gracious (channûn, H2587), and patient ('ârêk, H750), does not wish that any should perish. This is the way God revealed His good (chêšêd, H2617) character to Moses (Exodus 34:6-7). God desires all to repent so He can show His great love.

“...I will pour out my Spirit on all flesh; your sons and your daughters shall prophesy, your old men shall dream dreams, and your young men shall see visions. Even on the male and female servants in those days I will pour out my Spirit...And it shall come to pass that everyone who calls on the name of the Lord shall be saved.”

God gave a word (logos, G3056) of wisdom (sophia, G4678, 1 Corinthians 12:8) to the prophet Joel (yô’êl, H3100), whose name means Jehovah is God, to allow him to see a glimpse of what would occur hundreds of years later when Jesus brought the kingdom (basileia, G932) of God near (eggizō, G1448). Before His death, Jesus gave more information about this Spirit to his disciples:

‘“If you love me, you will keep my commandments. And I will ask the Father, and he will give you another Helper, to be with you forever, even the Spirit of truth, whom the world cannot receive, because it neither sees him nor knows him. You know him, for he dwells with you and will be in you. But the Helper, the Holy Spirit, whom the Father will send in my name, he will teach you all things and bring to your remembrance all that I have said to you.”’

John 14:15-17,26

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/JHN.14.15-17,26>

To the believers that were identified with Jesus in faith through His death and resurrection, He promised them that the Holy Spirit (rûach, H7307) who had dwelled with them, empowering (exousia, G1849) them in their ministry (e.g., Matthew 10:7-8,17:14-20, Luke 10:9,16,19), would instead live and abide (menō, G3306) in them as a Helper (paraklētos, G3875) for their continued ministry as Jesus’ ambassadors (presbeuō, G4243, 2 Corinthians 5:20). After Jesus’ resurrection, the following conversation happened between Jesus and his disciples:

‘So when they had come together, they asked him, “Lord, will you at this time restore the kingdom to Israel?” He said to them, “It is not for you to know times or seasons that the Father has fixed by his own authority. But you will receive power when the Holy Spirit has come upon you, and you will be my witnesses in Jerusalem and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the end of the earth.”’

Acts 1:6-8

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/ACT.1.6-8>

The following passage represents the beginning of the fulfillment of Joel’s prophecy:

'Then they returned to Jerusalem from the mount called Olivet, which is near Jerusalem, a Sabbath day's journey away. And when they had entered, they went up to the upper room, where they were staying, Peter and John and James and Andrew, Philip and Thomas, Bartholomew and Matthew, James the son of Alphaeus and Simon the Zealot and Judas the son of James. All these with one accord were devoting themselves to prayer, together with the women and Mary the mother of Jesus, and his brothers. In those days Peter stood up among the brothers (the company of persons was in all about 120) and said, ...'

Acts 1:12-15

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/ACT.1.12-15>

'When the day of Pentecost arrived, they were all together in one place. And suddenly there came from heaven a sound like a mighty rushing wind, and it filled the entire house where they were sitting. And divided tongues as of fire appeared to them and rested on each one of them. And they were all filled with the Holy Spirit and began to speak in other tongues as the Spirit gave them utterance.'

Acts 2:1-4

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/ACT.2.1-4>

The Holy Spirit came upon (shâphak, H8210) about 120 persons, male and female followers of Jesus, who spoke through their spirits in foreign tongues (glōssa, G1100) they did not know, praising God in the languages of the Jews who had come to Jerusalem from distant lands to celebrate Pentecost. This is prophecy (nâbâ', H5012; prophēteuō, G4395) as it is described in the Old Testament—when the Holy Spirit comes on those who are anointed (e.g., 1 Samuel 10:6-13). The event in Jerusalem was a sign from God for those visiting, causing thousands to put their faith in Jesus. Peter, after being led by the Spirit to preach and teach the crowd, described though how the gift of the indwelling Holy Spirit from Jesus was for all flesh:

'And Peter said to them, "Repent and be baptized every one of you in the name of Jesus Christ for the forgiveness of your sins, and you will receive the gift of the Holy Spirit. For the promise is for you and for your children and for all who are far off, everyone whom the Lord our God calls to himself."'

Acts 2:38-39

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/ACT.2.38-39>

In addition to tongues and prophecy, there are records of God speaking to believers through many visions throughout the rest of the book of Acts. Joel's

prophecy did come to pass after the resurrection of Jesus, and the Apostle Paul taught that these gifts (charisma, G5486) from God, exercised in love (agapē, G26), should continue to build up (oikodomē, G3619) the church (ekklēsia, G1577, 1 Corinthians 12-14).

Joel lived about 2800 years ago, and yet his prophecy from God was one that showed equality among all of God's children. The beginning of Christianity started to bring this to bear. Christ's followers were male and female, coming from all classes of society, yet acting in one accord (homothumadon, G3661, Acts 2:1,46, 4:24, 5:12, 8:6). God sees neither male nor female, slave nor free; all believers are beloved children of God (Acts 10:44-48, Galatians 3:28, Romans 10:9-13). All who put their faith in Jesus may experience God's full salvation (sōzō, G4982). Additionally, for societies that have experienced significant explosions of the gospel of Jesus Christ over the last two thousand years, one important part of the legacy has been increased freedoms for all men, women and children, including human rights.

Day 35: God's King and High Priest

' "Behold, the days are coming, declares the Lord , when I will fulfill the promise I made to the house of Israel and the house of Judah. In those days and at that time I will cause a righteous Branch to spring up for David, and he shall execute justice and righteousness in the land. In those days Judah will be saved, and Jerusalem will dwell securely. And this is the name by which it will be called: 'The Lord is our righteousness.' "For thus says the Lord : David shall never lack a man to sit on the throne of the house of Israel, and the Levitical priests shall never lack a man in my presence to offer burnt offerings, to burn grain offerings, and to make sacrifices forever." The word of the Lord came to Jeremiah: "Thus says the Lord : If you can break my covenant with the day and my covenant with the night, so that day and night will not come at their appointed time, then also my covenant with David my servant may be broken, so that he shall not have a son to reign on his throne, and my covenant with the Levitical priests my ministers. As the host of heaven cannot be numbered and the sands of the sea cannot be measured, so I will multiply the offspring of David my servant, and the Levitical priests who minister to me." '

Jeremiah 33:14-22

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/JER.33.14-22>

Jeremiah (yirmeyâh, H3414), meaning "whom Jehovah has appointed," lived in the day where God judged Israel and Judah for its unfaithfulness to Him. Some of the prophets speaking the word of God compared God's people to a bride (e.g., see Jeremiah 2:2) that had given herself away to other lovers. God told Jeremiah, "... to all to whom I send you, you shall go, and whatever I command you, you shall speak" and "I am watching over my word to perform it" (Jeremiah 1:7,12). As a prophet, Jeremiah was mainly to speak God's words (dâbâr, H1697) of judgment: "Is not my word like fire, declares the Lord, and like a hammer that breaks the rock in pieces?"

Jeremiah 23:29 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/jer.23.29.ESV>

This made for a difficult life for Jeremiah, who said:

'For whenever I speak, I cry out, I shout, "Violence and destruction!" For the word of the Lord has become for me a reproach and derision all day long. If I say, "I will

not mention him, or speak any more in his name," there is in my heart as it were a burning fire shut up in my bones, and I am weary with holding it in, and I cannot.'
Jeremiah 20:8-9 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/jer.20.8-9.ESV>

Jeremiah, made zealous by the Spirit of God that was with him, could not help but be obedient to speak the words God gave him to speak.

"...In those days and at that time I will cause a righteous Branch to spring up for David, and he shall execute justice and righteousness in the land..."

Although most of Jeremiah's prophecies were about judgment for Judah's disobedience, he also spoke words of hope from the covenant-keeping (berîth, H1285) God for what Jesus Christ would begin to bring to the world starting about 600 years later. Although the house of Judah had been cut down to a stump due to God's judgment (Isaiah 11:1), given over to captivity in Babylon, a righteous (tsedâqâh, H6666) branch (tsemach, H6780) would spring up (tsâmach, H6779) from the line of Judah and David. This branch was Jesus, who made available the rightness of God not only for Israel but for anyone from any nation that has faith in Him. Faith in Jesus' finished work puts men and women in right relation with God, even as the Apostle Paul wrote:

"For our sake [God] made [Jesus] to be sin who knew no sin, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God."

2 Corinthians 5:21 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/2co.5.21.ESV>

The righteousness (dikaïosunē, G1343) Christ our Redeemer (gâ'al, H1350) brings is in many parts.

The righteousness of God is for each believer. When Christ, the true Vine (John 15:1), abides (menō, G3306) in a life consecrated (qâdash, H6942) to Him, steadfast faith in the Lord can lead to the rightness of God in one's spirit (the part in contact with God), soul (mind, emotions, will), body, home, affairs, business, everywhere. As the regnant King (basileus, G935) of kings with all authority (exousia, G1849) over heaven and earth (Matthew 28:18, Revelation 19:16); the High Priest (archiereus, G749) who makes intercession at the right hand of God for the saints (Hebrews 4:14-5:10); and the One who dwells in believers (Colossians 1:27), even as they dwell in Him (1 Corinthians 12:27), Jesus Christ and the Holy Spirit

respond to faith to provide for that which is lacking due to the effects of original sin. God provides for the advancement of His own will, purposes and glory. Jeremiah said God would make his church into priests (kôhên, H3548) who minister (shârath, H8334) to Him, and priests are servants ('ebed, H5650) of men, doing God's will, not their own will. Abiding (menô, G3306) in the Vine, each believer is quickened (châyâh, H2421) by the Word (dâbâr, H1697; logos, G3056) of God (Psalm 119:107, 1 Peter 1:23), becoming a partaker (koinōnos, G2844) of the divine nature (2 Peter 1:3-4), part of His body, Christ living in them. Each believer is a jewel in the diadems (diadēma, G1238) of Jesus Christ (Revelation 19:12), each one precious to God (Zephaniah 3:17).

The righteousness of God is for the church. The church is made right as members of the body of Christ that joins them to God, making them more like God through the work of the indwelling Holy Spirit (Ephesians 4:11-16). Ultimately, this will lead to God's children, the church, being made kings and priests (Revelation 1:6, 5:10), "that in the coming ages he might show the immeasurable riches of his grace in kindness toward [them] in Christ Jesus" (Ephesians 2:7). This includes a great multitude (ochlos, G3793) from all nations (gôy, H1471; ethnos, G1484) that no one can number (Revelation 7:9), just as God promised to Abraham in response to His faith (Genesis 22:16-18). In following God on His own terms, there is reward both in life now and especially in the life to come according to God's promise of abundant life (zōē, G2222, John 10:10).

"...In those days Judah will be saved, and Jerusalem will dwell securely. And this is the name by which it will be called: 'The Lord is our righteousness.'..."

The righteousness of God is also for Judah and Israel (yisrâ'êl, H3478, meaning God prevails), although there are some theological differences about how Scripture is to be interpreted in this respect i.e., in what order Scripture will be fulfilled. To Judah, Jeremiah proclaimed:

"For thus says the Lord: When seventy years are completed for Babylon, I will visit you, and I will fulfill to you my promise and bring you back to this place. For I know the plans I have for you, declares the Lord, plans for welfare and not for evil, to give you a future and a hope. Then you will call upon me and come and pray to me, and I will hear you. You will seek me and find me, when you seek me with all your heart. I will be found by you, declares the Lord, and I will restore your

fortunes and gather you from all the nations and all the places where I have driven you, declares the Lord, and I will bring you back to the place from which I sent you into exile.'

Jeremiah 29:10-14

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/JER.29.10-14>

God watched over (shâqad, H8245) His word (dâbâr, H1697) spoken through Jeremiah to perform it ('âsâh, H6213, Jeremiah 1:12), giving His people welfare (shâlôm, H7965), a future, and a hope (tiqvâh, H8615). Furthermore, in Christ's second coming (Acts 15:16-17), Jesus, the Holy One (qâdôsh, H6918) of Israel, will be revealed to all of Israel (Zechariah 12:10). The people of Israel will believe in Him and be made righteous (tsaddîyq, H6662, Isaiah 25:9, Isaiah 60:21). Jesus will reign as King on earth for a thousand years, delivering those in Israel, bringing justice (mishpât, H4941), righteousness (tsedâqâh, H6666), and security (betach, H983 ;see also Micah 4:3, Isaiah 2:3, 33:24, 65:19). Then they will also inherit the immeasurable riches of God as part of God's church (Revelation 21:1-7).

In His steadfast love, this is what the Lord our Righteousness (Jehovah Tsidkenu, yehôvâh tsidqênû, H3072) has prepared for His beloved bride (Revelation 19:7-8), made alive together with (suzôopoieō, G4806) Christ and blessed with every spiritual blessing (Ephesians 1:3,2:5).

"...As the host of heaven cannot be numbered and the sands of the sea cannot be measured, so I will multiply the offspring of David my servant, and the Levitical priests who minister to me."

For now though, the Lord of hosts (tsâbâ', H6635) desires to multiply (râbâh, H7235) His church, and so He has commanded His beloved people to

' "Enlarge the place of your tent, and let the curtains of your habitations be stretched out; do not hold back; lengthen your cords and strengthen your stakes. For you will spread abroad to the right and to the left, and your offspring will possess the nations and will people the desolate cities. "Fear not, for you will not be ashamed; be not confounded, for you will not be disgraced; for you will forget the shame of your youth, and the reproach of your widowhood you will remember no more. For your Maker is your husband, the Lord of hosts is his name; and the Holy One of Israel is your Redeemer, the God of the whole earth he is called. '

Isaiah 54:2-5

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/ISA.54.2-5>

Day 36: A new covenant written on the heart

“Behold, the days are coming, declares the Lord, when I will make a new covenant with the house of Israel and the house of Judah, not like the covenant that I made with their fathers on the day when I took them by the hand to bring them out of the land of Egypt, my covenant that they broke, though I was their husband, declares the Lord. For this is the covenant that I will make with the house of Israel after those days, declares the Lord: I will put my law within them, and I will write it on their hearts. And I will be their God, and they shall be my people. And no longer shall each one teach his neighbor and each his brother, saying, ‘Know the Lord,’ for they shall all know me, from the least of them to the greatest, declares the Lord. For I will forgive their iniquity, and I will remember their sin no more.”

Jeremiah 31:31-34 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/jer.31.31-34.ESV>

“Behold, the days are coming, declares the Lord, when I will make a new covenant with the house of Israel and the house of Judah, not like the covenant that I made with their fathers on the day when I took them by the hand to bring them out of the land of Egypt, my covenant that they broke, though I was their husband, declares the Lord...”

God spoke through Jeremiah about the time when He would make a new (châqâsh, H2319) covenant (berîth, H1285) with His people through Jesus Christ. God dearly loved Israel as a bride, yet Israel had broken covenant with God again and again. God has continued to pursue union with men and women and communion with them, as a husband (bâ'al, H1166) seeks such from a bride and a bride from her husband. This is a relationship that men and women understand, as God has written it on the human heart that such faithfulness should be expected in a marriage relationship, or any serious relationship leading to marriage. With respect to Israel, God, who is known by His character of steadfast love, had been faithful, and He had desired faithfulness in return. In the time of Jeremiah, the people were unfaithful though.

“...For this is the covenant that I will make with the house of Israel after those days, declares the Lord: I will put my law within them, and I will write it on their

hearts. And I will be their God, and they shall be my people. And no longer shall each one teach his neighbor and each his brother, saying, 'Know the Lord,' for they shall all know me, from the least of them to the greatest, declares the Lord. For I will forgive their iniquity, and I will remember their sin no more."

Through the new covenant (diathēkē, G1242) brought about by the death and resurrection of Jesus Christ, God Himself made atonement for His bride in order to forgive her iniquity, giving the Holy Spirit to make alive in spirit those who put their faith in Jesus' finished work. When men and women give themselves over to the redemptive work of God and consecrate themselves to Him, the Holy Spirit writes (kâthab, H3789; epigraphō, G1924) the law (tôrâh, H8451; nomos, G3551) of love (apapē, G26, John 15:12, Romans 13:10) on their hearts (lêb, H3820; kardia, G2588) and minds (qereb, H7130; dianoia, G1271). Love for God draws them to love God as He desires to be loved. Love for men and women made in God's image and likeness causes them to keep God's law of love in regard to others (Luke 10:25-37). This is the type of love that the Apostle Paul wrote about in 1 Corinthians 13. It is the generous, unselfish, abundant love that everyone wants; it only comes from union and communion with the Almighty God. (It is probably also the Apostle Paul that wrote about this prophecy from Jeremiah in Hebrews 10:12-24.) It is the tender love for all that was exhibited by Jesus Christ during His ministry, while He was connected with His Father through the Holy Spirit.

Also during the time of the rule of Babylon (around 600-550 BC), the Spirit of God prophesied nearly the same thing through the prophet Ezekiel:

"I will sprinkle clean water on you, and you shall be clean from all your uncleannesses, and from all your idols I will cleanse you. And I will give you a new heart, and a new spirit I will put within you. And I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh and give you a heart of flesh. And I will put my Spirit within you, and cause you to walk in my statutes and be careful to obey my rules."

Ezekiel 36:25-27 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/ezk.36.25-27.ESV>

In the work of sanctification, God writes His law of love on a man or woman's heart. He does this on hearts consecrated to Him because it is to those that His Vine is connected (John 15:1, 1 Corinthians 6:17) through the Spirit of God. Fused to God in Christ (John 17:21), the Spirit of God infuses the resurrection life of Jesus

Christ and the love of God into the spirit, soul, and body of His church. Jesus commanded His followers,

“A new commandment I give to you, that you love one another: just as I have loved you, you also are to love one another.”

John 13:34 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/jhn.13.34.ESV>

It is God's will that His children show His love, growing up into the image of Christ (Ephesians 4:11-16). God is love (1 John 4:8), and to love others well with an unselfish love is to be formed to His image. This includes loving the marginalized (see Day 9), the unlovable, and loving one's enemies (Matthew 5:43-48). Rightly connected to God in steadfast faith, men and women are filled with God's love and it flows out of them (ekcheō, G1632) in various ways as a fruit of this connection (Romans 5:5).

(The following discussion is taken from the words of an unknown author.) Joy (chara, G5479) is love on wings. Peace (eirēnē, G1515) is love folding its wings, and nestling under the wings of God. Longsuffering (makrothumia, G3115) is love enduring. Gentleness (chrēstotēs, G5544) is love in society. Goodness (agathōsunē, G19) is love in activity. Faith (pistis, G4102) is love confiding. Meekness (praotēs, G4236) is love stooping. Temperance (egkrateia, G1466) is true self-love, and the proper regard for our own real interests, which is as much the duty of love, as regard for the interests of others (Galatians 5:22-23). Possessed of the Holy Spirit, the body of Christ partakes (koinōnos, G2844, 2 Peter 1:4) of the divine nature of love.

This is the type of love that God has for each person He has saved (yâsha', H3467): 'The Lord your God is in your midst, a mighty one who will save; he will rejoice over you with gladness; he will quiet you by his love; he will exult over you with loud singing.'

Zephaniah 3:17

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/ZEP.3.17>

The depth of the love of God is astounding! In view of God's great love, the Apostle Paul encouraged the church:

“Let us hold fast the confession of our hope without wavering, for he who promised is faithful. And let us consider how to stir up one another to love and good works...”

Hebrews 10:23-24 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/heb.10.23-24.ESV>

In view of the overwhelming goodness of our God and the fullness of our inheritance in Christ, let us as his workmanship (poiēma, G4161) both stir up (anazōpureō, G329) the gift (charisma, G5486) of the Spirit inside of us (2 Timothy 1:6) and stir up (paroxusmos, G3948) each other to be zealous (zēlōtēs, G2207) of the good works (Titus 2:14) that God has prepared in advance (proetoimazō, G4282) for us (Ephesians 2:10).

Day 37: The faith of the men of Judah in Babylon

"But Daniel resolved that he would not defile himself with the king's food, or with the wine that he drank. Therefore he asked the chief of the eunuchs to allow him not to defile himself. And God gave Daniel favor and compassion in the sight of the chief of the eunuchs, and the chief of the eunuchs said to Daniel, "I fear my Lord the king, who assigned your food and your drink; for why should he see that you were in worse condition than the youths who are of your own age? So you would endanger my head with the king." Then Daniel said to the steward whom the chief of the eunuchs had assigned over Daniel, Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah, "Test your servants for ten days; let us be given vegetables to eat and water to drink. Then let our appearance and the appearance of the youths who eat the king's food be observed by you, and deal with your servants according to what you see." So he listened to them in this matter, and tested them for ten days. At the end of ten days it was seen that they were better in appearance and fatter in flesh than all the youths who ate the king's food. So the steward took away their food and the wine they were to drink, and gave them vegetables. As for these four youths, God gave them learning and skill in all literature and wisdom, and Daniel had understanding in all visions and dreams."

Daniel 1:8-17 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/dan.1.8-17.ESV>

"In the second year of the reign of Nebuchadnezzar, Nebuchadnezzar had dreams; his spirit was troubled, and his sleep left him. Then the king commanded that the magicians, the enchanters, the sorcerers, and the Chaldeans be summoned to tell the king his dreams. So they came in and stood before the king... The king answered and said to the Chaldeans, "The word from me is firm: if you do not make known to me the dream and its interpretation, you shall be torn limb from limb, and your houses shall be laid in ruins... [They replied "The thing that the king asks is difficult, and no one can show it to the king except the gods, whose dwelling is not with flesh." Because of this the king was angry and very furious, and commanded that all the wise men of Babylon be destroyed. So the decree went out, and the wise men were about to be killed; and they sought Daniel and his companions, to kill them. Then Daniel replied with prudence and discretion to Arioch, the captain of the king's guard, who had gone out to kill the

wise men of Babylon. He declared to Arioch, the king's captain, "Why is the decree of the king so urgent?" Then Arioch made the matter known to Daniel. And Daniel went in and requested the king to appoint him a time, that he might show the interpretation to the king. Then Daniel went to his house and made the matter known to Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah, his companions, and told them to seek mercy from the God of heaven concerning this mystery, so that Daniel and his companions might not be destroyed with the rest of the wise men of Babylon. Then the mystery was revealed to Daniel in a vision of the night. Then Daniel blessed the God of heaven."

Daniel 2:1-2, 5, 11-19 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/dan.2.1-19.ESV>

"Nebuchadnezzar answered and said to them, "Is it true, O Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego, that you do not serve my gods or worship the golden image that I have set up? Now if you are ready when you hear the sound of the horn, pipe, lyre, trigon, harp, bagpipe, and every kind of music, to fall down and worship the image that I have made, well and good. But if you do not worship, you shall immediately be cast into a burning fiery furnace. And who is the god who will deliver you out of my hands?" Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego answered and said to the king, "O Nebuchadnezzar, we have no need to answer you in this matter. If this be so, our God whom we serve is able to deliver us from the burning fiery furnace, and he will deliver us out of your hand, O king. But if not, be it known to you, O king, that we will not serve your gods or worship the golden image that you have set up." ...Then these men were bound in their cloaks, their tunics, their hats, and their other garments, and they were thrown into the burning fiery furnace... Then King Nebuchadnezzar was astonished and rose up in haste. He declared to his counselors, "Did we not cast three men bound into the fire?" They answered and said to the king, "True, O king." He answered and said, "But I see four men unbound, walking in the midst of the fire, and they are not hurt; and the appearance of the fourth is like a son of the gods." Then Nebuchadnezzar came near to the door of the burning fiery furnace; he declared, "Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego, servants of the Most High God, come out, and come here!" Then Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego came out from the fire."

Daniel 3:14-18, 21, 24-26 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/dan.3.14-26.ESV>

Jeremiah had written a letter to the exiles of Judah in Babylon, telling them that God had plans for their welfare (shâlôm, H7965, Jeremiah 29:11), and they were directed:

“But seek the welfare of the city where I have sent you into exile, and pray to the Lord on its behalf, for in its welfare you will find your welfare.”

Jeremiah 29:7 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/jer.29.7.ESV>

Daniel, Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah were youths among these exiles, men who had strong faith in who God is and what His plans were for them. As exiles, they received a world class education for three years, learning the literature and language of the Chaldeans (Daniel 1:4-5). Meanwhile, they were expected to eat and drink the food given to them to make them strong for future service to the king. Daniel resolved to be faithful to God, who had commanded them to abstain from some of this food. God honored Daniel's faithfulness, giving him favor (chêsêd, H2617) and tender love (racham, H7356) with the eunuch put in charge of him despite the risk posed to his life of not obeying the instructions of the king. God also strengthened Daniel, Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah physically on their limited diet, even more so than the others who were on the Chaldean diet. God blessed them in their learning (sêpher, H5612), and He also gave Daniel a gift of His Spirit that allowed him to understand the way God speaks in dreams and visions. In this, Daniel was enabled by the Holy Spirit to have a supernatural understanding (bîyn, H995) of the revealed mind and purpose of God. God honors faith and obedience.

When Daniel was told that they were about to be executed at the whim of the king, he trusted the plan of God for his welfare and he took action, completely confident that God would come through by way of the gift God had given him. He stayed the executions by making an appointment with the king to recount the king's dream and reveal to him its meaning. Daniel and his companions sought the mercy of God in their complete dependence on Him. They asked in faith for wisdom from God and did not doubt (James 1:5-7). God was faithful to come through for them, revealing the wisdom needed to save the people of Judah to Daniel as he slept. Daniel's response was to bless (or praise, berak, H1289) God. He worshiped the living God, steadfast in His love and rich in mercy. Further, in the

dream that Daniel interpreted, the kingdom (malkû, H4437) that would never be destroyed was the kingdom that Jesus Christ would bring (Daniel 2:44).

The result was glory to God and continued favor and blessing for Daniel:

"The king answered and said to Daniel, "Truly, your God is God of gods and Lord of kings, and a revealer of mysteries, for you have been able to reveal this mystery."

Then the king gave Daniel high honors and many great gifts, and made him ruler over the whole province of Babylon and chief prefect over all the wise men of Babylon."

Daniel 2:47-48 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/dan.2.47-48.ESV>

Yet the king, having no real understanding of God and no relationship with Him, proceeded to command everyone to worship an idol at the penalty of death for disobedience. However, Hananiah (chananyâh, H2608, meaning God has favored), Mishaël (mîyshâ'êl, H4332, meaning Who is Like God?), and Azariah ('azaryâh, H5838, meaning Jehoved has helped) were men of faith. The men would not obey the king to save their lives. They trusted God with no backup plan. They released their faith when they said to the king, *"...our God whom we serve is able to deliver us from the burning fiery furnace, and he will deliver us out of your hand, O king. But if not, be it known to you, O king, that we will not serve your gods or worship the golden image that you have set up."*

Who is like God? No one. They knew they would be helped by the God of grace and mercy, just as their fathers, including Moses (see Psalm 91, Day 10) and David (see Psalm 40), had been. Like Joshua, they were strong and courageous (see Day 14). In their steadfast faith, they were made invincible, God acting on their behalf, and the rest is history. They were protected in a supernatural way by the Lord God Almighty (El Shaddai, 'êl shadday, H410+H7706, Genesis 17:1) when their faith activated the power (dunamis, G1411) of the Spirit of God that was with them.

These men of Judah had the kind of faith that Jesus instructed in the face of death and major difficulties:

"Do not fear, only believe" (Mark 5:36).

'...“Have faith in God. Truly, I say to you, whoever says to this mountain, ‘Be taken up and thrown into the sea,’ and does not doubt in his heart, but believes that what he says will come to pass, it will be done for him. ’ (Mark 11:22-23)

They believed (pisteuō, G4100) that those which they spoke (legō, G3004) would come to pass (ginomai, G1096), and so they did. The word (logos, G3056) of God is unbreakable (ou dunami luō, 3756+G1410+G3089, John 10:35).

Through Jeremiah, God said the following about those who trust (bâtach, H982; mibtâch, H4009) in Him:

“Blessed is the man who trusts in the Lord, whose trust is the Lord. He is like a tree planted by water, that sends out its roots by the stream, and does not fear when heat comes, for its leaves remain green, and is not anxious in the year of drought, for it does not cease to bear fruit.”

Jeremiah 17:7-8

<https://my.bible.com/bible/59/JER.17.7-8>

Steadfast faith allows God's people to stand firm (histēmi, G2476) as the men of Judah did (Ephesians 6:13,16), nourished by the Spirit of God, and it releases the blessings of God that flow from His very nature , character, substance and essence.

Day 38: Daniel's vision of the son of man and of God's kingdom

"I saw in the night visions, and behold, with the clouds of heaven there came one like a son of man, and he came to the Ancient of Days and was presented before him. And to him was given dominion and glory and a kingdom, that all peoples, nations, and languages should serve him; his dominion is an everlasting dominion, which shall not pass away, and his kingdom one that shall not be destroyed. As for me, Daniel, my spirit within me was anxious, and the visions of my head alarmed me. I approached one of those who stood there and asked him the truth concerning all this. So he told me and made known to me the interpretation of the things. 'These four great beasts are four kings who shall arise out of the earth. But the saints of the Most High shall receive the kingdom and possess the kingdom forever, forever and ever.' ...And the kingdom and the dominion and the greatness of the kingdoms under the whole heaven shall be given to the people of the saints of the Most High; his kingdom shall be an everlasting kingdom, and all dominions shall serve and obey him."

Daniel 7:13-18, 27 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/dan.7.13-27.ESV>

Daniel had a gift from the Spirit of God to see and impart a secret and hidden wisdom from God (1 Corinthians 2:7). About 500 years before the time of Jesus' ministry, he saw a vision of Jesus, the Son of Man, being glorified by God the Father, the Ancient of Days. The discussion below considers two main aspects: the kingdom of God ushered in during Jesus' ministry and the clouds of heaven that refer to His second coming.

The kingdom of God. God had promised an eternal kingdom that was composed of nations to Abram (Genesis 17:6-7), who became Abraham ('abrâhâm, H85), meaning father of many. God also made this promise to his descendent David (2 Samuel 7:12-16). This eternal kingdom (mamlâkâh, H4467) was spoken of also by Isaiah (Isaiah 9:6-7) and Jeremiah (Jeremiah 33:15-22). Daniel saw this kingdom (malkû, H4437, sholtân, H7985) given to Jesus Christ in his vision.

The angel Gabriel said of Jesus before His birth, "He will be great and will be called the Son of the Most High. And the Lord God will give to him the throne of

his father David, and he will reign over the house of Jacob forever, and of his kingdom there will be no end."

Luke 1:32-33 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/luk.1.32-33.ESV>

Jesus' ministry consisted of preaching that this kingdom (basileia, G932) had come near (or was at hand), teaching, and healing all who were sick and afflicted (Matthew 4:23-24, 9:35-36) out of His great tenderness and compassion (splanchnizomai, G4697). Through His ministry and especially through His resurrection from death, Jesus demonstrated the power, the authority, and the good will of God to bring freedom, salvation, and life to any that show faith in Him (Matthew 8:17, 28:18, Acts 10:38).

When Jesus was on trial by the Jewish Council, He claimed to be the fulfillment of this vision given to Daniel: "But he remained silent and made no answer. Again the high priest asked him, "Are you the Christ, the Son of the Blessed?" And Jesus said, "I am, and you will see the Son of Man seated at the right hand of Power, and coming with the clouds of heaven." And the high priest tore his garments and said, "What further witnesses do we need? You have heard his blasphemy. What is your decision?" And they all condemned him as deserving death."

Mark 14:61-64 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/mrk.14.61-64.ESV>

It was this claim by Jesus to be the Son of Man spoken of by Daniel which caused the Jewish Council to feel justified in sentencing Him to die. Yet, Jesus was speaking what was true. The unbelieving dead will be raised and stand before Jesus at the judgment (Revelation 20:11-12, Jude 14-15).

"...And the kingdom and the dominion and the greatness of the kingdoms under the whole heaven shall be given to the people of the saints of the Most High; his kingdom shall be an everlasting kingdom, and all dominions shall serve and obey him."

Because of Jesus' obedience to carry out His Father's will, "...God has highly exalted him and bestowed on him the name that is above every name, so that at the name of Jesus every knee should bow, in heaven and on earth and under the

earth, and every tongue confess that Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of God the Father."

Philippians 2:9-11 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/php.2.9-11.ESV>

The ministry of Jesus continues through the church, the body of Christ. The Apostle Paul wrote that the end will come "when [Jesus] delivers the kingdom to God the Father after destroying every rule and every authority and power. For he must reign until he has put all his enemies under his feet. The last enemy to be destroyed is death."

1 Corinthians 15:24-26 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/1co.15.24-26.ESV>

All dominions (sholtân, H7985) are subject to Jesus. Through the good works of His body, the body of Christ, He puts His enemies under His feet even now (Matthew 16:18-19).

The clouds of heaven. "...with the clouds of heaven there came one like a son of man..."

The clouds of heaven are mentioned in the passages from Daniel 7 and Mark 14.

The Apostle John also wrote the following from God's revelation to him:

"...Jesus Christ the faithful witness, the firstborn of the dead, and the ruler of kings on earth. To him who loves us and has freed us from our sins by his blood and made us a kingdom, priests to his God and Father, to him be glory and dominion forever and ever. Amen. Behold, he is coming with the clouds, and every eye will see him, even those who pierced him, and all tribes of the earth will wail on account of him. Even so. Amen."

Revelation 1:5-7 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/rev.1.5-7.ESV>

From this passage, one sees that the kingdom of God consists of the people of God, those made in God's image and likeness, who will live eternally with Him in His presence. They are God's glory. At His second coming, every eye will see a vision of Him coming with the clouds, including those in power responsible for killing Jesus. The clouds the Bible refers to could literally be clouds, or they may be the clouds (nephos, G3509) of witnesses (martus, G3144) mentioned in Hebrews 12:1, those who have been faithful to God. These holy ones (hagios, G40) are also mentioned by Jude:

“...Behold, the Lord comes with ten thousands of his holy ones, to execute judgment on all and to convict all the ungodly of all their deeds of ungodliness that they have committed in such an ungodly way, and of all the harsh things that ungodly sinners have spoken against him.”

Jude 1:14-15 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/jud.1.14-15.ESV>

These faithful ones are not made perfect or complete (teleioō, G5048) until joined by the rest of the body of Christ (Hebrews 11:39-40), His precious bride (Revelation 19:7-8), an answer to His prayer in John 17:21-23. The church will be with Jesus when He is revealed so that every eye can see Him in His glory, His good work (poiēma, G4161, Ephesians 2:10, Romans 1:20) surrounding Him.

The prophet Zechariah also spoke to this time of Jesus’ second coming:

““And I will pour out on the house of David and the inhabitants of Jerusalem a spirit of grace and pleas for mercy, so that, when they look on me, on him whom they have pierced, they shall mourn for him, as one mourns for an only child, and weep bitterly over him, as one weeps over a firstborn.”

Zechariah 12:10 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/zec.12.10.ESV>

The tribes will mourn separately (Zechariah 12:12-14), and forgiveness will be given (Zechariah 13:1). God’s people started out of Israel, and the last additions to the bride of Christ, grafted in as branches to the Vine, will be out of Israel as well (Romans 11:24).

While Christ has offered abundance (perissos, G4053) of life (zōē, G2222) in the present (John 7:38-39, John 10:10), the future hope of His church is even brighter (Isaiah 60:17-21). Ultimately, the eternal kingdom for the body of Christ is the new heavens and earth described in Revelation 21:1-7. This is good news for Christ’s church:

“But God, being rich in mercy, because of the great love with which he loved us, even when we were dead in our trespasses, made us alive together with Christ—by grace you have been saved—and raised us up with him and seated us with him in the heavenly places in Christ Jesus, so that in the coming ages he might show the immeasurable riches of his grace in kindness toward us in Christ Jesus.”

Ephesians 2:4-7 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/eph.2.4-7>

Our generous Creator has a love plan of abundant, eternal life in store (John 14:1-3) for His children in faith that is better than can be imagined (Ephesians 3:7-21). He has raised us up together (sunegeirō, G4891) with Himself, seated us together (sugkathizō, G4776) with Himself, and made our joy full (John 15:11).

Day 39: Daniel's prayers

'Daniel answered and said: "Blessed be the name of God forever and ever, to whom belong wisdom and might. He changes times and seasons; he removes kings and sets up kings; he gives wisdom to the wise and knowledge to those who have understanding; he reveals deep and hidden things; he knows what is in the darkness, and the light dwells with him. To you, O God of my fathers, I give thanks and praise, for you have given me wisdom and might, and have now made known to me what we asked of you, for you have made known to us the king's matter."

Daniel 2:20-23 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/dan.2.20-23.ESV>

"When Daniel knew that the document had been signed, he went to his house where he had windows in his upper chamber open toward Jerusalem. He got down on his knees three times a day and prayed and gave thanks before his God, as he had done previously. Then these men came by agreement and found Daniel making petition and plea before his God."

Daniel 6:10-11 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/dan.6.10-11.ESV>

'In the first year of Darius the son of Ahasuerus, by descent a Mede, who was made king over the realm of the Chaldeans—in the first year of his reign, I, Daniel, perceived in the books the number of years that, according to the word of the Lord to Jeremiah the prophet, must pass before the end of the desolations of Jerusalem, namely, seventy years. Then I turned my face to the Lord God, seeking him by prayer and pleas for mercy with fasting and sackcloth and ashes. I prayed to the Lord my God and made confession, saying, "O Lord, the great and awesome God, who keeps covenant and steadfast love with those who love him and keep his commandments, we have sinned and done wrong and acted wickedly and rebelled, turning aside from your commandments and rules. We have not listened to your servants the prophets, who spoke in your name to our kings, our princes, and our fathers, and to all the people of the land. To you, O Lord, belongs righteousness, but to us open shame, as at this day, to the men of Judah, to the inhabitants of Jerusalem, and to all Israel, those who are near and those who are far away, in all the lands to which you have driven them, because of the treachery

that they have committed against you. To us, O Lord, belongs open shame, to our kings, to our princes, and to our fathers, because we have sinned against you. To the Lord our God belong mercy and forgiveness, for we have rebelled against him and have not obeyed the voice of the Lord our God by walking in his laws, which he set before us by his servants the prophets. All Israel has transgressed your law and turned aside, refusing to obey your voice. And the curse and oath that are written in the Law of Moses the servant of God have been poured out upon us, because we have sinned against him. He has confirmed his words, which he spoke against us and against our rulers who ruled us, by bringing upon us a great calamity. For under the whole heaven there has not been done anything like what has been done against Jerusalem. As it is written in the Law of Moses, all this calamity has come upon us; yet we have not entreated the favor of the Lord our God, turning from our iniquities and gaining insight by your truth. Therefore the Lord has kept ready the calamity and has brought it upon us, for the Lord our God is righteous in all the works that he has done, and we have not obeyed his voice. And now, O Lord our God, who brought your people out of the land of Egypt with a mighty hand, and have made a name for yourself, as at this day, we have sinned, we have done wickedly. "O Lord, according to all your righteous acts, let your anger and your wrath turn away from your city Jerusalem, your holy hill, because for our sins, and for the iniquities of our fathers, Jerusalem and your people have become a byword among all who are around us. Now therefore, O our God, listen to the prayer of your servant and to his pleas for mercy, and for your own sake, O Lord, make your face to shine upon your sanctuary, which is desolate. O my God, incline your ear and hear. Open your eyes and see our desolations, and the city that is called by your name. For we do not present our pleas before you because of our righteousness, but because of your great mercy. O Lord, hear; O Lord, forgive. O Lord, pay attention and act. Delay not, for your own sake, O my God, because your city and your people are called by your name."

Daniel 9:1-19 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/dan.9.1-19.ESV>

Daniel is a member of the cloud of witnesses of faith in God (Hebrews 12:1), a prophet (Hebrews 11:32). He is one who came boldly (*parrhēsia*, G3954) to the throne (*thronos*, G2362) of grace (*charis*, G5485), that he might receive mercy (*eleos*,

G1656) and find grace from God to help in time of need (Hebrews 4:16). The church can learn from the way he prayed.

“...Blessed be the name of God forever and ever, to whom belong wisdom and might...”

In the first listed prayer, Daniel responded when God revealed Nebuchadnezzar's dream to him, starting by blessing (praising, berak, G1289) God. God is the source of the wisdom of the ages, and He gives wisdom and knowledge to whom He pleases. He is the Almighty God. He is sovereign over all of the rulers on the earth. Next, Daniel thanked God for the wisdom that God had given to him. He also thanked God for making him strong, for his remarkable strength came from God, although he ate only vegetables (Daniel 1:15). Lastly, he thanked God for answering his prayers regarding the revealing of the king's dream that led to the salvation of the wise men of Judah in Babylon, himself included. When his life depended on it, Daniel trusted God and expected Him to answer his prayer. Such expectation that God will act according to His Word, His benevolent nature, and His good will (eudokia, G2107) is perhaps the highest form of faith (Matthew 6:10, Mark 11:22-24, John 14:13-14, Luke 11:2, Romans 12:2, Philippians 2:13, 2 Thessalonians 2:11).

“... he went to his house where he had windows in his upper chamber open toward Jerusalem. He got down on his knees...”

In the second selected passage, we learn that Daniel prayed three times a day and he prayed out loud. He gave thanks and he made petitions to God in his prayers. He was not dissuaded when his prayers were made illegal by men trying to undermine him. Having the faith of God, which was given to him by God (1 Corinthians 12:9), Daniel was confident in the protection God provided for him as a servant ('ebed, H5650) of God, even as his ancestor King David wrote about in Psalm 34:

“The angel of the Lord encamps around those who fear him, and delivers them. Oh, taste and see that the Lord is good! Blessed is the man who takes refuge in him! ...Many are the afflictions of the righteous, but the Lord delivers him out of them all. He keeps all his bones; not one of them is broken. Affliction will slay the wicked, and those who hate the righteous will be condemned. The Lord redeems the life of his servants; none of those who take refuge in him will be condemned.”
Psalm 34:7-8, 19-22 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/psa.34.7-22.ESV>

Daniel spoke of God's protection for him when he was thrown to the lions for praying to God: "My God sent his angel and shut the lions' mouths, and they have not harmed me, because I was found blameless before him; and also before you, O king, I have done no harm." Then the king was exceedingly glad, and commanded that Daniel be taken up out of the den. So Daniel was taken up out of the den, and no kind of harm was found on him, because he had trusted in his God. And the king commanded, and those men who had maliciously accused Daniel were brought and cast into the den of lions... And before they reached the bottom of the den, the lions overpowered them and broke all their bones in pieces.'

Daniel 6:22-24 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/dan.6.22-24.ESV>

God protected the life of His servant, who trusted (châsâh, H2620, 'aman, H540) in Him, keeping (shâmar, H8104) and delivering (nâtsal, H5337, pādâh, H6299) Daniel by way of surrounding angels. The wicked were slayed instead. God's Word is true.

"...I, Daniel, perceived in the books the number of years that, according to the word of the Lord to Jeremiah the prophet, must pass before the end of the desolations of Jerusalem, namely, seventy years. Then I turned my face to the Lord God..."

In the passage from Daniel 9, Daniel, believing God's good word through Jeremiah that Judah would be restored after 70 years (Jeremiah 29:10), prayed at the proper time according to the will of God for that promised restoration, fulfilling what God had spoken: "Then you will call upon me and come and pray to me, and I will hear you. You will seek me and find me, when you seek me with all your heart."

Jeremiah 29:12-13 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/jer.29.12-13.ESV>

Daniel poured out his heart (lêbâb, H3824) in prayer to the living God, starting with adoration of who God is: *"O Lord, the great and awesome God, who keeps covenant and steadfast love with those who love him and keep his commandments" ... "To you, O Lord, belongs righteousness" ... "To the Lord our God belong mercy and forgiveness"*

Daniel worshiped God in truth as the covenant-keeping (berîyth, H1285) God who shows steadfast love (chêsêd, H2617) to those who faithfully love Him.

Next, Daniel took responsibility for his people, confessing both for himself and on their behalf: *"...we have sinned and done wrong and acted wickedly and rebelled, turning aside from your commandments and rules..."* Daniel was a youth at the beginning of the exile (Daniel 1:3), but he took responsibility for his people's actions anyway. He fasted, focusing on God, putting on sackcloth and ashes in mourning. Daniel saw the judgment that came upon Judah as part of the righteousness of God, who was just doing what He had said He would do: *"...And the curse and oath that are written in the Law of Moses the servant of God have been poured out upon us, because we have sinned against him. He has confirmed his words, which he spoke against us and against our rulers who ruled us, by bringing upon us a great calamity..."*

Daniel referred here to the curses (qelâlâh, H7045) described in Deuteronomy 28:15ff.

Finally, Daniel made supplication to God on behalf of his people, whom he loved, appealing for forgiveness and restoration because of God's great mercy: *"...for your own sake, O Lord, make your face to shine upon your sanctuary, which is desolate. O my God, incline your ear and hear. Open your eyes and see our desolations, and the city that is called by your name. For we do not present our pleas before you because of our righteousness, but because of your great mercy. O Lord, hear; O Lord, forgive. O Lord, pay attention and act. Delay not, for your own sake, O my God, because your city and your people are called by your name."*

Daniel's prayers reflect the instructions of Jesus for prayer (Matthew 6:9-13). As Jesus did, Daniel prayed regularly. His prayers included adoration for God, confession of sin, thanksgiving to God, and supplication (ACTS). As Jesus did, Daniel prayed for God's will (thelēma, G2307) to be done (ginomai, G1096), desiring God's glory (doxa, G1391). Furthermore, Daniel's maturity was shown in taking responsibility not just for himself but also for the people around him — his people. Daniel didn't pray for what he wanted for himself but instead clearly for what God wanted for His precious people. Jesus' apostles have also been led by God's Spirit

to take such responsibility for God's precious people (e.g., Acts 20:28, 1 Peter 5:2). God's people need a love that will take on their brothers' and sisters' need and pain as if it were their own: "Remember those who are in prison, as though in prison with them, and those who are mistreated, since you also are in the body."

Hebrews 13:3 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/heb.13.3.ESV>

Day 40: Visions of life from God to Ezekiel

Here is the first of three readings from the prophet Ezekiel:

“Again the word of the Lord came to me: “Son of man, make known to Jerusalem her abominations, and say, Thus says the Lord God to Jerusalem: Your origin and your birth are of the land of the Canaanites; your father was an Amorite and your mother a Hittite. And as for your birth, on the day you were born your cord was not cut, nor were you washed with water to cleanse you, nor rubbed with salt, nor wrapped in swaddling cloths. No eye pitied you, to do any of these things to you out of compassion for you, but you were cast out on the open field, for you were abhorred, on the day that you were born. And when I passed by you and saw you wallowing in your blood, I said to you in your blood, ‘Live!’ I said to you in your blood, ‘Live!’ I made you flourish like a plant of the field. And you grew up and became tall and arrived at full adornment. Your breasts were formed, and your hair had grown; yet you were naked and bare. When I passed by you again and saw you, behold, you were at the age for love, and I spread the corner of my garment over you and covered your nakedness; I made my vow to you and entered into a covenant with you, declares the Lord God, and you became mine. Then I bathed you with water and washed off your blood from you and anointed you with oil. I clothed you also with embroidered cloth and shod you with fine leather. I wrapped you in fine linen and covered you with silk. And I adorned you with ornaments and put bracelets on your wrists and a chain on your neck. And I put a ring on your nose and earrings in your ears and a beautiful crown on your head. Thus you were adorned with gold and silver, and your clothing was of fine linen and silk and embroidered cloth. You ate fine flour and honey and oil. You grew exceedingly beautiful and advanced to royalty. And your renown went forth among the nations because of your beauty, for it was perfect through the splendor that I had bestowed on you, declares the Lord God... For thus says the Lord God: I will deal with you as you have done, you who have despised the oath in breaking the covenant, yet I will remember my covenant with you in the days of your youth, and I will establish for you an everlasting covenant. Then you will remember your ways and be ashamed when you take your sisters, both your elder and your younger, and I give them to you as daughters, but not on account of the covenant with you. I will establish my covenant with you, and you shall know that I am the Lord, that you may remember and be confounded, and never open your

mouth again because of your shame, when I atone for you for all that you have done, declares the Lord God.”

Ezekiel 16:1-14, 59-63 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/ezk.16.1-63.ESV>

Israel was made into a people of God via Abram, who was renamed Abraham, a father of many. He was chosen by God on account of His faith (see Day 3). This people lived and worshiped among the Canaanites, Amorites and Hittites. Israel went through cycles of disobedience where they forgot about God and worshiped idols. Yet, in response to faith, God chose to take a people that had no worth and speak life to them by way of His Word: “Live!” (châyâh, H2421) Just as God spoke the beginning of time and all of creation into being, with words as His servants, the covenant-keeping God brought life to (châyâh, H2421) God’s church through the nation of Israel, causing it to flourish and making it imperishable when God *Himself* atoned for (kâphar, H3722) what they had done through the blood and the body of Jesus Christ. God took one man of faith, Abraham, and created from him a redeemed people for Himself that has become the church, His treasured possession (segûllâh, H5459, Exodus 19:5), His glory, His bride. He has made His people into royalty (melûkah, H4410), sons and daughters of God. The church has become partakers (koinōnos, G2844) of the divine nature (2 Peter 1:4), made at-one with God according to His original purpose and love plan. As the Apostle Peter preached, God calls all people to “...Repent and be baptized every one of you in the name of Jesus Christ for the forgiveness of your sins, and you will receive the gift of the Holy Spirit. For the promise is for you and for your children and for all who are far off, everyone whom the Lord our God calls to himself.”

Acts 2:38-39 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/act.2.38-39.ESV>

Here is the second of three readings from the prophet Ezekiel:

‘The hand of the Lord was upon me, and he brought me out in the Spirit of the Lord and set me down in the middle of the valley; it was full of bones. And he led me around among them, and behold, there were very many on the surface of the valley, and behold, they were very dry. And he said to me, “Son of man, can these bones live?” And I answered, “O Lord God, you know.” Then he said to me, “Prophecy over these bones, and say to them, O dry bones, hear the word of the

Lord. Thus says the Lord God to these bones: Behold, I will cause breath to enter you, and you shall live. And I will lay sinews upon you, and will cause flesh to come upon you, and cover you with skin, and put breath in you, and you shall live, and you shall know that I am the Lord." So I prophesied as I was commanded. And as I prophesied, there was a sound, and behold, a rattling, and the bones came together, bone to its bone. And I looked, and behold, there were sinews on them, and flesh had come upon them, and skin had covered them. But there was no breath in them. Then he said to me, "Prophecy to the breath; prophecy, son of man, and say to the breath, Thus says the Lord God: Come from the four winds, O breath, and breathe on these slain, that they may live." So I prophesied as he commanded me, and the breath came into them, and they lived and stood on their feet, an exceedingly great army. Then he said to me, "Son of man, these bones are the whole house of Israel. Behold, they say, 'Our bones are dried up, and our hope is lost; we are indeed cut off.' Therefore prophecy, and say to them, Thus says the Lord God: Behold, I will open your graves and raise you from your graves, O my people. And I will bring you into the land of Israel. And you shall know that I am the Lord, when I open your graves, and raise you from your graves, O my people. And I will put my Spirit within you, and you shall live, and I will place you in your own land. Then you shall know that I am the Lord; I have spoken, and I will do it,' declares the Lord. ...then say to them, "Thus says the Lord God: Behold, I will take the people of Israel from the nations among which they have gone, and will gather them from all around, and bring them to their own land. And I will make them one nation in the land, on the mountains of Israel. And one king shall be king over them all, and they shall be no longer two nations, and no longer divided into two kingdoms. They shall not defile themselves anymore with their idols and their detestable things, or with any of their transgressions. But I will save them from all the backslidings in which they have sinned, and will cleanse them; and they shall be my people, and I will be their God. My servant David shall be king over them, and they shall all have one shepherd. They shall walk in my rules and be careful to obey my statutes. They shall dwell in the land that I gave to my servant Jacob, where your fathers lived. They and their children and their children's children shall dwell there forever, and David my servant shall be their prince forever. I will make a covenant of peace with them. It shall be an everlasting covenant with them. And I will set them in their land and multiply them, and will set my sanctuary in their midst forevermore. My dwelling place shall be with them,

and I will be their God, and they shall be my people. Then the nations will know that I am the Lord who sanctifies Israel, when my sanctuary is in their midst forevermore.”

Ezekiel 37:1-14, 21-28 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/ezk.37.1-28.ESV>

In Ezekiel's vision, God commanded him to prophecy (nâbâ', H5012) over a valley of dead, dry bones, telling them to hear (shâma', H8085) the word (dâbâr, H1697) of the Lord. Ezekiel obeyed what God told him to do to make the bones come to life (châyâh, H2421), telling them “I will put breath in you, and you shall live.” Ezekiel watched God's words come to pass after He spoke them as God's ambassador (presbeuō, G4243, 2 Corinthians 5:20).

God revealed to Ezekiel what will happen in Jesus' second coming when He will reign over Israel in the millennium, forgiveness will be offered to Israel, and the bodies of God's people will be resurrected. God's people will be shepherded (râ'âh, H7462) by the Good Shepherd and be led to victory (nikaō, G3528) by the King of kings, Jesus Christ, and then they will inherit (klêronomeō, G2816) all of the good (ploutos, G4149, Ephesians 2:7) that God has created for them in the new heaven and the new earth (Revelation 21:1-7).

The Spirit (rûach, H7307) of God is life (zōē, G2222), and His words are life-giving (châyâh, H2421). Jesus Christ spoke words that the Father gave Him to speak (John 12:49-50). He taught His disciples to minister in his place as He did: “And as ye go, preach, saying, The kingdom of heaven is at hand. Heal the sick, cleanse the lepers, raise the dead, cast out devils: freely ye have received, freely give.”

Matthew 10:7-8 KJV

<https://bible.com/bible/1/mat.10.7-8.KJV>

They were to openly speak truth (kêrussō, G2784) and to freely (dōrean, G1432) give (didōmi, G1325), just as He had. Jesus told His disciples that when they were obedient to go as His ambassadors, they spoke His words as though they were Him:

“The one who hears you hears me, and the one who rejects you rejects me, and the one who rejects me rejects him who sent me.”

Luke 10:16 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/luk.10.16.ESV>

The same Spirit that God showed Ezekiel brought Jesus Christ back to life, and that same spirit indwells (enoikeō, G1774) and gives life to (zōopoieo, G2227) the bride of Christ: "But if the Spirit of him that raised up Jesus from the dead dwell in you, he that raised up Christ from the dead shall also quicken your mortal bodies by his Spirit that dwelleth in you."

Romans 8:11 KJV

<https://bible.com/bible/1/rom.8.11.KJV>

Here is the last reading from the prophet Ezekiel:

'Then he brought me back to the door of the temple, and behold, water was issuing from below the threshold of the temple toward the east (for the temple faced east). The water was flowing down from below the south end of the threshold of the temple, south of the altar. Then he brought me out by way of the north gate and led me around on the outside to the outer gate that faces toward the east; and behold, the water was trickling out on the south side. Going on eastward with a measuring line in his hand, the man measured a thousand cubits, and then led me through the water, and it was ankle-deep. Again he measured a thousand, and led me through the water, and it was knee-deep. Again he measured a thousand, and led me through the water, and it was waist-deep. Again he measured a thousand, and it was a river that I could not pass through, for the water had risen. It was deep enough to swim in, a river that could not be passed through. And he said to me, "Son of man, have you seen this?" Then he led me back to the bank of the river. As I went back, I saw on the bank of the river very many trees on the one side and on the other. And he said to me, "This water flows toward the eastern region and goes down into the Arabah, and enters the sea; when the water flows into the sea, the water will become fresh. And wherever the river goes, every living creature that swarms will live, and there will be very many fish. For this water goes there, that the waters of the sea may become fresh; so everything will live where the river goes. Fishermen will stand beside the sea. From Engedi to Eneglaim it will be a place for the spreading of nets. Its fish will be of very many kinds, like the fish of the Great Sea. But its swamps and marshes will not become fresh; they are to be left for salt. And on the banks, on both sides of the river, there will grow all kinds of trees for food. Their leaves will not wither, nor

their fruit fail, but they will bear fresh fruit every month, because the water for them flows from the sanctuary. Their fruit will be for food, and their leaves for healing.”

Ezekiel 47:1-12 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/ezk.47.1-12.ESV>

Starting in Ezekiel chapter 40, Ezekiel described the temple of God shown to Him by God's Spirit in a vision. Flowing through the temple was water that became the source of a river swarming with life (chay, H2416). Fish were plentiful. On each side of the banks were all kinds of trees for food. The water itself conferred life (châyâh, H2421) and brought healing (râphâ', H7495). The leaves of the trees never withered, and they were the source for healing (terûphâh, H8644). The trees bore fresh fruit every month.

The Apostle John had a similar vision of the New Jerusalem in the new heaven and earth prepared for the church: “Then the angel showed me the river of the water of life, bright as crystal, flowing from the throne of God and of the Lamb through the middle of the street of the city; also, on either side of the river, the tree of life with its twelve kinds of fruit, yielding its fruit each month. The leaves of the tree were for the healing of the nations.”

Revelation 22:1-2 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/rev.22.1-2.ESV>

This river also coming from the temple of God contained the water of life (zōē, G2222). On either side of the river was the tree of life, also yielding fruit each month. It yielded twelve kinds of fruit. The leaves of the tree were also for healing (therapeia, G2322) — healing of the nations.

God's will is to redeem and to save, giving life to the spirits, souls and bodies of His people, making His church at-one with Him through the finished work of the atonement of Christ.

As His love plan has unfolded, God, first present in person, gave life to mankind in the garden (Genesis 3:8). Next, present through the tabernacle (Leviticus 26:12) and His prophets, He made a way to be quickened through the law and through faith.

Next, God gave life through Jesus Christ, Immanuel (‘immânû’êl, H6005; emmanouêl, G1694), God with us (Isaiah 7:14, Matthew 1:23).

Now God quickens through the indwelling (enoikeō, G1774) Holy Spirit, who walks in (emperipateō, G1704) Christ's new body in the world (2 Corinthians 6:16).

In the future, the church will be forever alive, finally with Christ and with God the Father in person, experiencing the immeasurable (huperballō, G5235) riches (ploutos, G4149) of His grace (charis, G5485) in kindness (chrēstotēs, G5544) toward us in Christ Jesus (Ephesians 2:7). This is the hope (elpis, G1680, 1 Corinthians 13:13) of the church (ekklēsia, G1577).

Conclusion

To the Giver, the following prayer is lifted up for the readers and for God's beloved church: "Quicken thou me according unto thy word... strengthen thou me according unto thy word... quicken thou me in thy way... quicken me in thy righteousness ... thy word hath quickened me... quicken me after thy lovingkindness... quicken me, O Lord, after thy lovingkindness" (Psalm 119:25,28,37,40,50,88 KJV)

God is the giver and sustainer of life. He is not a respecter of persons (prosōpolēptēs, G4381, Acts 10:34). Instead, God is pleased by faith in Him and His Word and wholehearted love (agapē, G26) for Him and the people He has created. His benevolence is infinite and His will is to do good, consistent with His character of steadfast love (chêsêd, H2617) and mercy (rachûm, H7349, Exodus 34:6-7). God made men and women to be very much like Him and to be close to Him, which brings Him glory.

In the last chapter of the Old Testament, Malachi prophesied about how the Messiah will bless those who come to love God:

"But for you who fear my name, the sun of righteousness shall rise with healing in its wings. You shall go out leaping like calves from the stall."

Malachi 4:2 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/mol.4.2.ESV>

The first image from this verse is that of sunrise (shemesh, H8121) and light ('ôr, H216; phōs, G5457), the same which Isaiah had seen regarding the time of Christ's ministry:

"The people who walked in darkness have seen a great light; those who dwelt in a land of deep darkness, on them has light shone."

Isaiah 9:2 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/iso.9.2.ESV>

Jesus said of Himself, "...I am the light of the world. Whoever follows me will not walk in darkness, but will have the light of life."

John 8:12 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/jhn.8.12.ESV>

Jesus came to bring life (zōē, G2222) and light (phōs, G5457) to be a benighted world as the Word of God in a way the author of Psalm 119 could have not known.

Jesus is the Sun (shemesh, H8121) of righteousness (tsedâqâh, H6666). He was the Teacher the world had never seen and has never since seen. He is the perfect reflection of the image (eikōn, G1504) of God, and in Him all the fullness (plērōma, G4138) of God was pleased to dwell (katoikeō, G2730, Colossians 1:15-19). He brought a fresh revelation of God's will, purposes, and character, including that of tender love. During His ministry, He displayed the righteousness of God in the flesh. He made a way for any to become right with God through his life, death and resurrection; He showed the example for right living; and He brought near the kingdom of God as He started off the ministry of the church, bringing victory over sin, sickness, and the dominion of Satan. He made a path for anyone to be made righteous through faith, opening up the channel of God for abundant blessing, both through the earnest of the Holy Spirit and the inheritance of heaven.

The Sun of righteousness has risen with healing (marpē', H4832) in His wings. This refers back to the complete salvation (sōzō, G4982, John 3:17) that Jesus brought in His fulfillment of Isaiah 53 (see Day 32), first exalted on the cross, and now glorified in heaven, seated at the right hand of the Father with all authority in heaven, on earth, and under the earth (Matthew 28:18, Philippians 2:9-10). Jesus certainly brought physical healing as He brought the kingdom of God near; He healed all that came to Him during the time of His ministry. He also taught His disciples to heal as a sign of the salvation that He has brought. The healing in His wings though refers to the complete healing brought through redemption. This redemption is for those with faith in God and reverence toward Him — for those who fear His name. It is for those that have entered into intimate union and communion with Him through the choice of their will to trust Him, putting themselves under His wings. Even as Moses did (see Day 10) and as David did (e.g., see Psalm 31), they have made the Most High their shelter, their refuge, and their fortress.

The last image in the passage from Malachi is that of springtime: "You shall go out leaping like calves from the stall." This refers to the freedom and joy that God brings to those who consecrate themselves to Him because He has made them

new creations, fully alive with Him evermore. This rejoicing is not in the gifts of God; instead, in God Himself, they find boundless and everlasting delight.

My story in view of their stories

As humans, we love stories. We can't get enough of them: stories of good vs. evil; stories of heroes with supernatural abilities; stories about saving the world or righting a wrong; stories about love.

I'm no exception. I love a good comedy and at other times an action flick. I also find myself drawn to certain police dramas.

My favorite genre to read is biography. In recent years, I've been reading biographies of saints (not meant strictly in the Catholic sense) from the past few hundred years and taking another look at the lives of people in the Scriptures. I've also read many books authored by some of these saints.

I love to learn from people's experiences and live their adventures, and I've had some more time to do that during the pandemic while at home base. I've found that the stories of their lives have a lot to teach me. I also learn from their experiences with God. Preferring to lift up Jesus though rather than stir up any division about holding up particular saints, none of whom lived perfect lives, I stick to Jesus and the Bible.

The Old Testament presents a true account, inspired by the Spirit of God, of many a cast of characters created by God. Some are shining examples of faith. All of these humans show strengths and weaknesses, many changing over the course of their lives in relationship to God.

After describing many examples of faith written about in the Old Testament in Hebrews 11, the author (probably the Apostle Paul) writes that "we are surrounded by a great cloud of witnesses", so "let us run with endurance the race that is set before us..." (Hebrews 12:1).

Out of all of those witnesses from the Old Testament times, I identify most with Joshua in the time before he was tapped for leadership. As one way of telling my story in a way relevant to this book, I'd like to step through all those with which I feel some commonality.

I identify with Adam in his delight in his wife (Genesis 2:23), a precious gift from God; in his desire to know and to understand (Genesis 3:5); and in his doubt that God had the best in mind for him. I'm quite sure I also would have been deceived as he was. As an Enneagram 5 (The Investigator), I am curious, aiming to try to understand everything.

I identify with Abraham in that I have come to have faith in God and what He has said, and I have put my hope in the promise of God to Abraham that is for myself (as a part of "all the nations") and the rest of God's church (Genesis 22:18). I'm not sure, however, if I were in Abraham's place, if I would have followed God to the sacrifice of my own child. I identify with Abraham in that he was not perfect in his faith in God, for he also on occasion feared man (when he pretended Sarai wasn't his wife for his own protection, Genesis 20) and doubted God (when he had waited too long for his promised child through Sarai, so he took matters into his own hands and had a child with Hagar, Genesis 16). If I'm being honest, for much of my life I've feared what people thought of me, feared failure, feared speaking up about what I think. I've also doubted whether or not it was God's will to do good to me, my family, and sometimes others, thinking to myself or sometimes saying, "if it be your will." This has caused me at times to seek my own good apart from God.

My faith has changed over time. I've been a Christian now for over 30 years, and, thankfully, God hasn't left me where I started as a teenager in middle school when I first made a commitment to Him. I accepted Jesus as my Savior and Lord because I was so deeply impressed about the way God could change people through personal relationships with Him. I was most impressed by the testimony of a man named [Brett Roy](#). I also experienced Jesus through the witness of a middle school youth group. There are many I would profusely thank for investing in me in those formative, emotional days; the first would be a man named Mike Bonser. Thanks, Mikel

It was only months after my "coming to Jesus" when I met my best friend who became my wife. Within 7 years of meeting this ambassador of femininity, I was married. She initially thought I was a selfish jerk, and rightfully so, but thankfully God didn't keep me there. God has used her love, selflessness, friendship, and

patience, as well as the fatherhood of two beautiful girls, my 3rd and 4th loves, to mold me some. God's designs for marriage and family are very good. My 3rd love came to us while I was a military officer, a wonderful show of the grace of God (channâh, H2584, chânan, H2603). My last little love was given to us miraculously healthy, an answer to prayer ('êl 'ânâh, H410+H6030), while I was in graduate school getting my PhD in engineering. They are grown now. They are beautiful. I love them and am so proud of them.

As a man married now for about 23 years, I identify with Joseph who had to run away from sin in the face of Potiphar's wife (Genesis 39:12), desiring to be faithful to God. While I have always been faithful to my wife, I haven't always had the resolve and strength to run away from sin as Joseph did. I do now because of Christ who lives in me and strengthens me. Joseph also had a weakness in taking pride in the favor he received as a youth. I identify with this weakness based on attitudes I have taken, when really every good gift or any esteemed position is from God and any success is enabled by Him.

I identify with Moses when he was at the burning bush in that I care for God's people and I want right to be done — the kind of right that only God can bring about. (I know I'm not alone because this feeling of wanting wrongs made right is universal, embedded within us by God.) Additionally, I have come to believe in God's ability to do anything, but I have doubted myself and my natural abilities to lead spiritually, even as Moses did: "Then Moses answered, "But behold, they will not believe me or listen to my voice, for they will say, 'The Lord did not appear to you.'" ...But Moses said to the Lord, "Oh, my Lord, I am not eloquent, either in the past or since you have spoken to your servant, but I am slow of speech and of tongue." ...But he said, "Oh, my Lord, please send someone else.'""

Exodus 4:1, 10, 13 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/exo.4.1-13.ESV>

I identify with these feelings of inadequacy that caused Moses to refuse God. These feelings of mine were most prominent around the age of 18-20, before I joined the military and became a father. Rather than seeing those God has always used who begin as common, weak vessels, I looked at the way our culture appreciates the speaking abilities and charisma of the leaders of today, including leaders within the church. Even over the last few decades, when I'm not

the responsible person, I often tend not to speak up about what I think, keeping it instead to myself, letting others talk. Rather than giving off the impression that I'm a caring, approachable person, this often leaves people thinking I'm hard to read, uncaring, or difficult to approach. My recent bout of writing made publically available is one way to push back against my natural inclinations.

Out of all of the men in the Old Testament, I identify most with Joshua when he was simply Moses' assistant in the desert. He had witnessed the signs and wonders of God in Egypt and at the crossing of the Red Sea, delivered along with the rest of the nation of Israel. After crossing the Red Sea, he was a young man, but he was old enough to fight against Amalek, following Moses' command at God's leading to come out victorious. Joshua ascended Mt. Sinai with Moses the first time he went up to commune with God and receive the Ten Commandments. He was the keeper of the tent of meeting, where Moses would meet with God face-to-face. He was sent out as one of the spies to investigate the promised land, and he was one of only two that gave a good report. Then he spent time in the desert for 40 years, waiting for God's timing to move onto what God had next for him. During the time of his leadership, he was mostly faithful to God, but not perfectly, as on one recorded occasion he disobeyed God's command (Exodus 34:12, Joshua 9:15), which brought trouble on his people. After he had obtained what God had promised, he resolved that he and his family would be faithful to serve the Lord (Joshua 24:15).

Like Joshua, I am resolved to follow God with my family. My family is very important to me, and my wife shares my resolve. I've tried to be careful to set a good example and to not say things that would drive my children away from faith in God; perhaps I've been too careful in what I've chosen to say or not say. Like Joshua, I've not been perfectly faithful to God. I'm one whose faith in God is being built up as I've served in small ways, so far comfortably out of any prominent spotlight. I am learning not to doubt God, to throw away unbelief and fear, and to stand firm. I am learning to love and to give. God has been made real to me out of my own experiences, including the ways He has changed me from the lost, self-centered person I was 30 years ago. Even more so though, I have been impacted by what I've witnessed Him do and what I've learned that He has done in and through the lives of others that have surrendered themselves to Him. I have

learned that the living Jesus has not changed from the person He shows God to be in the Scriptures, and He is always victorious. I take my strength, courage, life, and love from Him, and while following, serving, and being faithful in small ways, I am waiting on God for what He has next. I am believing the best about Him, His good intent, and what He is about to do through His church. I seek His fullness, and I want to be more a part of His ongoing love story of expanding His church in the world He has created around me.

I identify somewhat with David in my love for the Lord, although I covet the passion and the complete abandon in his love. Compared with David, I am much more even tempered. I also identify with David in my growing love for and trust in His Word. David has helped me to understand the unbelievably good will of God for His children. I am also encouraged how someone who fell so drastically in sin (2 Samuel 11, 1 Chronicles 21) could return to God and be so loved and favored by Him.

Of late, I identify more with Jeremiah, feeling like God's Word is a fire inside my bones, wanting to be let out (Jeremiah 20:9). Unlike Jeremiah, I don't think it's God's judgment He wants me to speak, but instead to speak the truth in love (Ephesians 4:15) in order to lift up Jesus Christ and build up His beloved church. Jesus Christ, the Word of God, is the most fascinating person that ever lived, and He still lives. Jesus lives enthroned at the right hand of God and in the lives of those who comprise His body (1 Corinthians 12:27), each of them a pillar of the temple of God (Revelation 3:12). He also lives in me and walks in me. He is the fullness of life, righteousness, and love. Everything else that used to be more exciting outside of Jesus and His church has become less so. Jesus has brought the kingdom of God upon us. Praise be to God.

I identify with Elisha in his desire to ask for a double portion of God's Spirit. I am convinced that abundant life is found in intimacy with God, living as a servant of man according to God's purposes. God waters us as we water others (Proverbs 11:25); I have experienced this. At times in my life when I have stopped the flow of life out, the waters have started to become scummy, and God's life stopped flowing in.

I identify with Daniel in that he lived seeking the welfare of the city (Jeremiah 29:7) that was not his home, praying to the Lord on its behalf. He was well educated, as am I. As one made alive in Christ (Galatians 2:20), my home is with God (2 Corinthians 5:1-5). In seeking the welfare of the city I have lived in now for 14 years, I am devoted both to higher education through my day job and to building up the church within the corrections system as a volunteer activity.

Thirty years into my journey with God, I find myself thankful that He has killed a lot of the selfishness that was in me and brought me to a place of hungering and thirsting after His righteousness, of seeking the kingdom of God, and waiting on Him. God has moved me from hearing and learning about God and His word, to knowing and loving more of God Himself, to actually believing His written word and doing it (James 1:22). I am very excited to follow God into the future of the story He has prepared to unfold. I look forward to experiencing more of His goodness and fullness, and the relationships with those He has created.

Here is the beauty of the true story of God that all are able to join: "But God, being rich in mercy, because of the great love with which he loved us, even when we were dead in our trespasses, made us alive together with Christ—by grace you have been saved—and raised us up with him and seated us with him in the heavenly places in Christ Jesus, so that in the coming ages he might show the immeasurable riches of his grace in kindness toward us in Christ Jesus. For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, not a result of works, so that no one may boast. For we are his workmanship, created in Christ Jesus for good works, which God prepared beforehand, that we should walk in them."

Ephesians 2:4-10 ESV

<https://bible.com/bible/59/eph.2.4-10.ESV>

It's a true story of good defeating evil! Within it are stories of common men and women who have been loved and used by God, a cloud of witnesses. (The men and women in God's story have been uncommon though in that they were made righteous through faith in God, identified with God's own image and likeness, and the Spirit of God was with them to bring about the supernatural.) It's a story of prophecies that came true and some that have yet to come true when Jesus

Christ comes again. It's a true story about God saving the world and making wrong things right! It's a true story about the greatest love ever known.